

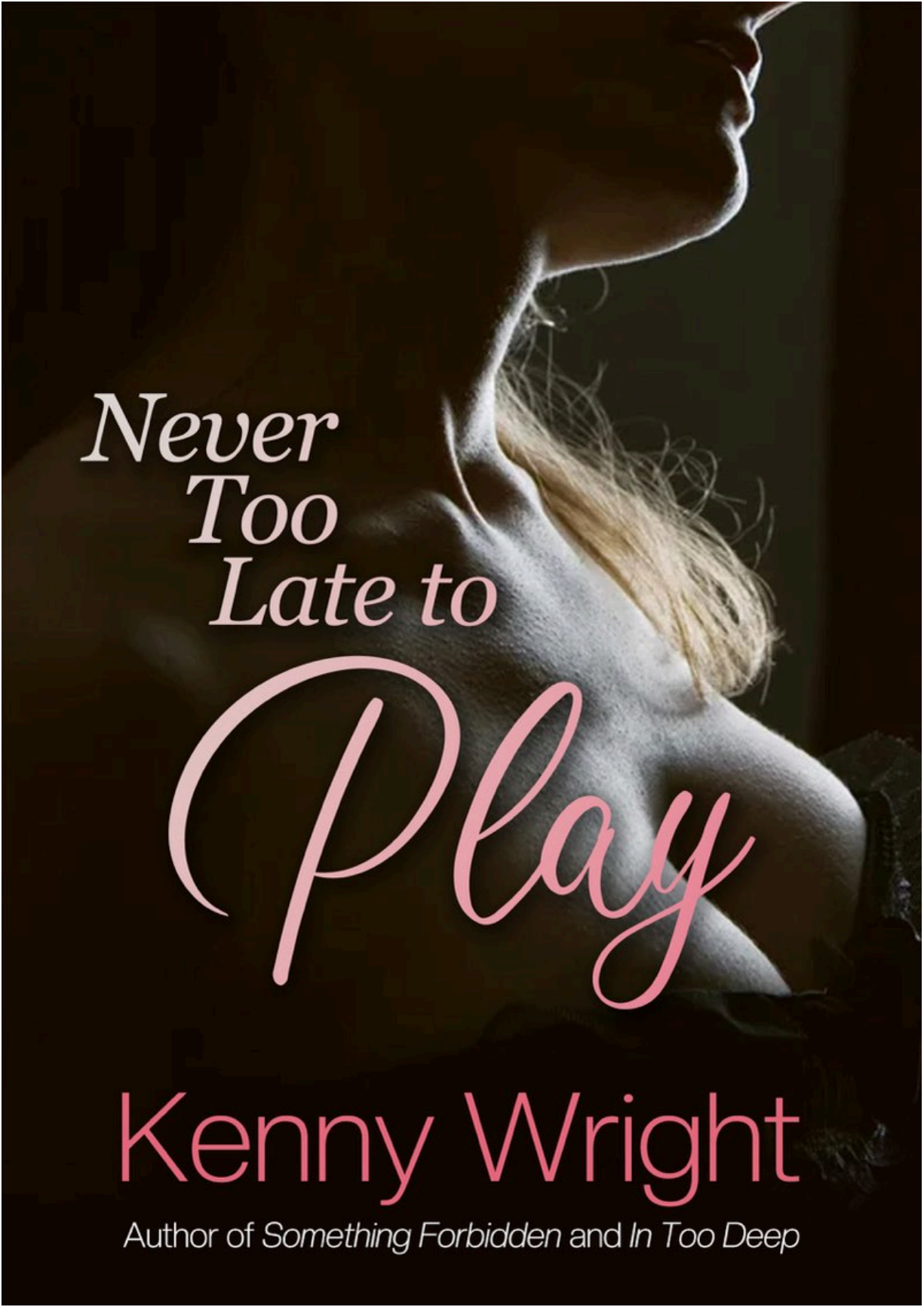


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Late to*

Play

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PREFACE

Never Too Late to Play is a series that was inspired by all the couples who decide to embark on their hotwife journey later in life. More often than not, the books that we read feature women in their twenties and thirties (and there's nothing wrong with that, I happen to have contributed man of these books!). But these fantasies, just like our desires, don't just go away after 50, and in a way, it's the ideal time to explore this kink.

I get a lot of correspondence with fans floating all kinds of ideas. I love these kinds of emails because, inevitably, it shakes something loose in my imagination. That's what happened here with a man was experiencing something akin to Julianna and Stephen. He has a beautiful, hot, sexy wife who also happens to be on the other side of fifty, who'd never entertained being a hotwife, and yet now they're in the lifestyle. How amazing is that? Gives all of us hope.

That said, this book is not a biography of that couple, and the events of these stories didn't actually happen to them. This is my take on the theme of "never too late" (and maybe the wife is largely inspired by his).

As you'll read, this story is written in three shorter parts, or vignettes. They're designed to be stand alone novellas, but together tell a complete story of how they got from point A to point B. If you like what you read,

please send me a note or write a review. There are so many more adventures to explore for them, and as always, I'm open to feedback and direction.

Oh, and if you *really* want to give feedback, join my Patreon. This was first published there, and the patrons helped shape the second and third parts of the book. It's a great community of like-minded readers.

Now enough chatter. Go enjoy!

PART I

AWAKENING

Julianna looked relaxed, sitting there in the wide seats of First Class. She smiled up at her husband before saying, “Shouldn’t you be running along, back to Economy?”

The two shared a laugh. Stephen scratched the back of his neck and grinned. “Just soaking up the last of this luxury.”

Julianna sank into her chair, crossing her legs and tossing her rich, russet-brown hair. She caressed the arm rests and blinked up at him. “It is quite plush.”

“Now you’re just rubbing it in.”

“Yeah, maybe.”

A flight attendant came by, asking Julianna if she’d like something to drink before takeoff.

“A drink would be wonderful. Could I get a mimosa?”

“Certainly,” the flight attendant said. “And sir, are you sitting here?”

“No, my seat’s back there... unless this seat is free?”

“I’m afraid we have a fully booked flight today.” She was polite enough about it, but Stephen felt the shift in tone. “And I need you to take your seat, please.”

Julianna could barely keep her smile in check as their eyes met. She raised her brows. *You are dismissed.* Dimples formed beneath her high

cheekbones and delight danced in her dark, luminous eyes. Even after thirty years of marriage, Julianna's beauty still took his breath away.

"Right. I'll just..." Stephen stuck his thumb out over his shoulder. "...be back there... if you need me."

I love you, Julianna mouthed, blowing him a kiss.

They were on their way to Arizona to visit their adult son, although this trip was doubling as a nice getaway from their busy, professional lives. Airlines being the mess that they were, the flight had been overbooked. The representative at the check-in desk, however, gave them a break. Or, rather, gave *Julianna* a break. This happened a lot for her, primarily with guys who went out of their way to accommodate her. She got upgraded to First Class. Stephen got to keep his seat.

"At least it's Economy Plus?" she'd joked as they made their way through security.

It wasn't so bad, honestly. The plane wasn't large, and as he was situated across the aisle and a few rows back, he could actually see her from his seat.

He was certainly biased, but she was more beautiful now, at 54, than ever. Sexier, too, thanks to her rigorous diet and dedication to fitness. He was looking forward to spending time in a hotel room with her. Things always felt fresher when they were on vacation.

Her mimosa arrived around the same time as her seatmate—a handsome guy, maybe a few years younger, with a little gray around the temples of his dark hair, a strong jaw, and broad shoulders. From Stephen's vantage, he watched the guy take in Julianna, watched him smile at his good fortune, and watched him turn on the charm.

As she always was, Julianna was oblivious to the attention. She said hello, was her usual, friendly self, and by the time they took off, the two were chatting like they were old friends.

Stephen's stomach dropped as they took to the air, but the sensation was only partially from the liftoff. He knew this feeling well—it came from all the years being married to Julianna. She always commanded the attention of men, turning heads, making their wives envious. When he was a young man and they were first dating, he'd been ridden by jealousy. These days, that feeling had transformed into what it probably always had been—arousal. Even now, watching the handsome guy with the nice smile flirt with Julianna, had his cock thickening in his pants.

Not that Julianna even realized that she was being flirted with.

THIS GUY WAS TOTALLY FLIRTING with her. Sometimes she chose to ignore it—call it her defense mechanism against these things. Sometimes, it was fun, particularly when the guy was good looking. Anthony definitely qualified as good looking, and thanks to the mimosa, she didn't ignore the extra attention.

“There's no way you have an adult son,” Anthony said. “Did you adopt?”

Julianna laughed. She'd actually been asked this question before, and it was flattering. She never really believed guys who asked it, though. “Are you trying to get me to reveal my age?”

“Oh.” He chuckled. “No, I know better than that. Sorry if I offended you. Seriously, I'm just surprised. You're gorgeous.”

The apology actually sounded sincere, although she wasn't going to let up on him. She liked putting cocky men off balance. “And older women can't be gorgeous?”

To his credit, Anthony wasn't fazed. “No, I'm saying that *you* are gorgeous, and honestly, you know it.”

“You're making a lot of assumptions.”

“Other than that you don’t look old enough to have an adult kid, have I been wrong?”

“Okay, what else do you think you know about me, based purely on my appearance?”

Anthony took the opportunity to look her up and down, his gaze lingering on her chest. She didn’t mind. He was a good looking guy, virile and manly and definitely younger than her. It was nice knowing she could still get that kind of attention.

“Well, you’re married,” he said. “That’s an easy one based on your ring. You’re traveling alone, though, so I’m guessing that he’s a work-a-holic.”

The work-a-holic part was true, although she didn’t correct him about traveling alone.

“You belong to a gym, and not just casually. Maybe you do spin classes, but you also definitely lift weights. I can tell by your hands.”

“Maybe I work in construction.” It was a little frightening how much he intuited.

Anthony shook his head. “No, not construction. Not a desk job either, though. Maybe... a physical therapist?”

“How did you...?”

“That it? No shit.”

“Actually, an occupational therapist, but that’s pretty close.”

“Remind me to look you up if I ever hurt myself. You make house calls?”

Julianna had to laugh. “You’re very forward.”

“You like forward men.”

“Do I now?”

“Mmm hmm. You’re definitely attracted to strong, confident men.”

Julianna actually laughed out loud at Anthony’s presumption, and she enjoyed the way his arrogance flickered. He wasn’t entirely wrong, if she

was honest. She did like confident men, but she'd been around enough of them to see right through their acts. She'd raised one. She understood them.

Without giving up ground to this particular confident man, she said, "I'm attracted to all types. But I'm also married, remember?"

"We're just talking, right? Just passing the time."

"Okay then. My turn to stereotype you."

He rolled her shoulders back and puffed out his chest. He wore a button down with more than a few buttons undone, and had the kind of chest to pull that look off. "Let the stereotyping commence."

Before she could start asking, the flight attendant came by to check on them. "I'll take a glass of Chardonnay, and he'll have a..." She studied Anthony. "What brand of bourbon do you have?"

"Woodford Reserve," the attendant said.

"Perfect. No ice," she finished.

As the flight attendant left to get their orders, Anthony seemed to reappraise Julianna. That'll show him how she really feels about "strong, confident men."

"Okay, so..." She tapped her lips with her finger as she sized him up. "You're single." An easy one since he had no ring and no ring indentation. "You like sports. Maybe even played... baseball, but in college." She knew she was close based on his body language.

The flight attendant came by with their drinks, and they took a moment. "How am I doing?"

"I played lacrosse, actually. But that was a while ago." He sipped at the bourbon, served neat, without wincing. So she was right about that, too.

They'd been in the air about an hour, and Julianna could definitely feel the effects of her takeoff mimosa. The wine wasn't going to help, but it certainly could make things interesting. She normally wasn't so straight forward with guys, but most likely she'd never see this one again. Might as well have fun.

“Okay, what else...” She took a sip of her wine, letting the chilled liquid soothe her throat and chest. “You were married, but that didn’t work out. I’m guessing that was your fault, too.”

“Ouch,” he said. But he also didn’t correct her.

Julianna back home may have apologized, but she let it go. She was having fun putting him back into his place. “You haven’t had many successful relationships since then, and your bedroom is a revolving door. Not that you mind, because it helps prop up your ego that’s more fragile than you care to admit, even to yourself.”

Anthony’s smile finally slipped. “Double ouch.”

“You work in sales, which has you traveling a lot, and are pretty good at it, although it also gives you a low opinion of people, who you have started to see more and more as marks. This includes women like me.”

“I... no...”

“It’s okay, I’m frequently underestimated,” she said. This was fun. It was nice to see a man like Anthony blush. “How am I doing?”

At least he could grin, good naturedly. “Cruel, but mostly fair.”

“Let me guess. You don’t see me as a mark?”

“Of course not. You’re clearly too smart for that.” He seemed to regain his composure. “Also, I’m not in sales. I’m a business owner.”

“Please don’t tell me it’s a car dealership.”

He glanced over her, and she didn’t mind. “You’d look amazing in a silver Mercedes.”

“So you see me as a Mercedes-kind-of-woman?”

He thumbed his lower lip in thought. “I do, yes. Classy, high end, beautiful lines...”

Julianna found herself blushing. It was too much of a concession to this man. “I drive a Jeep.”

“Cherokee?”

“Wrangler. With the doors that can pop off.”

Anthony looked as impressed as he was surprised. He finished his drink, seeming to gather his thoughts.

“I was married, you’re right. Years ago. It was a bad idea.” He grimaced. “Contrary to your theory, *she* was the first to cheat. But we were both headed that direction anyway.”

“I’m sorry.” Julianna wasn’t sure what she was apologizing for—her presumption or the dissolution of this guy’s marriage.

“It’s all good. That was a million years ago, and we never should have tied the knot. How about you? How long have you worn that ring?”

“Thirty years. Well, thirty next year.”

Anthony’s jaw did loosen, his mouth parting in the same surprise that registered when he learned about their adult son. “Did you get married in high school?”

Julianna laughed.

“And now we’re back to you trying to get me to reveal my age.” Still, it was flattering. He really did seem to think she was younger than her 54 years. That felt good. She worked hard, and this was proof that the hard work paid off.

“Can I be honest?” he asked.

“You haven’t this whole time?”

“You look like you’re in your forties—maybe late thirties—”

Julianna burst out laughing.

“But obviously you’re not, and that makes you even sexier.”

“My husband thinks so.” She hoped that he didn’t see how deep her blush was.

“Every straight man on this flight does.”

“I don’t know about that.”

Anthony sank back into his seat. “I actually am pretty sure that you do.”

STEPHEN WATCHED the two banter and play through the whole flight like someone watching a horror movie unfolding—his pulse pounded beneath the ever present sensation of dread and inevitability. This wouldn't end well, yet he couldn't take his eyes off of it.

In many ways, this had been Stephen's whole life with Julianna.

They'd actually met when he was 15. He was friends with her brother, and she was the tomboy, 12-year-old sister who could still hang with them without being annoying. As she grew up, that was still the image he had of her—this spunky, rail-thin girl with a pageboy haircut and a good laugh. It kept her approachable even as she blossomed into one of the most beautiful women he'd ever seen, let alone met. Even when he heard that she was modeling, the idea was tempered by the image of the kid who would get muddy in the creeks and woods behind their homes.

They didn't see each other much when he went off to college, and he drifted apart from his friendship with her brother. He forgot all about Julianna until he crushed his arm at work and had to visit an occupational therapist. Julianna was there as the intern, same familiar smile and friendly laugh. If he'd met her for the first time, he would have been too intimidated to even speak to her, let alone ask her out for a drink to reminisce about old times. Instead, they did go out for drinks, which led to dates and sex and romance and finally, bewilderingly, improbably, marriage.

The guy up in first class was definitely into her. Stephen had seen it plenty of times over the years. Julianna had that kind of effect on guys, especially when he wasn't at her side as her obvious significant other. She'd deny it if they talked about it, just as she always did.

Early in their relationship, Stephen thought she did this to make him feel better. She was empathetic to a fault and was sensitive to any feelings of jealousy or insecurity he felt. That was definitely true, but over the years, Stephen realized that she also just didn't see the effect she had on guys. *"Oh, he was just being friendly,"* she'd say.

Not that it helped Stephen. He still had all the insecurities, although over the years, they stopped manifesting as jealousy and grew into something uncomfortably arousing.

In the first year of marriage, she used to go out dancing with her friends. This was when they still lived near a city that even had places to go out and dance, before transitioning to small town life and a kid and adulthood. Stephen had never been much for dancing, and Julianna's friends were as beautiful as she was. Unlike her, they intimidated the hell out of him. Usually, he'd stay home and wait for her to return. The sex was always amazing, in no small part thanks to the little dresses and heels she'd return in.

But in the hours that preceded her return, Stephen was left alone, thinking about Julianna out with her hot friends—most of whom were still single—dancing with guys, drinking with guys, doing more...

The jealousy felt like fate. Like he was a man falling out of the sky, who knew that one day he'd hit the ground and it would all be over. And then, one night, things shifted. He could still remember watching her wiggle into her little black dress, put on her makeup, and step into her heels. He still remembered kissing her goodbye, then going into the bedroom and jerking off as he imagined her and her friends getting picked up by some hot guys. It had felt wrong. Even now, on the plane reminiscing, he felt the shame of it. Wanted to bury it deep, but more and more those early fantasies were back, even now, twenty-five years later.

The friendly chit-chat up in first class didn't stop until they were touching down in Phoenix, and even then, it continued as they started to deboard. Being back in coach, Stephen helplessly sat there as he watched Julianna and the guy rise and collect their luggage from the overhead bin.

The guy seemed to enjoy watching her stretch in her black, skin-tight leggings, her blouse rising just enough to tantalize a band of bare skin. He

stepped in, his body against hers, his hands brushing along hers as they lifted her roller bag down.

Stephen was so hard he didn't want to get out of his seat at first. When Julianna looked over her shoulder at the guy, their heads were so close that they could have kissed. His mind flashed to the two of them like that, alone in a hotel room, only they were naked now, and he was holding her hands up against the wall as he fucked her from behind.

Shame rushed through him at the illicit thought, just as it always did. What was wrong with him?

Julianna glanced in his direction. When their eyes met, he wanted to hide, felt the sudden urge to cover his crotch, as if being walked in while masturbating. It didn't help that she looked guilty herself with this handsome stranger pressed up behind her. It certainly didn't help that her guilt only fueled his lust.

"Excuse me, I'd like to get my bag," said the guy next to him. The aisle had emptied out. It was Stephen's turn to stand.

"Right." He took a deep breath, willed his erection down with some marginal success, and pulled his shoulder bag from under the seat. He collected his bag from the bin, but by the time he was ready to go, Julianna was already gone.

He followed, just in time to see them making their way up the jet bridge. Was it his imagination or did she have a particularly sassy swing in her step. He marveled at how good her ass looked in those leggings, juicy and round.

He floated up the tunnel, stepping out into the light like a ghost newly arrived. He felt incorporeal enough, unable to prevent this other man from finally stealing his wife away.

They stood there, just beyond the line of passengers waiting to board, chatting and laughing away. He said something, handed her something, and was gone.

Stephen floated up to her. “Make a new friend?” She was actually flushed, twisting something over and over in his hand. “What’s that?”

“Um...” She looked down at it, grimacing as if suddenly remembering that she was holding a hot pan. “He gave me his card.”

“His card?” Stephen remained calm, despite the explosions in his gut.

She could barely meet his eyes now, looking like a spooked horse ready to bolt. She looked guilty. She’d been flirting with this guy and now felt really, really guilty. It dawned on Stephen like a lance of fire. He wanted to vomit. He wanted to jerk off.

“He’s from the area and... offered to show me some of the sights.”

Stephen couldn’t help it as his eyes dipped into her cleavage. She was flushed there, too, her blouse low-cut enough to give quite a healthy view of her full bust. Glancing back to her face, he said, “The sights, huh?”

“Oh, stop,” she said, regaining her composure. She handed him the card, saying, “Here, you take it. Now come on, Garrett’s probably already waiting for us in arrivals.”

Garrett, their 21-year-old son, was, indeed, waiting for them outside of arrivals, idling in the used Hyundai that they’d bought him for college. Seeing him in person washed away all the insecurities that Stephen had been battling with on the plane. It was good to see his son—*their* son. He was proud of the young man that they’d raised, and the adult that he had become.

“Mom, Dad! Welcome to Arizona!”

“It’s hot here!” Julianna said, taking her son into her arms. Stephen could still remember when he barely reached her torso. Now, he towered over her. “You look great, Garrett.”

“It’s Gary now, Mom.”

Julianna laughed. “Not to me it’s not.”

Garrett dropped them off at their hotel and left them to check in. He'd offered to let them sleep in his room while he slept on the couch, but they offered to stay at the Marriott around the corner instead. He had a roommate, who was a nice enough guy, but Julianna and Stephen were long past that kind of life.

Besides, Julianna always loved staying in hotels. Not only were they so clean, but she didn't need to *do* the cleaning. Stephen was great, but house chores weren't his strong suit. She could count the number of times that he'd made the bed on one hand. Here, someone else took care of that.

And the dusting.

And the vacuuming.

And cleaning the bathroom.

She turned, ready to say something about that to Stephen when she found him standing at the door, lost in thought. Her stomach dropped. He was jealous, and she'd made him jealous. Heat built beneath her blouse, the same heat she'd felt when Stephen emerged into the terminal and Anthony made one last play for her.

"Give me a call when you're free at night," Anthony had said.

"I'm visiting my son."

She knew it wasn't the protest she should have made. *I'm married* or *my husband is right behind us* would have been more appropriate. But she liked the idea that Anthony thought she was free. There was something exciting in the secret that she didn't understand, and now made her feel sickeningly guilty.

"I'm guessing your son isn't out of his early twenties, and a woman like you isn't going to crash on his couch. You're at a hotel." He had her so well pegged. *"So if you're looking for someone to keep you company at night, here's my card."*

God, just remembering those last moments had her uncomfortably warm.

"Stephen?" she asked. "Everything okay?"

"Hmm?" He seemed to snap out of whatever was going on in his head. "Oh, yeah."

He wasn't telling the full truth, she knew, and that didn't help her manage her guilt at all. She took a deep breath. She'd learned in the past that the best way to deal with these things, though, was to not let them fester.

"I'm sorry about Anthony." Saying his name made it feel real. Her insides squirmed.

"His name was Anthony." Stephen sounded wooden.

"Yeah, Anthony." She wrung her hands, twisting her engagement ring around her fingers. "I told him that I was married, but..."

"He's not the kind of man who's bothered by that." Stephen's voice sounded odd as he said it. His smile was forced. "It's okay. Not your fault." The grin was less forced, as was the way his eyes tracked her body. "I can't blame him. You're so sexy, Julianna."

It came out in a rush, almost as if he were embarrassed to admit it. That's what she loved so much about Stephen—she loved how genuine he was. She wanted to hold him, so she did, pulling him close.

“I love you, honey,” she whispered. “I should have stayed back in coach with you.”

Stephen shook his head. “I... I’m glad you didn’t.” The forced smile was back. “You... you deserve it.”

She knew Stephen, knew all about his insecurities. He was one of those silly men who thought that she was out of his league, as if life and love were structured like sports. She couldn’t imagine any other man at her side, through all of the years, through starting her career and raising Garrett and whatever fun times came next.

But no matter what she said, she could never seem to get through to him. If talk didn’t do it, then maybe he needed something more physical.

Kissing a man that you’d known for decades came in all flavors. There were friendly kisses, goodnight pecks, *I love you* smooches in passing. And then there were kisses that started as one of those and grew into more. Standing there in the threshold of the hotel room was one such kiss.

It was Stephen who initiated, pushing his tongue into her mouth as his hands encircled her waist. It was Stephen who guided her across the room, to the bed, tugging at her clothes like they were back in their twenties.

With her blouse off, Stephen reached behind her back and easily twisted open her bra, freeing the girls. He practically growled as he took her nipple into his mouth, sucking on the hard nub. She moaned, reveling in the wet sensation, the way he teased her with his tongue exactly the way she liked.

She’d had her breasts augmented about ten years ago, when she was feeling down on herself and her entry into middle aged life. It wasn’t an easy decision. She’d always been a champion of natural remedies, hard work, exercise, diet, but that only helped so much. Stephen had been supportive, and now, while it wasn’t a decision for every woman, she was happy that she’d done it.

She was perched on the edge of the bed as Stephen slid to his knees, kissing down between her breasts and across her tummy. She always felt

self-conscious about that. She'd worked hard to keep it flat, but she wasn't twenty anymore.

"You're so sexy," he said, staring up at her as he took hold of her leggings, staring up at her through the valley of her breasts. "So, so sexy..."

Stephen was a handsome man. Rather than fight his receding hairline, he decided to shave his head completely and grow a salt-and-pepper goatee. She liked the change, making him look tougher and edgier than his younger years. It was his eyes, though, that she always loved, blue, kind, thoughtful. Now they swam with adoration.

That adoration followed her as he dragged her leggings and panties off and sank between her legs. She shivered in anticipation. Her husband knew how to go down on her and make her head spin, and the years of intimacy had only honed that art to perfection.

"Oh, yes!" she cried, rocking back onto the bed. She lifted her knees, enclosing Stephen's face in her thighs as he swirled his tongue about her clit. And that was before he introduced his fingers, which she knew would come in three, two, one—

"YES!"

So good. Like opening the doors on a sunshine filled meadow after a long winter. All the tension of the flight, of the flirtation, or her guilt, fluttered away with that exalted breath. She rolled her hips up, bucking her pussy against Stephen's face as she tightened her fingers along his bare scalp.

He knew the score. He didn't stop licking, lapping, fingering. Not until she had too much. Not until she couldn't take it anymore. If anything, her orgasm spurred him on. He shook his head and gnashed between her thighs, and the higher her orgasm climbed.

When she finally came back down to earth, releasing him from her thighs, she looked down and couldn't help but laugh. He was red with

exertion, from his cheeks to the top of his shaved head. He huffed air like a swimmer finally breaking the surface after a long dive.

“You okay?” she giggled.

“Never better.” He ran his tongue up her slit. She shuddered, pushing him away with a foot on his face.

“Too much!”

“I just can’t get enough of this body.” He climbed up over her, kicking off his pants.

She reached between them, grabbing his cock. She shot him a look. “You’re really hard.”

“I like hearing you come,” he said. There was more to it than that, but she didn’t press. Now wasn’t the time.

“Good, because I like it when you make me come.” She guided him to her, opening her legs around his hips as he pressed home. He really was hard, steely and long, almost like another man.

Julianna shivered. No, not going to go there. This moment was about the two of them. This moment was a time for them to connect in a strange new place, and have strange, new experiences.

She focused on the feel of him, the smell of him, the way he moaned and gasped with each thrust. She held him against her, savoring the slippery friction of his body over hers. She loved the weight of him. She loved everything about him.

“Julie... Jules... ha, haaa...”

“That’s it, baby. Fuck me.” Her voice was a breathy whisper. She wasn’t much for dirty talk—not because she was too modest, more like it made her feel silly. But she knew Stephen liked it, and could feel him grow even harder as she teased for him. “Fuck me with your big, hard dick.”

“Ohhh.” It was enough. “Oh, I’m...” The rest was lost in a groan.

She squeezed him as he came, milking him of all that slippery heat. She didn’t come herself, but she was okay with that. She’d already had her

release, and feeling him climax was satisfying enough. She savored the connection, pulling him close, squeezing him tightly.

“I love you,” she said.

He pulled up enough to look down at her, brushing her hair from her face. “I love you, too, Jules.” For a moment, it looked as if he was going to say more, but then he pushed himself off of her and went to the bathroom.

She watched him go, enjoying his naked backside. Now pushing sixty, he’d thickened a little around the middle, and his butt wasn’t the cute tush that it once was, but neither was hers. She thought of her friends’ husbands, all of whom had let themselves go as they progressed through middle age. She made sure that he ate well to keep most of the pounds off, and he went to the gym with regularity. She would have recommended a better cardio to weight training ratio, but was sensitive to his insecurities. She also just liked muscles.

She slipped beneath the sheets, enjoying the feeling of clean linen against her naked skin. Why was it that hotel sheets felt so much better? Stephen came back from the bathroom with a wad of tissues—their usual routine after sex to keep the bed clean.

“Don’t worry about that,” she said. “We can just have housekeeping switch them out when we meet Garrett for dinner.”

Stephen smiled, sliding under the sheets at her side. “We should probably get ready to meet back up with him.”

“Probably.” But all she did was snuggle closer to her husband. Even with an empty nest, moments of quiet connection like this in the middle of the day were rare.

They lay there, listening to the background hum of the air conditioner until Julianna was almost asleep, then...

“If you were single, would you have called that guy?”

That guy... “Anthony?”

She felt him tense up beside him. “Yeah.”

He really had been bothered by that. Shoot. “No, I don’t think so.”

“But you’d think about it.”

She couldn’t read his tone, so she tread lightly. “I honestly don’t know what I’d be like if I wasn’t married to you. Probably a very different person.”

“But maybe one who’d go out with a guy like Anthony?”

She heard the downward spiral that he was on. “I love you, Stephen. I can’t imagine a life where you’re not by my side. Guys like Anthony don’t make great partners. They’re in it for one thing. A woman like me needs more than that.”

“You deserve more—”

“You always talk about me like I’m entitled to this and that. I don’t deserve anything, and Stephen, I’m so lucky to have you in my life. Look at all that we’ve done. We have an amazing son, a great life, friends back home, money to travel. And we just had a lot of fun. How many couples can say that after 30 years?”

“But didn’t you say you needed more?” He was stuck on her first statement.

“More than what the Anthony’s of the world offer. And besides, need is different than what is owed. All I really deserve is some respect, of course, and...” She twisted his nipple playfully. “...for you to believe me when I say that there’s no one I’d rather spend my life with than you.”

Stephen conceded with a smile. “Thank you.” He kissed her softly. “Sorry I get like that. I believe you.”

“Come on, let’s get dressed and call Garrett.”

“You broke up with Helena? What happened?” Julianna sounded shocked. Stephen felt it less so as he watched his son gather his thoughts.

They were sitting on the outdoor patio, having dinner as the sun set in the distance. It was warm and pleasant out here. He could see himself retiring in a climate like this one day. Julianna looked relaxed, wearing a loose, white blouse, her shades pushed up into her russet hair—turned a reddish hue in the setting sun.

“She... I...” Garrett looked flustered under his mother’s gaze. “I caught her cheating on me.”

“What? Helena?” Garrett and his girlfriend, Helena, had been going out since sophomore year of college. She’d come to their last two Christmases. She was a wonderful girl, and Julianna had already begun to think of her as a daughter-in-law.

“Yeah.”

Stephen stepped in. “I’m sorry, Garrett. That’s hard.”

Julianna actually got up and hugged him, and for a moment, Stephen was transported back in time, to when Garrett was seven and had scraped his knee running along the sidewalk. He was older now, but still their little boy.

Later that evening, after dinner had been settled and Julianna and Stephen were back at their hotel room, lying in bed, Julianna brought it up again. “I don’t understand people sometimes.”

“Hm?”

“Cheating, I mean.”

“Oh, you mean with Helana?”

“Yeah, but also... Lori. I didn’t tell you, but she and Luke are getting divorced.”

Lori and Luke were two of their close friends, going way back, although clearly Stephen had lost touch of late. “No...” That was more shocking than hearing about Garrett’s girlfriend. His son was young, and Stephen had never been under the impression that things were permanent. But Lori and Luke had been married almost as long as he and Julianna. “They always seemed good.”

“I know!”

“What happened?” Stephen reeled as he thought about Luke and Lori and their three kids—two of whom were still in high school. He thought of their expensive home, their cars, all the things that they’d accumulated over the years and now would have to split up.

“Luke caught her fooling around with their neighbor. Apparently he came home early for lunch one day because he forgot something and found them going at it in the den.”

As she filled Stephen in on the details and he laid there listening, he felt the way he always did when he heard stuff like this—not righteous disgust at the cheater, but rather how absurd the whole thing was. Absurd that Lori would throw her life away for some sex, but also absurd that Luke would as well.

If he had walked in on Julianna with the neighbor, he couldn’t ever imagine throwing everything they had away. He just couldn’t. And deep

down, confusingly, uncomfortably, the idea of walking in on Julianna with another man had his gut squirming in a not entirely unpleasant way.

He always kept these thoughts to himself, worried that it sounded like he was taking the cheater's side. He wasn't. Not at all. And he'd never, *ever* cheat. And as for the other thing—the illicit thrill that came with the thought—he didn't even want to acknowledge whatever *that* was.

"...knew that their sex life wasn't great, but it's no excuse," Julianna finished.

"If you did that—"

"I'd never," she cut him off, turning to snuggle closer. "Besides, we have a pretty good sex life."

Pretty good. Not great. He heard it, but let it go. Or maybe not. Maybe it helped him say the next thing.

"I know, but if you did, I'd never divorce you for it."

This statement silenced her. He stared up at the ceiling, too afraid to look at his wife, yet knowing her eyes were boring into him.

"I mean, I love you, and I know you love me. And if you did want to fuck the neighbor, you could tell me. We could talk." Stephen's heart was racing. He couldn't believe he'd actually confessed that, and tensed as he awaited the backlash. When it didn't come, when only silence greeted him, he added, "I'd rather talk it over than throwing everything we have away."

When he finally looked at Julianna, he couldn't tell what she was thinking. Her face was a beautiful mask, a slight furrow in her brow, the makings of a smile tugging at the corners of her lips.

He said, "It just seems... dumb..." Just like he was feeling now as he finally said his theory outloud.

"Oh, Stephen," was all she said. And then she started kissing him. Kissing led to more, led to her pushing him onto his back and mounting him. He was hard, just as he was always hard when thinking about this

stuff. “I will *never* do something like that.” The conviction behind her voice was palpable. “Ever.”

As she said it, he realized that it actually wasn’t what he wanted to hear. He didn’t need reassurances. He never doubted her fidelity. But he also didn’t want her to deny her desires. He knew that she enjoyed the attention from men like the guy on the plane. He wished she was comfortable talking about that.

She rubbed his cock along her pussy. She wasn’t dripping wet, but after a little friction, she welcomed him inside of her.

That was as far as the conversation went that night. As soon as he sank into her, he knew that talk of cheating and his progressive ideology on sex and marriage was over. Even still, he went to bed with a weight off of his shoulders. It was out there now, and even if Julianna didn’t bring it up again that night, he knew she wouldn’t forget it.

That’s how Julianna was. She enjoyed turning things over and over. She liked to contemplate. There was no taking it back now. *Que sera, sera*, he always believed. With Julianna, with their life, he never wanted anyone to have regrets.

JULIANNA DID NOT KNOW what to make of Stephen’s idea, but it worried her. It had sounded like something he’d been thinking about a lot, a theory that he’d been refining.

‘If you did...’ cheat... ‘I’d never divorce you for it...’

If he expected her to reciprocate, he’d be waiting a long time. She didn’t think of herself as a jealous person, but she wasn’t immune from the feeling. Stephen was an amazing man. She knew what she had, and knew more than a few women who wanted it.

But is that what he was hinting at? He seemed so nervous, almost like a confession. What did he mean when he said, *'I'd rather talk it over than throw everything we have away.'*

Was he trying to talk about it that night? Had he met someone else? The question alone made her sick to her stomach. After thirty years of marriage, she'd started taking Stephen for granted. Just like Luke had. There must have been signs that Lori was straying, but Luke had been too preoccupied with life to see them. Was this Stephen's sign?

Seeing their son was a reminder of the life that they had, and seeing Stephen laughing at one of Garrett's stories transported her back through the years—to Garrett as a teen, as a pre-teen, as a boy, as a toddler. In every scene, Stephen was there, experiencing life right along with her.

It had been hard to find time for intimacy with Garrett in the house. It took work, and some years were better than others. When Garrett grew up and started to lead a life of his own, they'd worked to regain that closeness. This trip was a reminder that everything was always just a work in progress.

And what better way to start working on it than the present time?

“How’s this?” Julianna asked, stepping out of the bathroom. She posed in the doorframe, one hip out, her arms above her as her husband stood mesmerized.

“Amazing,” he said breathlessly. “When did you get that?”

“Picked it up when you and Garrett were golfing. Glad you like it.”

Julianna had other little black dresses, but they were all back home, relegated to the back of her closet. Besides, this was a time to look forward, to having new experiences, to freshening things up.

“I do.” He stood. “A lot.”

The dress hugged her body, ending high enough above her knees to show off her shapely legs. The top of the dress was the interesting part—a front that crossed over her breasts and tied behind her back. It left her shoulders and upper back bare, two features that she worked hard to keep toned and was proud to show off.

“Maybe we skip dinner and just stay here,” Stephen said hungrily.

He looked good. He wore a brown, tattersall sports coat, along with a black t-shirt and black pants—also things she’d helped him pick. With his trimmed goatee and bald head, he looked sexy in a disguised way.

She moved up to him, running her finger along the coat’s lapel. “It’s nice to see you in something other than a golf shirt or a business suit,” she

said. “Don’t worry, we can have plenty of fun when we’re back.”

He caressed her bare shoulder, then brushed the spill of silky, dark red hair away from her neck. Leaning in, he kissed her there. She sighed.

“You sure?” He seemed nervous. Like this was a first date that he didn’t want to mess up. So funny after all these years.

“Stephen, you should know that I always put out on dates with handsome men.” She smiled as she watched him practically swoon. “Come on, take me out.”

La Bella Cucina was an upscale, Italian steakhouse, and not at all the kind of place they usually went to. She wasn’t a big fan of red meat, and Stephen had always complained that they were overpriced. Still, Julianna felt right at home in the swanky restaurant. It was the perfect place to strut around in an LBD and a pair of heels, on the arm of a handsome, older man.

Their table wasn’t ready when they arrived, so they went to the bar to enjoy some artisanal cocktails. “You really do clean up well, Stephen Reeves.”

“I’m just doing my best to keep up, Julianna Reeves.” He seemed distracted, his eyes scanning the crowd at the bar. Like he was bored of her?

“I have a fun surprise,” she said, getting close. His attention was back on her.

“Yeah?”

“Mmm hmm. This dress wasn’t the only new thing that I picked up while you were golfing.” She made a show of crossing her legs on the stool, drawing his eyes to her dark nylons. “I always forget how good expensive lace can feel against my skin.”

Stephen’s pupils practically dilated with arousal. That’s more like it. Before she could tease him more, though, a disorientingly familiar voice announced, “Your table is ready.”

It took Julianna a moment to connect the man with his strong jaw and dark eyes to a memory. Anthony. From First Class. He looked different

here, wearing a dark suit and dark shirt, dark tie, like an action star villain. He had more stubble on his face, but it looked good on him. And when he stared at her, she knew that he hadn't forgotten her, either.

"Oh, right," she stuttered, off-balance.

"Follow me, Mr. and Mrs. Reeves."

His grin was a knowing one—one that said, *Don't worry, we can keep our flight a little secret.*

Julianna was dizzy as she followed him into the restaurant, like she'd had a dozen cocktails, rather than half of one. How had this happened? Of all the restaurants in the city, they chose the one that he owned?

"A server will be along shortly. In the meantime, can I get you anything?" The question was for Julianna, laced with innuendo, although he had the grace to glance at Stephen at the end.

"I think we're all set for now," Stephen said. "Thank you."

"Of course."

As soon as he was out of earshot, Julianna leaned forward and whispered, "What the hell is going on?"

"Hm? What do you mean?" He lifted his menu up, blocking his face and hiding his smile. Stephen was behind this.

"What did you do?"

"Nothing. I just... made a reservation."

She stared at her husband like he'd grown a second head, but then it fell into place. "His card. You kept it."

"Oh, that's where I heard about this restaurant first. But I read the reviews. Even Garrett said it was a good spot for a date."

Julianna took a slow, calming breath. It didn't help much. Her mind was already working through the consequences of this reservation. Anthony would assume that *she* had kept his card. He'd assume that *she* had made this reservation—or at the very least, convinced her husband to take her out

here. That was why he pretended not to know her at the bar. What else was the man assuming?

“What’s your game, Stephen?” she asked.

“Just wanting to have dinner with my beautiful wife. And hopefully, if she’s up to it, some sex after.”

“Well, after this stunt, you may come up short on that last part.”

Stephen opened his mouth to say something, hesitated, and then seemed to decide to say it anyway. “I bet Anthony would be happy to take my place.”

It was a common refrain from Stephen, his chronic insecurity that Julianna knew she’d never be able to cure. Only this wasn’t quite so straightforward. This was self-inflicted. “What’s going on, Stephen? Seriously. Tell me.”

She expected another joke. Instead, she watched him pick up his cocktail and sip. Was his hand trembling? Was he flushed in the low light of the restaurant?

He licked his lips. “I...” And then he *was* flushed, red climbing unmistakably up his neck. She shifted, all of a sudden nervous herself, her heart racing.

“What?”

“You’re so... beautiful.” He swallowed. “I don’t want to hold you back.” It was almost a mumble. Almost unintelligible.

She reached across the table and took his hands in hers. “Oh, honey, how could you say that? You’re not holding me back from anything. You *never* have. You’ve given us this life that I love. That *we* love.”

He seemed to drag his eyes up to hers and force himself to hold their gaze. Those blue, familiar eyes. Eyes that she stared into once, years ago, and said, *‘I do.’*

“That’s not what I mean. I know you love me. I’m not talking about love.”

“Oh...kay. What are we talking about?”

Another deep breath. Another big hesitation. Then, with a smile and a shrug like a man finally committing to jump off a cliff, he said, “Sex. I’m talking about sex.”

“I—”

“With other men. You and other men.”

Her heart jumped. Heat enveloped her. “This is about Lori? And Helena?”

“Kind of, but... but no, not exactly like that.”

“About your hypothetical from the other night then,” she said. “About open communication.”

He winced, as if embarrassed by the reminder of that conversation. “Closer, yeah.”

“Okay, but I’m not looking for that kind of permission. I don’t need anyone other than you.” Her heart skipped. “Do you?”

“No. Never.” His denial was so quick, like he hadn’t even considered that. That gave Julianna pause. “You didn’t really think...” he began, then quickly seemed to put it all together. “Oh, honey, no, I don’t need... I don’t want...”

She believed him, and that only made her more confused. “What do you want?” she asked softly.

“I guess I have this... thing...”

He looked so uncomfortable, and she felt uncomfortable right along with him. As if beckoned, the server came by not only with their menus, but with a bottle of wine as well. “From the owner,” she explained. “An apology that your table wasn’t ready when you arrived.”

Julianna glanced at Stephen, who had a slightly crazed look on his face. “Thank you,” he said. “Wine sounds wonderful.”

The server poured him a full glass. “And you?”

She glanced beyond her husband, where Anthony was watching from the bar. The temperature in the room seemed to jump ten full degrees. “Yes, please.”

“Are you ready to order?”

She hadn’t even had a chance to look at the menu. “Not quite.”

The server excused herself. Stephen picked up the wine glass. “Thank you for this,” he said. “To having a beautiful wife.”

“Who will always be your wife,” she added, clinking her glass to his. “Now tell me about your thing please.”

“Of course.” He took another deep sip of his drink. “Maybe we should figure out what we’re going to order first though?”

Julianna studied him for a long time before letting it go. For now. “Sure. So what did the reviews say were good?”

“I actually have no idea.”

Julianna snorted. Of course.

STEPHEN SPENT most of the meal feeling like he was either going to throw up all over the table, or have a heart attack. He’d dug himself into a hole, and as they ordered and waited for the food to arrive, he tried to think of a way out of this mess that didn’t involve him confessing this dark fantasy of his. What else could his ‘thing’ be other than a fucked up desire for his wife to take on a lover?

The wine helped, fortifying his courage just as he’d hoped. Didn’t help that the wine was from a guy who’d spent an entire plane trip trying to get into his wife’s bed.

Then again, that was on him. He’d kept the guy’s business card and ended up calling the restaurant that he apparently owned to figure out when

he'd be there. That had been quite nerve-wracking, doing it discreetly, pretending to be an old friend in town.

He'd set it all up so that he would *have* to finally come clean.

So when Julianna looked at him, raised her brows, and said, "Time to talk about your thing," there was no escape. He was grateful for that. He'd finally be free, one way or another.

"I have a fantasy..."

"Yes?" She nodded, looking both nervous and encouraging.

"About you... sleeping with other men."

Her jaw fell open, just as he had been terrified that it would.

His face burned. "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have said anything. It's not really—"

She cut him off before he could fully escape. "No, I'm sorry. I shouldn't have reacted like that..." She slowed down, clearly trying to wrap her head around that. "But I'm going to have to ask you to clarify please."

"Sure." It was easier, now that it was out there. "It turns me on when I think about you getting it on with other men."

"Yeah, that's what I thought you said." She bit her lower lip, looking around in thought. "So you want to... try swinging?"

Julianna's question made him squirm even more. "No, not exactly swinging."

"I don't understand."

"Swinging is when a couple swaps with another couple." His ears burned at his own, matter-of-fact explanation. He looked around, realizing how public they were, but the tables were spaced enough that he didn't think anyone else heard. "This is just you and... someone else."

"I don't get it." Then, after a beat, "Do you want to sleep with someone else?"

"No, I told you, that's not it." He didn't realize that he'd raised his voice until he noticed the people beside him looking their way. He lowered his

voice, leaned closer to her, and took her hands. He ran his thumb over her ring, the diamond a reminder of how solid their relationship was. “This isn’t for me. It’s about you.”

“But...” She shook her head, trailing off.

“Honestly, I don’t fully understand it myself, but I’ve been living with it for almost the entire time we’ve been together, although I guess my thoughts have been evolving. When you and Lori used to go out together, actually, I used to sit at home and think about all the guys hitting on two such attractive women, and it was... exciting.”

“I always thought it made you jealous,” she said.

“Well, it did. That’s definitely a part of it. It makes me crazy. Even earlier this week, on the plane, I was all over the place.” He saw her begin to apologize again, so he moved on to get them past that. “But I’ve realized over the last few years that I have nothing to worry about. For whatever reason, you’ve decided to stick with me into our old age. But you’re also still so... hot, attractive, and sexy. Guys notice, even if you don’t. And subconsciously, at least, it makes you feel good when they do.”

“You make me sound like an attention whore.”

That was her defense mechanism kicking in. She always got like this, although Stephen was starting to realize how much she’d developed it to protect *him*. “No.” He shook his head. “Just a woman with needs and desires. And I’m not here to judge, certainly not to blame. I sure as hell don’t blame the guys. And I want to give you the freedom to... reciprocate, I guess.”

She raised a single brow at him. “How generous.”

“No, I didn’t mean... that sounded bad.”

“Kind of, sort of.”

“I’m sorry to objectify you, or be possessive. Really, it’s not like that.” He wet his suddenly very dry lips. This wasn’t going the way he wanted it to.

Julianna helped him out. "I'm sorry, it's all just... a lot." She laughed stiffly. "Truth is, I guess, I do notice. And I... do like it. But I'd never do anything more than notice."

"And flirt back?"

It was nice to see her go all red. "Maybe sometimes." She took a deep breath, still chewing on his confession. "So if I told you that I want to meet up with Anthony after dinner for a drink, you'd just... go back to the hotel?"

Like that, he was hard. He was so hard. Hard enough that he was glad that this was the type of restaurant with table clothes. "Do you want to?"

"Can't answer a question with a question, Stephen. I get my answer first."

That was fair. Honesty. He could give her that. "Just thinking about you getting a drink with him seems to have drained all the blood out of my big head down to my small one."

"Not so small," she said with a coy smile. A moment later, Stephen felt her foot slide up the inside of his thigh and right up against his erection. This was another benefit of table cloth. "Oh, you really are turned on."

She wiggled her toes across his balls before pulling back, drawing a shudder. Her surprised delight persisted as she sipped more wine. Stephen realized that she was feeling the alcohol as much as he was, which gave him the courage to make the next suggestion.

"What if I just leave? Like, pretend to get a call and have to leave you here alone? I bet it takes him only a few minutes before he's over here."

Julianna stared at Stephen, her smile frozen as she unpacked his suggestion. "You're serious," she seemed to conclude.

He hedged. "Maybe?"

"You know he probably thinks it was my idea to come here," she pointed out. Which meant that she was doing the calculus on his suggestion.

Which made his blood pressure spike even higher. Her eyes refocused on Stephen and she laughed. “The look on your face...”

“What?”

“You don’t look like you’re enjoying this. You look more like you’re going to be sick.”

Stephen forced a chuckle. “It feels kind of like I’m at the top of a rollercoaster. There’s definitely that feeling of *what am I doing here*, but also all this anticipation.”

When she shook her head, she wasn’t dismissing him or writing off his fantasy. He felt so exposed to her, so vulnerable, and so grateful that he could be that way with her. Why hadn’t he confessed this sooner?

Seizing on the momentum, he pulled out his phone before Julianna could find her words. When she realized what he was doing, her eyes got big and, simultaneously, she started to laugh. “No, you’re not...”

“Hello?” he said. He pretended to receive a call, looking put out by whoever was on the other end. “Tonight? But Larry, I’m out with my wife. Can this wait until tomorrow morning?”

Julianna just shook her head over her smile. “We are not doing this,” she mouthed.

“No, I understand,” he went on, chatting into the phone. “Sure, I can jump on a call back in the hotel room. Give me...” He glanced at his watch, making a big show of it. “A half hour. I need to get a taxi.”

He faked hanging up. He still wasn’t sure, himself, whether he was actually going to go through with it. Then he thought about the way Julianna had spent the entire flight flirting with this man, and how he felt at the time, and how it made him feel now. He grabbed his napkin as he stood, holding it over his erection as he calmed that down, and leaned towards Julianna.

“I’ll see you back at the hotel. Stay out as late as you want.”

She was speechless, continuing to shake her head with a disbelief that he happened to share. Things felt fuzzy from wine, and even warmer because he was doing something brand new.

“You’re not really leaving,” she said.

“I am. Enjoy your drink.”

She stared. He walked out.

Julianna watched her husband actually leave the restaurant, still thinking this was all a joke. She sat there and waited for him to come back. When he didn't, her disbelief gave way to something more acute, like she'd been in an accident and only now, as the shock began to wear off, did she realize she was injured.

Looking around in the sea of people all having their quiet, intimate conversations, Julianna felt very aware that she was at a table of one. She was abandoned. Her husband had left her.

She finished off her glass of wine and looked around to make eye contact with her server. Time for the check. This wasn't fun. She was already thinking about seeing if there were any movies starting soon, so that she could sit in a theater and make Stephen squirm, when someone came over, picked up the bottle of wine, and started to refill her glass.

"No, I—"

It was Anthony, smiling down at her as he emptied the last bit of the bottle. Looking at the label, he smiled. "Did you enjoy it? It's one of my favorites. I love the subtle notes of spice mixed in with the grapes." He glanced at her, and her breath caught. "Thought you were traveling alone." He set the bottle down. "Or was that not your husband?"

“He... met me out here.” She wasn’t sure why she was lying. “He was able to make it out after all.”

“And he left?”

She picked up her refilled glass. Her hand didn’t tremble. “Work followed him here. He works way too much.”

“I’d never choose work over a beautiful woman like you.”

“So if I asked you to buy me a drink at someone else’s restaurant...?” Julianna couldn’t believe that she made the suggestion, but this man’s arrogance just begged to be challenged.

“Is that an offer?”

“It’s a question.” She sipped at the wine, this time tasting the aforementioned spice lingering on her tongue.

“Wait here.”

She watched him go, wondering what the hell she was doing. It was flattering, no doubt. Anthony was a good looking guy, who cleaned up even better than she’d expected. With that jaw, those eyes, and all that confidence, he could have his pick of women, yet here he was, trying to get off of work to spend time with a fifty-something woman.

To fuck that fifty-something woman.

Her stomach fluttered. *You still have it*, she thought to herself.

The server came by first, and she nearly jumped out of her seat. “Can I get you anything else?”

“Just the check please.”

STEPHEN COULDN’T BELIEVE he was walking out of the restaurant. He couldn’t believe that he was just going to leave Julianna alone. The emotions were as confusing as they were powerful. He didn’t even need to

close his eyes anymore to imagine them together, their naked bodies entangled, Julianna's mouth agape as she moaned.

It kept him going, driving forward like a drum beat. He hailed the taxi. He went back to the hotel. He immediately went to the bar and ordered a stiff drink. He didn't want to be alone. Not immediately. He didn't want to be totally lost in his swirling thoughts and the dark of his room.

"Here you are," the bartender said, setting a cocktail down before him after what felt like the blink of an eye. That's how the last half hour had felt, ever since he'd left. A blink, like time skipping, and here he was. "You okay, sir?"

"Um, yes. Sorry, just... interesting night."

The bartender nodded before floating away, not interested in lending a sympathetic ear. Which was fine for Stephen. He wasn't sure how much he could articulate, anyway.

Stephen had his phone out, his Messages app open, staring at the last text message thread that he'd had with Julianna—an exchange about their groceries list. He was asking what kind of tomatoes she wanted; she responded with her request, along with a warning not to buy potato chips. It all sounded so mundane in light of what was happening right now. It was dizzying.

His cocktail came and went without memory. He ordered another, along with a glass of water, and forced himself to sip it as he snuggled into the warm, comforting blanket of his buzz. He opened his photos, browsed pictures of Julianna and the life that they shared.

Like the texts, most were mundane. Pictures of the two of them on hikes, posing with their dog, a smiling one of Julianna at dinner for her 52nd birthday. She wore a dress much like the one she had on now, showing off a healthy amount of her cleavage... cleavage that another man was enjoying right now, no doubt.

He took a deep, wavering breath, feeling light-headed at it all. He was so hard, and so tied up in knots at the same time. This was a mistake. This was awesome. Was it possible to hold both truths?

“Is this seat taken?”

Stephen was startled out of his thoughts by the question, delivered in a smoky, suggestive woman’s voice.

“I...” He stuttered before realizing that it was Julianna asking the question. That feeling of relief and disappointment was becoming a familiar one. He quickly recovered. “Not anymore. Can I get you a drink?”

It was now Julianna’s turn to appraise him, flicking her eyes across his broad shoulders before locking gazes. “I don’t know. I’ve already had a lot to drink tonight.”

The suggestion hung in the air between them—she’d had drinks, but with who? How long had they been apart? How long had she been alone with Anthony?

“Then one more drink won’t hurt.”

She seemed to consider shooting him down, and even though this was all a fun lark, Stephen felt the jittery fear of rejection that he used to feel all the time with Julianna, long before marriage and kids and life.

Her eyes drifted about the bar, as if taking in her other options, before refocusing on him. “One more would be lovely.”

Stephen’s heart raced. Did she even realize what she was doing to him?

“So what brings you into town?” he asked.

The role-play slipped for just a minute as the familiar Julianna-smile shined through. “Visiting my son.”

“Alone?” He shifted, pretending to have the confidence that a guy like Anthony wore so naturally.

The way Julianna’s smile lingered, the way she paused before answering, was delicious. “Tonight I’m alone.”

He glanced at her ring. “Where’s your husband?”

“I’m not sure.” Her smile fell as she waved her hand before her like clearing away a bad smell. “I don’t care. I’m upset with him.”

“Oh?”

“He made me feel like a piece of meat.”

Uh oh. “Did he now?”

“Mmm hmm.” At least she was smiling, seeming to enjoy needling him. “He’s a good guy, but sometimes he doesn’t think things all the way through. He sees something he wants—or thinks he wants—and doesn’t consider me in the process.”

Double uh oh. The blood drained from Stephen’s face. “That... doesn’t seem good. I’m sure he didn’t mean it.”

“Such a typical guy thing to say.” She seemed to take delight in his discomfort. “But you’re probably right. I don’t get it, but he does want me to have my fun.”

Her tone shifted, getting deeper, sultrier. Stephen gulped. “Did... did you?”

“Did I *what*?”

“Have... fun?”

“You know what?” Again, the dramatic pause. Again, the tightening of everything in Stephen’s body. Julianna leaned in, tantalizing him with her cleavage in those crossing straps, with her raw sexuality. “I did. My husband wanted me to have a drink with a handsome stranger. Can you believe that?”

“Doesn’t sound so bad for you.”

“Oh, it wasn’t,” she purred. Stephen’s balls tightened enough that he nearly groaned. “But that doesn’t excuse him.”

“Want to get back at him?”

“I do. You have an idea?”

Again, he imagined he was Anthony. Again, he put on the mask of a man who went through life with a big dick. He looked her right in the eyes,

not seeing the woman he'd been married to for three decades, or the mother of his son, or the capable working professional, but the way guys like Anthony saw her—a smoking hot woman with a killer body and a great smile.

“I’ve got a *great* idea...”

THEY COULD BARELY KEEP their hands off of one another on their way up to the hotel room, and were all over each other as soon as the door latched. It hadn't been like this between them for many years—if ever, Stephen thought.

Julianna's mouth was wet and willing as they kissed, her tongue wrestling with his as they made out and stumbled through the room.

His hands roamed her body, and he could feel the heat of her beneath the thin dress. He traced her panties, a plunging thong, and wondered if he was the first to discover it.

He'd done the calculations on their way upstairs. They had been apart for a little less than an hour and a half. The hotel was about ten minutes from the restaurant. Factoring in the time it took to get the check and to find a taxi or get an Uber, that left maybe 45 minutes of unaccounted time. Too short for for much to happen, long enough that maybe something did. A drink? Did he offer to wait with her as her Uber arrived? Did he offer to drive her back to the hotel, and if so, did they make out in his car?

She wouldn't do that, of course. Even in his wildest fantasies, he couldn't actually believe that she'd get in a stranger's car in a strange city. But a drink at the bar, the two of them getting close, his hand sliding along her hip and into the small of her back as she drank in the smell of his cologne. Maybe they were in a booth. Maybe his hand slid in between her legs, along the inside of her thigh, right up against her—

“Oh!” Julianna gasped as Stephen pressed his fingers against her thong-clad pussy. She was damp. He could feel how balmy she was, how her panties slipped along her lips and soaked the lacy material. She may have been upset at him, but something had turned her on.

He pushed her panties aside, needing more. She was wet. So exquisitely slippery. Like running his finger along a damp bar of soap.

She gasped again as he pushed first one finger, then a second, inside of her. Teasing her was second nature. Like breathing. Like kissing. He ran his thumb up over her clit, just grazing it before sliding up along her landing strip.

“Ngh!” Julianna gasped. Was she remembering how Anthony had touched her here first, his large, unfamiliar digits slinking up beneath her dress, touching her in new and exciting ways.

Stephen moved them to the bed. He couldn’t wait longer, and knew that he wouldn’t be able to last long. Normally they took their time to get naked. Normally they drew out the foreplay, kissing, caressing, stripping.

Not this time. Neither of them seemed interested in sharing a tender moment. When Stephen climbed atop Julianna, who was still wearing her dress and her panties, his pants unzipped and pushed down just to his mid-thigh, he expected his wife to laugh and push him away so she could undress.

She didn’t. She welcomed him, as desperate to feel cock as he was to fuck her. He pushed her dress up to her waist, exposing her stockings, lacy banded and as sexy as her panties. Garters were clipped into the tops, and as he pushed the dress higher, he saw the garter belt.

He didn’t admire long. Not with Julianna holding her thong to one side, her pussy glistening beneath her dark landing strip. He lined up and drove into her as she wrapped her arms around his neck and pulled him close. He heard her orgasm before he felt it, a low growl that came from deep in her

throat before spreading through her. She tossed her head back, squeezed her legs around him, and crashed against his driving dick.

JULIANNA WAS aware that this was the third time that they'd had sex in as many days, which was a real feat after being married for so long. Not that she complained. She loved it, and she loved having sex with her husband. But it *was* noteworthy.

She still couldn't get her head wrapped around Stephen's fantasy, but there was no doubt that it turned him on. She had six inches of hard manhood driving in and out of her to prove it.

It turned her on, too, although she didn't like to admit it. Not after the trick he'd played on her by leaving. He'd set her up, then left her alone. She could hardly blame Anthony for making assumptions. Or taking her up on her offer to buy her a drink. Or moving in to kiss her.

Her orgasm took her by surprise, like stepping outside thinking it would be cold, only to feel the sun kiss her face. She welcomed it. It was only fair after Stephen's stunt. She let it radiate over her, emboldened with each thrust of her husband.

It had been over thirty years since she'd kissed another man on the mouth. She had forgotten how exciting that could feel. A kiss held so much promise and vulnerability and anticipation. That moment started long before his lips actually touched hers, and in the moment, she saw the possibility of all that could come. His face felt different. He tasted new. He smelled spicy. She wondered what he looked like naked. She wondered how he fucked, and realized with frightening clarity that she could easily find out.

"Gah!" She arched back, touching her face with one hand, pinky and ring finger tugging at her lips as she lost herself in the fever dream.

'Let's get out of here,' he'd said.

'I can't. My husband...' She couldn't even finish that sentence.

'I live just a few blocks away. We'll be quick.'

"Oh!"

In her head, behind her tightly shut eyes, the man inside of her wasn't Stephen, but Anthony. They weren't on the bed, but the cool, hard surface of a desk, her dress hiked up around her hips just like now, her thong pushed to one side as Anthony took her right there in the illicit dark of his office.

"I want your come," she hissed. It was an un-Julianna thing to say, but tonight she was behaving very differently than Julianna ever had. "Come, Baby. Come—OHHH!"

She couldn't escape the churn of her illicit thoughts. About Anthony. About the things he wanted to do to her. About the things *Stephen* apparently wanted him to do to her.

Stephen's come, hot and wet and pulsing as it flooded through her, was a welcome familiarity. She laced her legs around him and welcomed him home, no longer fighting the lust and her climax, but going with it. If this was what he wanted, she could go with it. For now.

They drunkenly climbed into bed together, wiggling out of their evening clothes beneath the high thread count sheets. Julianna's post-orgasmic high abated, leaving her once again confused and more than a little exasperated. She snuggled up to Stephen, pressing her naked body against his, and caressed the soft hairs on his chest.

"Stephen?"

"Hmm?"

"Never do that again."

He didn't try to play naive. Stephen knew that what he'd done was wrong. "I shouldn't have left you alone—"

"Correct—"

"But you also didn't seem to have minded *that* much—OW!"

She twisted his nipple, not too hard, but hard enough to get his attention. “I’m serious, Stephen! I felt... used. Like a piece of meat between you two.”

Stephen processed it quietly. He took her in his arms and squeezed her tightly. “That sucks. I’m sorry. Not what I wanted at all.”

And that begged the question that she wasn’t sure she wanted to ask. She did anyway. “What... what did you want?”

Stephen’s sigh was long and full of meaning. “I don’t know.”

Julianna knew him so well. He couldn’t lie to her, and what he was saying wasn’t the full truth. She could have let it go, but this felt like an important moment in their lives. A lot hinged on getting clarity. “You wanted one drink to turn into more.” She felt him tense. “You wanted him to take me somewhere private and then... take me.”

Her tummy quivered as she said it.

“Yes,” her husband said breathlessly.

“He... kissed me.”

“No.”

She winced, afraid that this whole thing was a ruse. Afraid that he’d throw her out of bed. “Yes.”

“Did... was it... wow...”

“You’re not upset?”

“No.” It was a drawn out no, like he was testing it out. “Unless it was unwelcome.”

She was back in that moment again. They’d gone to a bar across the street from the restaurant—a crowded spot, trendy and fun and full of laughter. He’d ordered her a drink, and she’d accepted. It was fun to get lost in the crowd like that, having to yell to be heard, getting caught up in the moment. It had been years since she’d felt that kind of energy.

They were sharing some forgotten anecdote when Anthony was jostled close to her, one hand gliding across her hip as he steadied himself, their

bodies pushed closer.

She remembered looking up at him, ready to accept his apology—because that’s what Stephen would have done—he would have apologized. Instead, Anthony touched her face, leaned down, and kissed her.

Julianna returned to the present and smiled at her husband. “No, it wasn’t unwelcomed.”

“You kissed him back?” Stephen said. He looked manic, much like he had when confessing his fantasy earlier.

“Yeah, kind of. Yeah.” She grinned, feeling his cock harden against her hip. “We were in a bar. It wasn’t like, you know, a full on makeout thing.”

“Right.” Stephen released a heavy breath. “That’s very sexy.” The way he was looking at her was like a starving man seeing a hot meal. “You’re so sexy.”

“Thanks.”

“Did anything else happen?”

‘Let’s get out of here.’

‘I can’t. My husband...’

‘I live just a few blocks away. We’ll be quick.’

The memory was still there, lingering like a stranger’s cologne. “He... wanted it.”

“And you didn’t?”

“I wanted to come back to you. I only stayed out to punish you.”

“And I loved that you did. But... you really weren’t tempted?”

“Stephen, give me some credit. I’m not an animal, completely driven by the whims of my impulses. He’s not the first good looking guy to flirt with me, you know, and I’ve never slept with any of them.”

She knew that even admitting to that—that others have hit on her in the past—would land like a gut-punch to her husband. She’d always been careful in the past to keep those observations to herself. What she was

checking for was lust, and she found it in his racing heart and once-again hard cock.

“That really does turn you on, though,” she observed. It was no longer a question, even if she didn’t fully understand the answer.

“Yeah, it does.” They cuddled together, intimate while giving space for quiet thought. At last, he said, “It’s weird, I know, but it... it feels good to tell you. I’ve been holding onto that for so long.”

Stephen was a stoic man who kept so much to himself. Here he was, putting his guard down. Here he was, exposed before her, and she appreciated how hard that was for him. “Thank you for telling me.” She kissed him sweetly, looked him right in the eyes, and said, “If we’re going to explore this thing, it’s going to take that kind of open communication.”

He looked both confused and excited all at once. “We’re going to explore... this thing?”

Julianna grinned. “If you want to.” She kissed his forehead, his cheek, his jaw. “Do you want to?”

Before he could answer, she started kissing down her body, where his cock waited, hard and ready for her mouth.

It was amazing that even after thirty years of marriage, you could still learn something totally, wildly, erotically brand new about your partner.

PART II

THE PROFILE

“How about, ‘*Looking for intelligent and attractive men to have a discreet, no-strings attached relationship with.*’”

“Uh, no. That’s not me at all,” Julianna said with a laugh.

“It’s a starting point. We’re workshopping it.”

Julianna was chopping vegetables at the counter. Stephen was on his computer, composing a profile for her on Ashley Madison. “*You’re workshopping it,*” she said. “I’m preparing dinner.”

About a month had passed since Phoenix, and Stephen was increasingly eager to push the hotwife thing. He got like this about new pursuits—even went through a board game phase a few years back, acquiring games of escalating complexity and making Julianna try them out with him. She finally had to tell him that she wasn’t interested. He took it well, but the hobby stopped after that, and they were *still* receiving Kickstarter fulfillments.

That level of enthusiasm was one of qualities that drew her to him back in the day. She got excited when he did. Early on, before they had much money, they hiked and camped all over the place, and she still had amazing memories. He could be like a kid just before Christmas, eager, speculative, obsessed.

It was also sometimes kind of annoying. That was the way when you knew someone for so long. She was trying not to let this new hotwife thing get to her, but it also came laden with doubt and insecurity.

Was she not good enough for him? What kind of woman did he think she was that she'd just have sex with other men after years of being monogamous? And also, maybe, he was just angling this to be some kind of swinger thing and sleep with a younger, tighter, sexier woman.

"I think those onions are minced enough," Stephen said softly behind her. He touched her arms, pressing up behind her.

Julianna looked down at the cutting board, where she'd been taking out her angst on the poor Vidalia.

"Oh, right." She laughed to herself.

"I'm sorry," he said. "I'm doing it again, aren't I?"

She turned in his arms, leaning back against the counter, and looked up at him. He was such a handsome man. She'd always thought that, even when he was just "her brother's best friend." She knew she was biased, but thought he looked better now than ever. She liked his current look—shaved head and graying goatee. She liked the way he'd filled out over the years, with muscle in his arms and shoulders... and some extra padding around his waist. Even that, she kind of liked.

It wasn't fair that men could go into their later years and look better—that they could be called "distinguished" as a good thing—while women had to put all of their energy into fighting their age. She would soon be 55. Again, the doubt rose in her—that Stephen was getting bored, and that maybe he wanted to trade up.

He seemed to pick up on her anxiety. "Hey, I'm sorry I'm pushing. I don't need this. Definitely not." He pulled her in for a hug. "You're all I ever need, okay?"

That felt good to hear. She believed him, because it was exactly how she felt about *him*. And yet, she couldn't help but wonder if there was more.

“But?”

“No butts,” he said, sliding his hands down over her ass. “Other than this one,” he added, squeezing her cheeks.

Julianna laughed, even though it was a joke she’d heard from him a hundred times.

“I can just drop it. No more talk about hotwives.” He made a gesture to zip his lips closed, but she stopped him mid-zip.

“No, don’t do that. Don’t hide it away again, because that’s what you’d be doing. I just... I’m still processing it all. You’ve lived with this fantasy for years—”

“Probably decades.”

“I’ve had a month. It’s just... a lot.”

“I understand.” He took her hand in his—the one that stopped the zip—and kissed the backs of her fingers. “And when you’re ready, maybe we can actually write the profile together.”

“Yes, let’s do that.”

“And you know what else we’re going to need for the profile, right?”

“What?” she asked.

“Photos!”

“I am *not* putting photos of myself on some random internet site.”

“Not so random. And we’ll make sure they can’t identify you.”

“If you want to scare away any potential guys, just put pics of this old body out there.”

“Oh please,” Stephen made a face and waved. “You know that’s not true at all.”

“I can’t compete with anyone in their 20s. Or even 30s or 40s—”

“Not true. And deep down, you know it.”

Julianna was used to this kind of flattery from her husband, but it still felt good. He took her hand and pulled her towards the stairs.

“Where are we going? Dinner—”

“Can wait. I need to prove something to you.”

STEPHEN SNAPPED a photo of Julianna at the bathroom sink, applying lipstick, before she chased him out. He sat on the edge of the bed and waited, his heart racing as he studied the candid shot.

It wasn't just that she was beautiful. She definitely was that. Her statement about competing with women in their 20s came back to him, as it always did, because that's what made her exceptional. Those girls didn't need to try. Their youthful beauty came almost effortlessly. Julianna had to work hard to stay trim and sexy, and that effort made everything so much more meaningful.

She was also his partner. He looked at the photo of her in her lacy black boyshorts, her garter belt, her push-up bra, and remembered the first time she modeled it a decade before, when the two of them had left Garrett with Stephen's mom and taken a trip to Estes Park. They were celebrating Stephen's 50th, and Julianna had gone all out to make it extra special.

The perfume she wore reminded him of a trip to New York in their early 30s, when she'd first discovered it in the Macy's cosmetics department. Even the shade of lipstick that she was applying reminded him of dates they'd shared over the years, which got him thinking about dates she might have in the future... with other men.

He knew he needed to pump the brakes some. He knew that his relentless pursuit of this hotwife fantasy—a thing that he'd been terrified to even admit to himself a month ago—was getting under his wife's skin. But he couldn't stop.

“I kissed him.” Was that how she'd phrased it? She'd kissed another man in Phoenix. After decades together, that was a huge step. Maybe it wasn't the pace of some of the hotwife books and stories that were out

there, but it still made him light-headed every time he remembered the confession. It also made him hard, even now.

“Okay, how’s this?” Julianna’s question pulled him out of his reverie. He looked up at her, standing in the doorway with the poise of the model she had once been.

“Wow,” Stephen said, drinking her in—and imagining that guy from Arizona, Anthony, doing the same.

She’d left her russet brown hair loose. It fell just above her shoulders in rich waves, and her pose seemed designed to accentuate her curves.

He lifted his phone and took a photo, and this time, she didn’t wave him away. This time, she sauntered into the bedroom, her smile bright, her face flushed—two dead giveaways that she was more than ready for what they were about to do.

“I’m not sure how you talked me into this,” she said.

Stephen wasn’t sure, either, but he was going with it. “You listened. You love me,” he said simply, gesturing towards the bed.

“I’m beginning to question the importance of listening in a relationship,” she said, her smile wry. But she glided over to the bed anyway, climbing up into the middle and folding her legs beneath her.

Her doubtful demeanor actually helped dispel some of Stephen’s nervousness. “That’s, uh... that’s perfect,” he said as she arranged her hair off of her cheek. He took a quick snapshot of it, then glanced down at his phone to check his work.

The image caught her in a half-blink. Not good. “What?” she asked, seeing his face.

“Nothing, just...” He tried again. “Just getting the hang of this phone.”

This photo was better, although it also perfectly captured her skepticism. In it, she stared up at the camera, one brow raised as if asking again, *“I’m not sure how you talked me into this.”*

It made him laugh.

“What, Stephen? Come on, let me see?”

He made sure to delete the first image before walking over to her and showing her the shot. To his relief, she started laughing. “Yeah, that’s just about right,” she agreed, nodding at the photo. “Not bad, but I look old.”

“You look amazing, Jules. Seriously.” He stood up again. “Now, maybe smile?”

“Why? I thought you said we weren’t going to use any shots of my face?”

They’d agreed to keep her privacy in the online profile, but he still wanted some shots for himself. “Just smile, okay, Julianna?”

She put on the most fake smile she could. “Perfect,” he said. Yet after a few shots, her fake smile slipped into a real one. He didn’t try to direct her, just let her pose as he moved around her.

“I think you have enough, don’t you?” she asked, looking at him over her shoulder.

“Maybe. But... what if you take off the bra.”

“I don’t think so,” she said, but once again, she was smiling.

“Think about doing this for Anthony.” Stephen said it before he lost his nerve, and was pleased to see the color spring into his wife’s cheeks.

“That is *not* happening.”

“I don’t know,” he said. “I kind of think that it is.”

Still, she reached behind her and unfastened her bra, and Stephen had to take a steadying breath, silently thanking her for playing along.

“You can never show these photos to anyone,” she said sternly, even as he started snapping pics that captured the side swell of her breast. She draped a hand across her nipples as she turned to him. “Promise me.”

“I promise. Of course, of course. Anything.” He licked his lips, but even still, she didn’t immediately lower her arm. She did lie back on the bed, though, her breasts somehow looking larger and fuller as they swelled over her arm.

Stephen climbed up onto the bed, balancing on the springy material to take a photo of her from above. When he wobbled, Julianna laughed. “You better not fall and break something doing this,” she warned. “Not sure how we’ll explain *this* one in the ER.”

“Sometimes true art requires sacrifice,” he said. His instincts were correct. She looked great from above, her hair fanned out around her, one leg draped over the other, tantalizing with her barely covered breasts.

She turned onto her back, giving him another view of her topless form. He snapped some more photos before hopping off the bed and moving down, in line with her face. Her smile was genuine now, like she was getting more into it than she cared to admit. She lifted up enough to show the deep well of her cleavage as she rested her head on her elbows and smiled.

He knew right away that this one was a keeper. Her dark eyes danced with mischief, her expression vibrant, engaged, and beneath, the hint of her nipples. It wasn’t a photo he’d ever be able to share, but one he knew he’d look back on for years to come.

She reached for him, taking the phone away. “Come on,” she said. “We’re done, right?”

Stephen could have gone on forever, but he saw the playfulness in her expression. He couldn’t deny that. Nor did he want to. “For now,” he said. “I think we have enough.”

“Good,” she said, drawing him close. He kissed her, and she readily accepted his mouth. “I’m getting cold.”

Stephen laughed with her as he climbed onto the bed once again. She rolled onto her back, exposing her bare breasts to him for the first time. Her nipples were hard. “I can see that,” he commented. “Let me help warm you up.”

Before she could roll her eyes, he climbed over her and kissed her on the mouth. For all her resistance to the photo shoot, she kissed him back

with the same enthusiasm that had been coursing through him all evening, every evening, ever since Arizona. Stephen could feel her hum with pleasure against his lips, and when she ran her hands along his back, he knew she was game.

He was probably wrong, but he liked to think that at least a part of her was considering his fantasy—that as she felt the weight of him over her, she was thinking of someone else on her. He sat up and together they pulled his shirt off.

She ran her hands over his bare chest, tracing the pecs that he worked so hard to keep toned. He did it for her, mostly, and whenever he felt like skipping a gym session to watch television, he thought about the Anthonys of the world and found his motivation. Yet despite all that, it still turned him on to think that maybe his considerable extra effort still just wasn't enough. That was the cuckold paradox.

"You're hard," Julianna whispered as she reached down between his legs.

"Maybe I'm just cold, too."

"Ha!"

She tugged at his pants. He helped her out, freeing his dick. "Very... cold."

Stephen caressed the exposed skin between her panties and stockings. "Love this."

"At least someone does." Julianna hated the snaps of garters, no matter how much Stephen told her it was worth it.

"Not just me." He ran his hand up over her boyshorts, which she'd put over the garters. He always loved that detail—that she was ready for sex, but also not something that he'd taught her. No, she'd learned to do that at some point before him. He dragged her panties down, and he could smell her excitement. "They look great in photos."

He wanted to take a photo of her right now, her legs spread, naked except for the garter belt and stockings. She'd even touched up her landing strip, the dark slash of hair neat and sexy above her glistening, bare lips.

"No, you're not—" she said as he grabbed his phone again.

"Yes, I definitely am."

It wasn't the best nude, but it encapsulated their relationship perfectly. Julianna was laughing, holding her hands out, arms straight as if warding off paparazzi. But her hands didn't hide her bright smile just behind her fingers.

More than that, she was so comfortably sexy. It was what had always struck him most about her. Her beauty was effortless, despite knowing how much effort she put into it.

"Delete that," she said.

"Never." He locked his phone and tucked it out of reach. "That one's just about perfect."

"Stephen." There was a hint of warning in her voice.

"I won't share it. I promise. But you have to let me keep it." He slipped up at her side this time, and she rolled to meet him. "Thank you for indulging me, Jules."

"I still don't get it, you know," she said. She climbed over him, taking his dick and guiding it against her smooth gash. She didn't get it, no, but something had her worked up. Maybe it was just his excitement. Sinking down onto him, she shuddered and sighed. "But you clearly aren't faking this."

"No."

"Unless you got some blue pill help?" She opened one eye to check him out.

"No help, other than the thought of... new adventures."

Julianna giggled, but kept any further quips to herself. She began to ride him with renewed vigor, her initial hesitation giving way to something more

primal. He marveled at the sight of her body, her curves accentuated by the mood lighting of their amateur photo shoot. Each roll of her hips sent shockwaves of pleasure coursing through his body, his cock throbbing within her tight embrace. He imagined another man seeing her like this, experiencing her raw beauty, feeling her wet pussy wrapped around his dick.

Stephen reached up, capturing her breasts in his hands, feeling their weight as he thumbed her hardened nipples. Julianna's gasp of pleasure spurred him to sit up and capture one taut peak between his lips. He sucked and nibbled, encouraged by her keening moan.

The taste of her skin, salty with sweat and musky with desire, was intoxicating. Stephen trailed his lips along the column of her neck. She shivered beneath his touch. "I want to watch you with someone else," he whispered.

She didn't protest this time. She only moaned, her eyes still shut, perhaps even imagining that she was with someone else.

"I want to see another man worship you, to pleasure you, to make you come."

He'd wanted to tell her that for so long, yet couldn't. Even now, he worried that there would be repercussions, but his cock was now fully in control. His balls were boiling. His time was nearly at an end.

So was Julianna's. He could feel her inner walls flutter around him, her body responding to his deep, dark confession. He thrust upward, meeting her downward strokes with increasing urgency. He held her close, pulling her body to his as they rutted through the last moments.

Julianna pulled her head back, her scream of release filling the room. Stephen finally let go of his own restraint. His orgasm tore through him, his seed pulsing deep into her as they clung to each other, riding out the waves of their mutual ecstasy.

At last, Julianna collapsed onto him, taking in deep, heaving breaths. As he held her close, he realized just how sweaty they were now. He was going to be sore in the morning. It had been a long time since they'd had such vigorous sex.

"I'm going to be sore tomorrow," she said, echoing his thoughts. Stephen laughed.

"Then we'll need to keep practicing."

Stephen's fantasy still hung in the air between them, his words still ringing in his ears—*I want to watch you with someone else.*

"Practicing," Julianna said. "And talking. This is good, Baby." She kissed him. "But also, you better not share that photo."

"Nothing will be shared that we both don't agree to," he said. "We go into this together. Always."

I am a vivacious and confident woman in her prime, looking to add some excitement to my life without disrupting my stable marriage. With a zest for life and a youthful spirit, I believe in embracing every opportunity for growth and pleasure. I'm not interested in emotional entanglements or drama, just mutually satisfying encounters with like-minded individuals who appreciate the finer things in life.

“How’s that?” Stephen asked.

They’d been workshopping the profile description together for a few weeks now, and Stephen seemed to be doing a better job not pushing it all the time. Julianna appreciated the restraint, although she still wasn’t super sure about any of it.

“It’s better than when we started,” she offered. “‘Mutually satisfying encounters with like-minded individuals’ sounds a bit stiff.”

Also, is that really what she was looking for? Before all of this started, she definitely would have said no way. But Stephen’s persistence—even the more restrained version of it—must have been wearing her down.

Stephen typed away at the computer on the kitchen table as Julianna was depositing checks via her phone, grumbling as the online checking app failed to recognize the images. Many of her clients paid by check, which Stephen found quaint.

She adjusted her reading glasses and tried again to take a photo, her tongue escaping the corner of her mouth in concentration.

“How about this,” he said. “*‘I’m not interested in emotional entanglements or drama’—*”

“That’s definitely true,” she said, not looking up from her work.

Stephen continued without pause. “—*‘just a good time with a good looking man who knows how to show me a good time.’*”

“Excessive use of ‘good’. Don’t you think?”

“I was trying to be poetic.” Stephen didn’t look wounded at all. He was used to her.

“It’s better.” She closed her checkbook and folded the last of the bills, then took off her glasses.

“Uh oh,” he said, recognizing the gesture. It said, *Time for a Serious Talk*.

“When did this all start?”

“This, as in—”

“Your fantasy. About me and other men.” It still made her flush to say, every single time. Just uttering it aloud was like a transgression. She could never do that. Never. Not actually.

Stephen hesitated.

“Help me understand.” She reached across the table and clasped his hands in hers. She ran her thumb along his wedding band, feeling the bumps and scratches etched in the soft gold. Their hands were no longer those of unblemished youth, but they were familiar. Her own wedding ring glimmered in the kitchen light. “It’s okay, Stephen. I’m not going to judge, but I do want to understand.”

“Honestly, it’s probably been there since almost the beginning.” At first, he kept his eyes on their hands, and when he did look up at her, it was with those bashful eyes of the man she’d fallen for. She still remembered how out of place that looked in the eyes of this burly construction worker. Now,

he fell into an uneasy smile as he pressed on. “You remember that time we were out at Nines?”

She vaguely remembered a lounge by that name, back when they lived in the city, but couldn’t remember anything remarkable about it. She shook her head.

“That’s so funny, because I can still remember it so vividly.” He shut his eyes, as if sinking into his memory. “We’d just started dating. You were 22, and I finally realized that you were no longer my friend’s kid sister, but this vibrant—and hot—woman who I was starting to fall for...”

She shook her head, still not remembering the night.

“You wore this short... skater dress, I think they’re called? Casual and cool yet so sexy. It was made of that crushed velvet material that was so popular back then. Maroon. And your hair was so long at the time.”

“Wow, I don’t remember any of this.” She felt bad as soon as she said it, watching Stephen grimace. Clearly the night meant something to him. “I’m sorry. Go on.”

“It wasn’t really anything so dramatic. I got held up, you arrived first. By the time I got there, you were at the bar chatting with some guy, and I just felt... unworthy.”

“What did I do?”

“As soon as you saw me, you dismissed the guy. I felt silly for feeling any jealousy at all.”

“But it still stuck with you,” she said. One thing still confused her though. “So that’s when you realized you wanted me to sleep with other men?”

Stephen’s face went bright red. “Oh, no. That was years in the making. No, the Nines incident was the first step on a long journey.”

“So help me understand it. Be my guide, Stephen. When did it go from jealousy to something else?”

“There were so many little moments, but...” His eyes darted back and forth as he searched his memory—or perhaps his courage. “But maybe there were a few standouts.”

She was quiet, giving him space to go on.

“I think maybe the first time that things started to change was when we ran into your old... friend, Aiden.”

Now it was Julianna’s time to feel the heat along her face. Aiden Stone was a photographer she’d met while modeling, and had a brief fling with in the time before Stephen entered her life. This was an encounter that she *did* remember. Quite vividly. Aiden had that kind of effect.

Stephen picked up on that flicker of recognition, too, making Julianna blush even more. “It was like a year into our marriage,” he said. “And we were at some gallery opening. You were wearing this sleek black dress.”

“I remember that dress,” she said. She remembered how it was backless, and how exposed she felt wearing it.

“We were standing in front of this really provocative photo, trying to figure out what it was, when he came up behind us. ‘Stunning piece, isn’t it?’ I remember him saying, but his eyes were on you, not the photo.”

“I remember that night,” Julianna whispered.

“Me too.”

“STUNNING PIECE, ISN’T IT?”

The man’s voice wasn’t especially deep or resonant, but Stephen was struck by how confident he was. When he glanced over, Stephen was caught off guard by the way this guy’s eyes lingered on the bare skin of Julianna’s back. It was like he was recalling a memory, and in that moment, Stephen knew that they’d been lovers once.

Julianna turned, seemingly taken aback. “Aiden?”

“It hasn’t been *that* long,” the man said, running his fingers through his thick, dark hair. He was a little older than the two of them at the time—early 30s, perhaps—but Stephen remembered thinking how sophisticated and worldly this guy was. He seemed to notice Stephen standing there, but didn’t move to introduce himself. He just turned back to Julianna and said, “You look amazing, as always.”

“Thanks.” She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear and preened under the attention. She seemed to remember Stephen—or maybe he just imagined the lapse in time. “Aiden, this is my husband, Stephen. Stephen, this is Aiden. We... worked together a few years back.”

There was definitely a hesitation there, and that sent a sickening jolt through Stephen’s core.

“Aiden’s a photographer,” Julianna rushed on.

“Nice to meet you, Aiden.” Stephen was proud of himself for not hesitating to hold out his hand. This guy may have fucked his wife back before they were a thing, but she’d ended up with him in the end. “Did you ever shoot with Julianna?”

“A few times, yes,” Aiden said with an unreadable smile. “She’s a great subject. As I’m sure you know.”

“Oh, for sure.”

“You two, please stop,” Julianna said with a blushing laugh. “Aiden, do you have anything in tonight’s show?”

“I do, actually. Far side. Just a few pieces I’m working on.”

“That’s wonderful, Aid.”

Aid. The familiarity in that nickname sent Stephen spiraling, if just a little bit. Thank goodness he’d already had a glass of wine.

“Is it as provocative as this one?” Stephen asked.

Aiden squinted at the enlarged photograph, which Stephen was pretty sure was a closeup of a woman’s inner thigh. “No, not quite,” he chuckled. “This may be a good conversational piece, but the people here aren’t going

to buy something like this, and while I like to think of myself as an artist, I also have bills.”

“You’ve grown up some,” Julianna said.

Aiden scratched the back of his neck and looked a bit sheepish. “We all need to grow up, you know? You probably helped me realize that.”

There had been men who hit on Julianna while they’d been together—incidents like the one at Nines that amounted to nothing. This was the first time Stephen had met an ex, though, and his reaction was not what he’d expected. The jealousy was there, sickening like an overripe melon. He didn’t even need to close his eyes to imagine Julianna gasp this man’s name as he climbed over her naked body.

But in that image, raw and unwanted, he felt something new—arousal. A whole scene grew out of the queasy sensation. She was in a studio, wearing nothing but a sheet over her lithe body as he circled her with his camera, making eyes at him, smiling that bright, welcoming smile. He’d tell her to strip. She would. He’d get closer, on the bed, over her. He’d put the camera down as she tugged him close and kissed him and—

“Stephen?”

“Hm? Oh, sorry, must have zoned out.”

Julianna was studying him with concern when he blinked away the daydream.

“Sorry, the wine and the long day are just catching up with me. I’m going to go track down some coffee. I’ll catch up with you two.”

It was a reckless thing to suggest, but he really was drunk and tired and not thinking entirely rationally. Call it self-loathing or self-pitying, but at that moment, Stephen was in the mood for a self-inflicted wound.

Julianna wasn’t having it, although she didn’t know exactly what was going on. “It’s okay, we can head out, honey.”

“We just got here. It’s fine.” Stephen still didn’t understand why he was arguing for this, but like the stubborn man that he was, once decided, he

bullishly pressed on. He was already back away from them. “I’ll catch up.”

He turned his back on a thoroughly confused Julianna before he lost his nerve, then went off in search of the bar, leaving Julianna alone with her charming ex-lover.

There was no coffee, but for better or worse, there was more wine. He swiped one of those, made himself scarce on the opposite side of the gallery from the two of them, and tried to reflect on what was going on.

Julianna was gorgeous. He’d married up. She was once a model, and he was just a construction worker at the time, going to night school for his MBA. She rubbed shoulders—and a whole lot more—with the kind of people who attended art gallery openings such as this one, or had pieces in art galleries. This was her world—or could be. It was at this time in their relationship that he really started to wonder if he was holding her back.

And he didn’t want to do that. He loved her. He wanted her to live her best life.

So he found himself stretching out his time at the bar, choosing to stand in the longest line, taking his drink over to the art pieces close to them and observing them without actually seeing a thing. This became very clear when a pretty blond came over and said to him, “I think it’s sexy. You?”

The way she looked at him was full of suggestion and innuendo—or so his wine-lubricated brain interpreted. “Uh, yeah, I... I don’t really see it.”

She had sharp, dark eyebrows that rose into her platinum bangs as she smiled at him, and as flattering as it was to be hit on by this woman, he mostly felt guilty. Also, he realized that this wasn’t the way that Julianna had been acting with Aiden at all. Aiden may have been his wife’s ex-lover, but what he’d thought was flirtation was merely politeness, or old familiarity.

“I’m sorry, I need to...” And he shuffled off before he could finish that sentence.

Stephen spotted the two before the crowd. They were standing before a painting, rather than a photograph, and Stephen slowed his approach as he watched their interaction. His heart raced as Aiden leaned in close, whispering something that made Julianna laugh and blush. Stephen wanted to rush in—but he also wanted to watch, to see where this went, his insecurities and desires clashing.

Aiden said something to her again, and Julianna seemed to hesitate. Stephen's mind went to the darkest places—did he ask her if she wanted to get out of there, to find somewhere more private? Or was he simply telling her that she could do better?

Julianna looked around, scanning the crowd, and finally she saw Stephen there. Relief seemed to flood through her, just as embarrassment raced through him. “There you are,” she said, her mouth forming the words even before Stephen could actually hear them through the din.

“I couldn't find any coffee,” Stephen said lamely. He felt like he'd been caught red-handed, that she could look at him and see that he'd been spying and read his confused emotions. That she was judging him for wanting to watch her flirt with her old lover.

But Julianna didn't see any of that. Instead, she saw her husband and her true love and the insecurities that *she* had caused when she was at an old boyfriend's side.

“We were going to get a cigarette,” Aiden said to Stephen. “The gallery doesn't let anyone smoke inside.”

So they weren't going to go someplace quiet to fuck.

“You smoke?” Aiden asked.

“Uh, no.” And neither did he think Julianna did.

“I'm actually kind of tired myself,” Julianna said, linking her arm into Stephen's. “You didn't find coffee, did you?”

“No, just more wine.”

Julianna's laugh was musical as ever, but Stephen detected the forced note in it. "Then I'll drive. Ready?"

A part of him was sad to let this dynamic go. Another part was already wondering when it would happen again, and couldn't wait to feel that sickly, sticky, delicious jealousy all over again.

"Ready."

"It was nice catching up with you, Aiden. Good luck selling your photos."

"Good to see you, too, Julianna. And Stephen, take care of her."

In the car, before turning the ignition on, Julianna ran her hand along the inside of his thigh and said, "You know you have nothing to worry about, right?"

"Uh, what do you mean?"

"I know you were jealous, and... I just want you to know that... you don't ever have to worry about that. I'd never..."

Cheat. She couldn't even say it. And yet, a part of him wanted to hear her say it, like a trigger word. Instead, he forced a smile as his emotions continued to churn.

"I know. I'm sorry that I get like that," he said, although he rode the angst all the way back to their home, and all the way up to their bedroom.

Alone, amidst their familiar things, Stephen pulled Julianna into a searing kiss—the kind that he imagined Aiden used to give her. His hands roamed her curves, traced her hair back the way Aiden had been dying to do all night long.

She responded eagerly, hurriedly, kissing him back, tugging at his clothes, eager to feel skin on skin. Stephen laid her back on the bed, trailing kisses along her collarbone before capturing a pert nipple in his mouth. It swelled and hardened, Julianna's fingers tracing through his hair—thinning even back then. She arched into his touch, moaning, filling his mouth with her breast.

Behind his closed eyes, he became his wife's former lover. He grazed her nipples with his teeth, drawing a sharp gasp, before surging over her and kissing her hard. Her hands caressed him, tugged at him, groped his ass in a way that he swore she didn't normally do. When he entered her, he wondered if she was thinking about Aiden plunging into her. When she wrapped her legs around him, pulling him deeper, he wondered if this is how Aiden had fucked her.

Their lovemaking was fierce and primal, fueled by the night's emotional undercurrents. Stephen pounded into her relentlessly, imagining that he was both Aiden from the past and Stephen from the present, there to reclaim his wife. Julianna was just as ardent, meeting him thrust for thrust, urging him on with breathy pleas and nails digging into his back. They reached their peak together, bodies locked tight as wave after wave of ecstasy crashed over them.

Afterward, they lay entwined, hearts racing and limbs heavy with satisfaction. Julianna traced patterns on Stephen's chest, a contented smile on her face. "Mmm, that was fun. I should take you to gallery openings more often."

Stephen chuckled, keeping his tumultuous thoughts to himself.

"I REMEMBER THAT NIGHT," Julianna said quietly after listening to Stephen's story. "But I had no idea that's how you felt. I just felt bad about making you jealous."

In the days and weeks that followed the gallery event, Julianna had gone out of her way to make Stephen feel better, gingerly reassuring him that she loved *him*. She turned down invitations that don't include him, dressed more conservatively, and showered him with affection.

“I know. And that kind of set us on this path,” he said. “I should have said more, but you and I... we never really talked about that stuff. I was so afraid of what you’d think of me if I told you that deep down, I kind of ached for the thrill of uncertainty. That’s when I thought back on you laughing at whatever Aiden had said, or what would have happened if you’d gone and had that cigarette with him...”

“Nothing would have happened,” she said.

“I know, but you see? That’s kind of where my head was at. Maybe still is at.”

“Clearly. You’re still leaving me alone with good looking men,” she said dryly.

Stephen flushed. “Is it a pattern if it happens thirty years apart?”

“I’m sure if we thought about it, there are other moments when you set me up.”

He licked his lips, eager to move them along. “So what *did* he say to you at that gallery opening? Something that made you blush.”

“Honestly, I have no idea. Probably something about the photo being dirty.”

“Really? You don’t remember?”

“He... he told me that I should shoot with him again. For old times.”

Even now, decades later, her confession made him feel dizzy, washing over him like a blaze of heat. “What did you tell him?”

“I told him no, of course. I reminded him that I was married.” She clasped his hand in hers. “But you didn’t think I would, did you?”

“I... I don’t know. I don’t think I did.”

“So you started to build up a defense mechanism after that. Your fantasy of me with other men?”

He was quiet. She was slowly starting to understand, but it was still difficult.

“Stephen?”

“Yes?”

“Please don’t leave me alone anymore, okay? Don’t leave me out of your thoughts? I don’t want to live my life without you. I haven’t built these last three decades with you because I was settling, okay?”

He nodded, meeting her eyes. “Okay, yes. And I get that.”

“Yet you still want me to put my profile online for other men to read?”

Her heart hopped and bounced at her own question, and she could tell that Stephen’s was doing the same.

“Yes.”

“Then let’s do it. Together.”

Hello, Gentlemen,

I am a vivacious and confident woman in her prime, looking to add some excitement to my life without disrupting my stable marriage. I'm married, and intend to stay married. No drama, no emotional entanglements, no strings.

My husband knows about this profile, and chances are will read any messages that you send me. He supports me, he loves me, we have a good sex life, and none of that will ever change=.

So why have a profile here at all? For adventure and excitement. Variety and new experiences add an element to our relationship. I get to meet new people. He gets to hear stories about those encounters.

I'm looking for a handsome man who understands the value of discretion and respect. Someone who can engage me intellectually as well as physically.

I am looking for a man who practices good grooming habits, is fit, and isn't overweight. No judgment or body shaming, I am just stating what I'm looking for. Please be honest and save us all some time. Profiles must feature up-to-date photos. Do not send me a picture of your dick!

I travel for work, and will not meet you in my hometown.

If you're seeking a sophisticated arrangement with no strings attached, let's connect and see where our chemistry takes us.

Stephen read the profile over again, tweaking a word here, adding a comma there. He liked it. A bit wordy, but it captured his wife well.

They'd written it together, more or less, and that was the most fun part of the experience. She'd laughed out loud when she told him to add the restriction on dick pics, still finding it hilarious that anyone would send her, of all people, something so vulgar.

For Stephen, the thought was slightly more hysterical than funny. The idea was absolutely mind-blowing.

Ultimately, though, the experience ended in the disappointment that he'd expected. "So when should we post this?" he'd asked last night as they crawled into bed.

Julianna was reading off of the Kindle, glasses on, makeup scrubbed?

"Post what?"

"Your profile."

"Oh." She set the Kindle down. "Wait, you were serious about actually... putting it online?"

If he was a balloon, now was the moment that he became untethered, air whipping him about the room. "Um, I guess, yes?" He slumped into himself, a red and blushing mess. "I mean, you know, just to see what happens."

Julianna was quiet a long moment. Stephen could have just let it go—probably should have. But they'd come too far to put it all back into a box. He turned to her, sidling closer, resting a hand on her hip.

"What if someone that knows us sees the profile?" she blurted to the ceiling, then looked at him.

"How would they know it's you? We'll just make sure to crop out your head in any photos."

"What if they recognize my, like, clothes?"

Stephen grinned. “Then let’s use just the lingerie ones. No one should recognize those, right?”

Julianna glanced at him, catching him smirking. “Of course not. But they may recognize the furniture. Stephen, this seems like a really bad idea just to get some photos of male genitalia when I have everything I want,” she slipped a hand between his legs, “right here.” She met his eyes. “And you’re turned on.”

“Just the idea of it... even just *talking* about a profile—not even what comes next—is so hot, Julianna.”

She still looked skeptical, but he could tell that she was slowly caving. It was the look that she’d given him back when he turned 50 and had wanted a Corvette. He still had the silvery white Z06 in the garage, and one of his favorite memories of it was looking over to see Julianna’s hair dancing wildly in the wind as they cruised along with the top down.

So he pressed just a little more. “Just think about it, okay? Don’t totally dismiss the possibility. It’ll be a fun thing we can do, the two of us.”

AND THINK ABOUT IT, Julianna definitely did. She couldn’t stop thinking about it. It was a crazy idea. She’d been with this man for three decades, with no intention of ever changing that. The day that he’d asked her to marry him was the happiest day of her life. She’d said yes without hesitation. She knew that Stephen was the kind of partner she wanted to spend her life with.

It hadn’t always been smooth. They’d had their bumps. No relationship was that smooth, but compared to many of their friends, their dips weren’t so serious. Stephen had been laid off just after Garrett was born, but that had led to him forming his own construction company, and all the success that came after.

They'd bickered over household responsibilities, and Julianna could still remember the argument they had when Garrett wanted to quit the soccer team mid-year and Stephen made him play it out despite hating it.

But the biggest issues they had were around communication. They were good when they agreed on things, which was most things—politics, travel, sometimes movie preferences. But when they weren't on the same page, their default was just not to talk about it. Sex was like that. It was always good, but they rarely got into their fantasies.

Now that Stephen had opened up about his, she didn't want to dismiss it. That didn't mean she was ready to jump into bed with a random dude, either.

Julianna worked as an occupational therapist, but at this point in her career, she didn't have many shifts at the hospital or the local clinic anymore. She traveled and consulted mostly, training others across the country. She always enjoyed traveling, so when this job opened up with her company a couple years ago, she'd jumped at it. At the time, it had helped her deal with the empty nest. Now, she just liked the new experiences.

But in hindsight, knowing what she knew about Stephen's proclivities, all of her travel had to play into his insecurities and fantasies. She'd been on the road for a few days, and he must have been at home, thinking about all the guys hitting on her and getting all angsty.

Thing was, he wasn't wrong about the guys. They'd always been there, although most had kept their professionalism, or had been steered away by a flash of her ring. Not all, though. Before Phoenix and the profile and Stephen's confession, she'd never thought much about any of it. After, though, everything felt so much more charged.

"You're really good at this." The compliment came from Noah Blake, the coordinator of this afternoon's workshop. Julianna was local today, a guest speaker at the college on the other side of town, but she'd not met Noah before.

“Anyone can get good at something if you’ve been doing it as long as I have.”

“Please, you know that’s not true.” Noah was probably ten years her junior. She liked the laugh lines around his dark eyes, and he had an easy-going confidence that came from teaching. He also didn’t have a ring on. It was a detail that Julianna never would have looked for until recently, and she found herself embarrassed when he caught her looking.

“Um, so, thank you for inviting me,” she stammered, brushing a strand of dark, red hair across her forehead. “You’ve got a good group here. Hope at least one goes on to be an OT. We could definitely use more.”

Noah nodded. Mercifully, he didn’t say anything inappropriate. He didn’t ask her for a drink or ask for her number. But he didn’t let her off the hook entirely. “Hope to work with you again, Julianna. It’s been the highlight of my week so far.”

She smiled wanly at him and practically fled to her Jeep.

That kind of attention wasn’t new to Julianna, but her evolving reaction to it certainly was. For the first time in her long years as a married woman, she’d started to wonder what it would be like to be receptive to those subtle advances. If Noah had asked her to get coffee, what would have happened if she’d said yes?

She made sure that even in her imagination, her hypothetical answer to that was vague—laughter, the hint of cologne, a hand in hers. She expelled the thoughts before things got too hot, but the heat still lingered and her heart still raced.

She wasn’t ready to share any of this with Stephen. She knew how he’d get—it would be like pouring gasoline on an open fire. But she suspected that he sensed her shift. When they’d go out, he’d notice her noticing the lingering stares around her, the subtle double-takes of men whenever she wore something even marginally tight.

He showed more self-restraint than usual, though, and kept his comments to himself.

Then, one day she was replying to emails at a coffee shop between appointments when she looked up and met the eyes of a guy at the next table over. For a second, she thought that he was Anthony, her Phoenix friend, with his dark hair and the hint of gray, with his strong jaw and dark eyes. But his nose was wrong, and when he spoke, his voice didn't match what she remembered.

"Hey, I've seen you in here before. Good place to get some work in."

It's funny, but she'd never noticed him before. "Yeah, it's a convenient spot," Julianna answered neutrally. "And the coffee's better than Starbucks."

"Not a high bar to pass," the stranger said, "but I definitely agree."

She had these kinds of exchanges all the time. Normally, she'd think nothing of it. She'd smile, go back to her emails, and that would be that. Only this time, she saw the invitation in his smile. She felt the possibility in the way that he looked at her, his eyes trained on hers, resisting the urge to check her out more openly. A ripple of excitement zipped down her spine.

"I'm Julianna," she found herself saying.

"Jonathan," the guy introduced. She liked his smile. "Nice to put a name to a pretty face, Julianna."

A thrill ran through her at the compliment. She could have this man, she realized. She could lean in and ask him if he wanted to get out of there, and he'd probably go. No ring, she noticed, and he picked up on her furtive eyes. When he smiled, she grew warm and almost giddy.

"So you're here often?" she asked, chasing away her nerves.

"Often enough to start to notice the regulars, I suppose."

As they made small talk, Julianna felt like she was right back on the plane with Anthony. Only back then, it had been harmless. There were no stakes. She didn't know what she did now. Talking to Jonathan, she couldn't

shake the idea that all it would take was a mere suggestion and things could get so much steamier.

“God, look at the time,” he said, checking his watch for the first time. “Damn meetings, always getting in the way.”

Julianna felt both disappointment and relief—mostly relief, though. She was on the precipice of something, but didn’t want to go any further.

“It was nice to chat with you, Jonathan,” she said as he shut his own laptop.

When he rose, though, he paused first, leaning in close. Unlike Noah from the workshop, Jonathan does make an offer. “I shouldn’t say this, but you’re absolutely stunning, Julianna. If you ever want to grab a drink or something, I’d love to get to know you more.” He smiled one more time. “Hope to see you around here again.”

With that, he walked away, leaving Julianna a buzzing, sweaty, heart-pounding mess. She watched him push out through the doors of the coffee shop without looking back. As the door swung shut, she imagined what he would have been like to tell him yes. She shut her eyes, picturing his hands on her, his mouth trailing kisses down her neck.

“No,” she says aloud. The strength of her reaction surprised her, but it was just that—a reaction. No lines were crossed, but the possibility hung in the air, ripe with promise. She could have it. Stephen would be fine with it. Could she really do it?

Stephen had girded himself for disappointment, but the reality was still hard to swallow. She'd gone along with writing the profile, but apparently she'd never been serious about it. He also knew that if he pressed, it could backfire. Julianna could be stubborn, and they'd made so much progress since Phoenix that he didn't want to blow it.

Even still, this wild, destructive part of him had started to wonder if he should get in touch with Anthony. He'd kept the guy's card, so had his contact information. He knew that the owner of La Bella Cucina had been one of the only men to break through to her. Maybe the man could do it again.

But no. Stephen may have been eager, but he wasn't stupid. That was a line that he couldn't cross unless he was completely desperate.

So rather, he contented himself with daydreaming, wandering through his days, sometimes losing hope, sometimes gaining it. He reviewed his history with Julianna, lingering on those incidents like the Nines, when guys would hit on her right in his presence. He let it slowly torture him, thinking about that delicious, angsty melodrama.

He thought about Aiden, wondering what would have happened if he'd left her alone, the way he'd left her alone with Anthony. Nothing would have happened, most likely, but maybe something would have?

There was one other guy in her life that made his gut squirm even more than Aiden, though. Just thinking this man's name tickled like butterflies, even a decade later. Ethan Brooks.

This was just over 11 years ago. Julianna was 43. Stephen was about to turn 50. He was in the midst of a full-on midlife crisis. He was insecure about *everything*—he wasn't cool enough for his teenage son, he wasn't making enough to support their family, he was spending too much time at work and not enough time with Julianna.

At the same time, Julianna seemed to be blossoming. After years focused on motherhood and career, she started paying more attention to her appearance again. She wore more fitted clothing, started to style her hair. She wanted to feel desirable again.

It was around this time that she decided to get breast implants, partly motivated by this renewed focus on her femininity. "I want to feel confident and sexy in my own skin again," he remembered her telling him, and of course Stephen supported her.

It also made him even more self-conscious of his own inadequacies.

That's when he learned about Ethan Brooks, a young occupational therapist who Julianna had started mentoring at work. She'd mentioned him before in passing, and Stephen had even teased her about corrupting the rare male OT in an office mostly made up of women. She'd laughed it off, telling him he was being silly.

Then he picked her up at work one day and saw the guy standing outside of their clinic with her, and it was like the ground beneath his feet opened up and all of a sudden he was falling.

IT WAS the way she laughed that froze him. He was at a light across the street, waiting for it to turn green, when he saw Julianna standing beside

this tall, extremely handsome young man. Even at that distance Stephen could see his blue eyes and sandy blond hair, long without being shaggy, swept back in a crest that curled around his ears.

He knew immediately that this must be Ethan. She'd mentioned him in passing—something about how young he was, about how different the newer generations were. The way she'd talked about him, Stephen had pictured a literal child working at the clinic, like a Doogie Houser situation. This man was clearly not a child.

And he was making her laugh—laugh in a way that rippled through her whole body. She put a hand on his arm, as if to brace herself, and that level of physical comfort struck Stephen right in the gut.

The man said one last thing, offering Julianna a smile that brought out a pair of dimples, before walking away, towards the parking lot.

Someone honked behind Stephen. The light had turned green. Julianna looked towards the commotion, and Stephen swore she looked guilty as he pulled up to the curb. But she didn't say anything about the man she'd been chatting with, and Stephen was too afraid to ask about it.

But Stephen was now on high alert for all things related to Ethan Brooks, and because of that, he started to really notice that whenever she brought him up, she seemed to downplay anything remotely romantic between them, almost like she was going out of her way to make him seem like a friendly coworker.

Like how she walked in when Stephen was doing the dishes and said, "I need to stop taking you for granted."

"Hm?"

"Apparently Ethan's roommate is a total slob. Left a pile of dirty dishes in the sink for days. Poor guy snapped and cleaned them himself."

"Sounds familiar," Stephen joked. Julianna was bad, but not quite that bad. "So he's coming to you for domestic advice now, too?"

“Well, you know how it is. I told him he needs to set some ground rules or find a new place.”

Other stories that stuck out to Stephen seemed to feature Julianna proving to him that Ethan wasn’t really a threat. She talked about his dating life and the trials and tribulations of courting in the era of *Swipe Right*. “Apparently he was matched up with this girl on OkCupid who turned out to be a total catfish. Poor guy was so disappointed!”

“Wait, the girl was a guy?”

“Who knows. He/she was a no show, but that’s what Ethan suspects.” She slipped up close to him. “I don’t think I could do that these days. Too complicated.”

She didn’t talk about him often—no more than she talked about her boss, Helen, or her other colleagues, but each anecdote and story felt like a needle into Stephen’s core. He stopped teasing her about the guy, and started to wonder if maybe there was more going on there.

And then came the conference. Julianna brought it up so casually, not even mentioning that Ethan was going—certainly not mentioned that it was *only* her and Ethan going. “Hey, I forgot to mention that there’s this big conference coming up next month. Helen wants me to go for her, as she’s got the board meeting. Would you mind watching Garrett?”

“Not at all. Great opportunity for you.”

“I totally agree!” They were actually driving to the gym together, Julianna behind the wheel, her eyes fixed on the road as Stephen studied her. “It’ll be nice to do some networking and learning about the latest trends. Can’t let this old lady fall behind.”

“You need to stop with the ‘old lady’ thing,” he said. Then, as casually as he could, he asked the question that was really on his mind. “So who else from your team is going?”

He watched her face for a reaction, but she was so casual. “Oh, it’s a smaller conference. It’ll just be me. Oh, and maybe Ethan? Helen thinks it

would be good for him to get some professional development in, too.”

Stephen couldn’t tell if that was a flush climbing up her neck, and he didn’t know how to respond to any of it. So it would just be her and Ethan?

“I’m not sure how much time I’ll even see him. We’re going to split the seminar tracks, then meet up and compare notes. It’ll probably be pretty boring for him, to be honest. Lots of PowerPoint presentations and awkward small talk with strangers.”

“I don’t know,” Stephen found himself saying, watching her face as she clearly over-explained. “I think he’ll find something of interest while there.”

Julianna chose to ignore any innuendo. “Well, maybe I’m speaking for myself. I’d much rather stay home with you and Garrett.”

“I think it’ll be good for you, too,” he said, sliding a hand along her Lycra-clad thigh. “Breaks up the routine some.”

“I can think of other ways that we could do that,” she said, finally glancing at him as they stopped at a light. “Maybe when I’m back, we can plan a little weekend getaway, just the two of us? You keep promising me a trip to the Bahamas.”

“Now you’re talking. And that bikini I showed you online?”

“Scandalous, dear.” She laughed. “But for you, maybe?”

Despite the talk of their Caribbean trip, though, it was the conference that consumed Stephen over the next month. There was nothing suspicious going on. She barely mentioned Ethan again, but somewhere in the dark recesses of Stephen’s imagination, a wild thought started to take root: what if something *was* going on?

That hypothetical, more than any other—more than the flirtations and past boyfriends and guys at bars—forced him to confront his fantasy. He shouldn’t have wanted any of it. He *should* have been worried for the state of their marriage—and to be clear, he was. The rational side of him worried

and feared and turned his insides to soup. But there was a part of him that found the whole situation so arousing.

That part of him kept his mouth shut as she prepared for the flight, as she packed and gave him instructions on how to heat up the lasagna like he was a child.

“We’ll be fine;” he reassured as he drove her to the airport.

“Set the oven to 350, okay? Otherwise it’ll burn—”

“Seriously, Jules, it’ll be fine.” Even as he reassured, he wondered if she was nervous about leaving them alone, or for something else. And that “something else” had his heart racing. “It’s only two nights. Don’t worry about us. Focus on the conference, okay?”

She nodded. They kissed. He watched her walk into the airport wearing tight, black leggings that made her butt look wonderful. Would Ethan notice, too? Stephen drove away, hoping that the younger man would.

Those two days were delicious torture. He knew he was just fantasizing. He was certain that his wife would keep things professional with her mentee. But in the dark, when he was alone with his thoughts at night, he couldn’t help thinking about the two of them back at the hotel, also in the dark, naked and rutting against one another. He jerked off, thinking about it, but refused to let himself come.

They talked as usual. She texted him throughout the day, and called him and Garrett at night before bed. It was totally normal. She did all the things that she needed to do to keep him from getting paranoid, and yet it was precisely because she was doing all of those things that he got even more paranoid.

Then came the day that she was to come home. It was late morning on a work day, and Stephen originally had meetings that kept him from picking her up. The day before, though, he barely slept, tossing and turning as he thought about Julianna having her world rocked by Ethan and his tall, hard body.

Stephen realized that he didn't want to spend another minute without his wife. He didn't want to wait through the work day. He didn't even want to wait at home for her Uber to drop her off. He canceled his meetings, took a cold shower, and headed to the airport to surprise her.

Parking, he realized that it had been ages since either of them had actually gone *into* the airport to pick the other up. They were long past romantic gestures like that, and it felt good to do it now. He headed for the terminal exits, scanning the crowd for arriving passengers. He spotted her walking down the long ramp, dressed in tight, dark jeans and a tight sweater that hugged and accentuated her new silhouette.

And there, beside her, walked Ethan. Even from all the way across the concourse, Stephen recognized Ethan's sandy hair and broad shoulders. His stomach dropped. His scalp felt aflame. He shrank back, just a little, slipping behind a column. He hadn't called or texted ahead, telling Julianna that he was going to meet her. She didn't know.

He watched them approach, noticing the easy rapport between them. They seem so engrossed in conversation, their heads tilted close together as if sharing a private joke. Suddenly, Julianna stumbled slightly. Ethan's arm shot out, steadying her with a firm grip around her narrow waist.

The touch lingered for a beat too long, Ethan's hand resting on the curve of Julianna's hip. To anyone around, it was nothing. To Stephen, it was like a bolt of lightning right through the top of his head. He saw all of the charged and unspoken intimacy.

Before Stephen could react, and long before they got close enough to him, Julianna and Ethan parted ways with a warm hug. Again, the embrace felt one beat too long. Or maybe that was in his head. Then, Julianna was walking towards him, smiling to herself.

As Stephen watched his wife approach, he noticed a flicker of something cross her face when she spotted him. The look was gone in an instant, replaced by a brilliant smile, but Stephen couldn't shake the feeling

that it was... guilt. This was that moment from before, when he'd picked her up from work, and this time, he knew he wasn't imagining things.

Before he could process it, Julianna had her arms around him, pulling him in for a tight hug. Her body felt wonderful and warm and familiar against him. "I thought you had to work?" Her voice was breathless with surprise.

Stephen held her tightly, breathing in the scent of her hair. "Work can wait. I missed you so much," he murmured, his mind still reeling from the sight of Ethan's hand on her hip.

"Aw, I missed you, too." She kissed him, and it was a familiar, friendly kiss—the kind of kiss shared by two people who've been together for ages.

Stephen could barely focus during the walk to the car. His thoughts keep drifting back to the airport, to the easy familiarity between Julianna and Ethan. Walking along at his side, Julianna chatted away animatedly about the trip, filling him in on the conference highlights, apparently oblivious to her husband's state.

Had something happened between them? The rational part of him insisted 'no way.' But the look on Julianna's face when she first saw him...it hinted at secrets, at hidden desires.

Even if nothing physical happened, maybe Julianna fantasized herself during those long nights in her hotel room. Maybe she'd imagined Ethan's hands on her body, his mouth claiming hers—just like Stephen had. The thought sent a jolt of conflicting emotions through Stephen—jealousy, arousal, and a perverse sense of excitement.

And how did Stephen handle it? He bottled it up inside until years later, when they were finally able to talk about his fantasies. But if he had to pinpoint a time when his thoughts turned from paranoid fear to fantasy, it was that trip.

“CAN I ASK YOU SOMETHING?” Stephen said as Julianna walked into the house. He looked like he was going to be sick, and that, in turn, made her nervous. She’d still had her encounter with the guy from the coffee shop, Jonathan, on her mind—along with all of the other confusing thoughts that had swirled since Phoenix.

“Uh oh,” she said, forcing calm into her own voice. “Never a good thing when you need to ask permission to ask something.”

“You’re looking nice, by the way,” he said.

“Random compliment. Double uh oh.”

“It’s nothing. Just...” Stephen was blushing hard. This definitely wasn’t nothing, and he was making her even more nervous. Had he seen her flirting with Jonathan? “You know you can tell me anything, right? What I said back in Arizona, when you told me about Lori’s affair...”

She blinked, recalling the conversation. “How you said that if you were Luke, you would have forgiven me?”

“Yes. That. You believe me, right?”

“I, uh, do, yes. But honey, you don’t have to worry. You never do.” Then it occurred to her—he must have followed her, maybe had been for a while. Maybe he thought that she was seeing Jonathan regularly. She might not have noticed the guy, but perhaps Stephen had? “Is this about the guy from the coffee shop?”

Now it was Stephen’s turn to look thoroughly confused. “What? There’s a guy from a coffee shop?”

And now it was Julianna stammering. “No. I mean, yes, but not like *that*.” She grew even hotter as his eyes widened. She could practically see where his mind was going. “There was a guy, Jonathan, who kind of hit on me at the cafe I go to.”

“When?”

“Just today. Earlier. Between appointments.”

“What happened?” He wasn’t accusing her of being bad. He was so clearly into it, fixating like a PTA mom on the latest neighborhood gossip. She laughed, the tension breaking.

“Nothing really. Honestly. We just chatted a little and... and he complimented me.”

“What did he say?” Stephen’s eyes practically bored into hers.

“He called me stunning, or something.” *I shouldn’t say this, but you’re absolutely stunning, Julianna.* She couldn’t say it all out loud, feeling self-conscious, even as she blushed harder at his words. “Then he asked me if I wanted to get a drink.”

“No way! What did you say?” Juliana giggled at her husband’s excrement, knowing he’d like the second part.

“I told him no, of course.”

“But you could have said yes.”

Julianna found it as thrilling to think about as her husband clearly did. “But I didn’t.”

He looked... disappointed. Shouldn’t he look relieved? “So if that wasn’t it, what did you want to ask me?”

“Oh, right.” He scratched the back of his neck and winced.

“Just say it, Stephen. I won’t—”

“Do you ever sleep with Ethan?”

“What?” Julianna felt like she’d been struck. “How could you even ask that, Stephen. I’ve never...” She felt heat climb up her neck as she came to realize something. “But you’ve always thought that maybe I did.”

It wasn’t a question. This was a revelation, and Stephen confirmed it by casting his eyes at the floor.

“Oh, honey,” she said. She could have been angry—in almost any other circumstance, if he’d accused her of this, she would have been. But right now, all she saw was vulnerability. This question had been a decade in the asking.

“I wasn’t sure,” he mumbled. “You two were always... and there was that trip.”

Julianna’s chest fluttered at that. “Nothing ever happened between the two of us,” she said, seeing him deflate a little. “But...”

He perked up, looking at her. “But?”

She took his hand and pulled him close. “But it didn’t mean that I didn’t notice him looking.”

Stephen took a sharp, quiet breath. “Really?”

They moved to the sofa, cuddling together. She needed him close. She needed to be able to look him in the eyes as they talked about this.

“I actually may have had a little crush on him, too.”

“Really?”

“Let’s just say that if you and I weren’t together, and he didn’t work with me, maybe something could have happened.” She blushed at the confession—one that she could have only made recently, knowing what she knew now. “But I swear to you, nothing happened.”

“So you didn’t spend the nights with him at that conference?”

“Is that what you wanted to happen?”

“No,” he said. “Not rationally, but... also, is it weird that I’m a little disappointed that nothing did.”

Yes, definitely weird, she wanted to say. But that wasn’t the moment. “Makes me a little sad that you didn’t trust me.”

“Oh, honey, I do trust you. And I didn’t *really* think anything happened. But a part of me kind of got... excited.”

“A part of me got excited by Ethan, too.” She remembered the way he’d look at her. The way her heart would begin to race when she got ready for work. “He was actually one of the people who made me feel sexy again, after years of being just a mom.”

While she never “let herself go” as they say, she’d definitely wrapped her identity up in motherhood first, then her career. It was only when she

saw a guy like Ethan looking that she started to reclaim her femininity. It felt good. He helped her get confident and sexy in her own skin again.

“You have *always* been sexy,” Stephen said.

“Thanks, hon, but you know what I mean. I was in a funk. You got a Corvette, I got a new wardrobe.”

Stephen slid his hands over her chest. “And other new things.” When Julianna blushed, he made a connection. “Wait, did you want to get these done for Ethan?”

“Don’t be silly. I did that for myself.” She chewed on her lower lip. “But I did like the way he looked at me after.”

“You’re bright red, Jules!”

“Am I?” She giggled nervously.

“I’m sorry I ever questioned your faithfulness.”

“And I’m sorry that I wasn’t honest about my crush.”

“Hey, I didn’t tell you about my fantasy for way longer than that.”

She nodded, thinking about Ethan—then about all the other men she could have, if she wanted. This *was* fun, and it was even more fun doing it with Stephen.

“Let’s post the profile.”

“Really?” Stephen looked like she’d just announced that it was Christmas tomorrow.

“Yes, although we are just posting it. For fun. I’m not going to meet anyone, okay?”

“Okay, yes. Just posting. And maybe responding to some?”

Julianna giggled. “One step at a time.”

“Come on,” he said, grabbing her hand and jumping to his feet. “Let’s do it now.”

“You’re eager.”

“I want to do it before you change your mind!”

“What about this one?” Stephen said. They were in bed. He was on his phone, she was reading her book. “Just read your profile. And by read, I mean I jer—”

“No thank you.”

“He attached a photo. Want to see? Wow!”

“Didn’t we specify no dick pics?” Julianna set her book down. “Let me see your phone.”

The profile had been live for less than a week, and already they’d been flooded with comments and messages. The first few, they’d read together. That lasted about ten minutes. When it became clear what the sheer volume of messages was, coupled with the low quality of those messages, Julianna had delegated the screening of men to Stephen, who’d happily taken on the task.

He passed the phone to her. She took one look at the man’s erection and laughed. “Why do men send stuff like this? Is that supposed to make me excited?”

“Maybe he intends it to be flattering? Like, ‘look how hard you make me.’”

“A penis isn’t really inherently sexy, though. It’s not all that pleasant to look at, like a pair of boobs—”

“You like looking at boobs, do you?”

Julianna rolled her eyes. “I appreciate the beauty of the female form. And the man’s form, for that matter. If this guy had sent me a pic of his chiseled chest and eight pack abs, maybe I’d respond.”

“Really?”

“Plus something more thoughtful than...” She glanced at the message and read the rest of it aloud. ““And by read, I mean I jerked off all over the phone onto that hot bod of yours.”” She snorted. “Also, no way this guy has an eight pack.”

She handed the phone back to her husband and went back to her book.

There were a lot of messages to sort—like a fire hose of them, too many to truly parse. Stephen set himself the task, but even he found himself scrolling through and rejecting almost all of them without a second’s thought.

Then there was the problem with how to direct them to Julianna. The app had a messaging platform, but even with all the pre-screening, he knew it would just be too much for Julianna. They were so close to a breakthrough, he didn’t want to spook her off with a tsunami of dick pics.

“How about a Kik account?” he suggested one day.

“What’s that?”

“An encrypted messaging app. I could connect you and pre-screened guys on there to chat with.”

He held his breath, waiting for the inevitable, *You really are serious?* question that came from her. But this time, after a moment of pause, she simply said, “Okay, that sounds like a good idea. Seems safe.”

The relief that Stephen felt was sweet and uplifting.

“I’ll need to come up with a fake name.”

“Definitely,” he said, encouraged that she was thinking this through.

“What about ‘Julia’?”

“Yeah. They’ll never suspect that.”

“‘Jules’?”

She laughed.

“‘Anna’?”

“How about just ‘Ana,’” she said, as in aww-na. “You think I look like an Ana?”

Stephen set the phone down and rolled onto his side. Reaching out, he ran his hand along her body, feeling the heat of her skin beneath the thin cotton of her pajama top.

“Ana,” he said, weighing the name as he spoke. “It’s sophisticated, vaguely Eastern European. I think of darker hair...” He reached out and threaded his fingers through her locks, the reddish hue shimmering in the lamplight amidst her otherwise dark waves. He touched her neck. “I think of soft skin and a lean, slender body....” He shimmied closer to her, until her body grazed his. “Yes, I do think that you could pull off ‘Ana’. Better than ‘Julia’, honestly.”

“My mom called me Julia.”

“Exactly.”

Julianna laughed.

Stephen kissed her, already thinking about what this meant—what “Ana” meant. Ana wore slinky dresses on dates with attractive strangers. She was interested in no-strings-attached encounters. She had a flair for the mysterious and was drawn to the illicit.

When Julianna kissed him back with the same passion that he was feeling, Stephen knew that she was thinking about it too. When she reached down between his legs and found him hard, it was game on.

They tugged at their pajamas, kissing and caressing, momentum growing with each touch, with each new expanse of skin exposed. Julianna was wet, her smooth skin glistening with excitement as he ran his fingers down her landing strip and across her bare lips. He pressed two inside, and she bucked against his wrist. Her eyes, he noted, were closed.

“Ana, I’m so happy you met up with me,” he whispered. It felt awkward to say at first, but when she moaned softly, he was encouraged. “You’re even more beautiful than your photos.”

She groaned. He kissed her neck and moved down, working on her breasts. Her nipples were hard, thickening as he tongued them. Her fingers worked across his bare scalp and rubbed his ears, the way she always did when she was excited.

But he wanted to push this fantasy further. Rather than go down on her, then climbing over her for a quick fuck, he rolled her onto her stomach, and pulled her hips up. He loved Julianna’s ass, caressing her round cheeks as she got her knees under her and spread her thighs.

“Fuck, Ana, you’re so hot,” he groaned.

She really was, and his hard dick was proof. Moving forward, he slid into her with ease, her pussy silky and snug around his shaft.

“Uh,” she groaned, quickly swallowing her moan to stay quiet—a habit from all the years with Garrett living in the house.

“Let it out, Ana,” he said, lowering his voice, edging it with a rough growl. He wasn’t her husband. He was the Other Man now. “You don’t have to hold back with me.”

Stephen held his breath, ready for her to laugh at him. A laugh did emerge, but it quickly broke into a cry of ecstasy. He clutched her hips, digging his fingers into her skin, and began to fuck her.

Her fingers grabbed the bedsheets as she began to moan, heaving in short, tight gasps. Stephen took her harder, driving forward, their skin slapping wetly.

He pounded into her mercilessly, his cock stretching her tight pussy with every brutal thrust. Julianna cried out, the illicit pleasure of being ravaged by another man overwhelming her senses. Their skin slapped. She wasn’t trying to stay quiet anymore.

“That’s it, Ana. Scream for my cock.” It wasn’t a thing that he’d *ever* said to her, but he wasn’t himself. And when he did say it, he felt her pussy clench around him involuntarily, spurring on his own dirty talk.

“Yes, oh god, yes! Fuck me harder!” Julianna screamed, throwing her ass back to meet Stephen's thrusts. The bed shook violently beneath them as he rammed into her again and again, his balls slapping against her clit with each forceful stroke. Sweat slicked their bodies, their labored breathing and lewd grunts filling the room.

“That’s it, Jul—Ana! Scream for it. Take it!”

“Uh, yes!”

He felt her fingers between her legs, playing with her clit. It spurred him on. He rocked into her, fighting for control of her hips as he took her. She was definitely fully bought in. There was no doubt that right then and there, she was with someone new.

It sent a wave of jealous excitement through his whole body. He hesitated a moment before giving in to the urge to grab her, to punish her. He reached out, his fingers tangled in Julianna’s thick hair, gripping tightly near the roots. With a firm tug, he arched her back, eliciting a gasp that morphed into a moan. “That’s it, give yourself over to me completely,” he found himself ordering.

Amazingly, she went with it, throwing her head back and screaming.

Stephen’s grip on Julianna’s hair tightened as he felt his climax approaching. His hips moved faster, pistoning in and out of her slick heat with increasing urgency. Julianna’s cries grew louder, her body trembling beneath him.

“I’m close,” he grunted. “I want you to come with me, Ana. Touch yourself, make yourself come all over my cock.”

Julianna’s hand worked her clit harder between her legs, rubbing frantically. Her inner muscles began to spasm around him, milking his length. Stephen threw his head back with a roar as his orgasm crashed over

him. He slammed deep inside her one last time, pulsing jets of hot cum painting her insides. They collapsed onto the bed in a tangle of limbs, chests heaving as they rode out the aftershocks of their mutual release.

Stephen spooned up behind Julianna as she came down from the high of their intense sex. In the aftermath, he started to worry that he'd gone too far, and as he always did, started to compose an apology.

Before he could, though, Julianna said, "That was fun."

She twisted around so that she was face to face with him. She was smiling, his own apprehension reflected back in her beautiful features. He brushed her hair off of her sweaty brow. "I'm sorry I pulled your hair."

"You've never done that before," she said. "I... I didn't hate it."

"Really?"

Julianna glanced away, flushed, before forcing her to meet his eyes again. "It's not something I would have asked for, but yeah, I kind of liked the roughness. More than I expected." She winced. "Is that terrible?"

"It's beautiful," he said, knowing that was completely the wrong word to describe it, but his brain was all tied up. "I love that."

"What?"

"That you're still discovering new things about your own desires." He licked his lips, hesitating before moving the conversation back to the hotwife fantasy. "You think maybe the profile, and those guys, have something to do with it?"

"The guys you've shown me? No." She laughed. Stephen felt disappointment settle over him before she added, "But the idea that maybe *someone's* out there kind of, maybe, sort of is exciting?"

"Kind of, maybe, sort of"? I'll take it."

Julianna giggled. "I don't want to get your hopes up or anything, Stephen, but I *am* having fun with this. Even if it seems like I'm not. It just goes against everything that I've ever believed in. When we got married,

that was it. That was the end of the line when it came to romantic relationships.”

“Time out. I’m not a ‘romantic relationship’ anymore?”

She knew that he was just kidding around. “You’re so much more than that, Stephen. You know that.”

“You know there’s a difference between ‘romantic’ and ‘no strings’ kinds of relationships, right?”

She ran a finger along his chest. “Oh, I remember...”

Stephen shivered, his cock twitching back to life. Aiden, the photographer, jumped to mind. He wondered how many others there had been.

“Anyway,” she went on, refocusing them. “After we got married, I was ready to spend the rest of my life with you. Not just ready, but excited. Thrilled. I still am. I’ve found my one.”

“I know.”

“But I won’t lie, just the possibility that the door isn’t entirely closed is pretty... stimulating.”

Her confession got him going even more, but he kept his mouth shut, nodding for her to continue.

“So let’s just say that I’ve got an open mind, alright? Just... find me someone more interesting than a hairy dick pic.”

“That’s quite a task, but I’m up for it.”

She caressed his face. “Oh, I know you are.”

T HE HUSBAND: Just testing to see whether this thing is on.

ANA: Yes, dear, I installed it and set it up.

THE HUSBAND: You stop by the coffee shop again?

ANA: No time yet. Still at the gym. Think I should see if Jonathan is there today?

THE HUSBAND: Of course! And definitely keep your gym clothes on when you do.

Julianna had to laugh. Ever since she installed this discreet messaging app on her phone, Stephen had been blowing her phone up with messages. She also noticed that while he was hesitant to talk about some things face-to-face, he didn't seem to have a problem texting.

She actually found that to be true for herself, too. It was easier to send a text when she wasn't looking him in the eyes. It was easier to be "Ana."

Julianna set her phone into the cup-holder of the treadmill, took a sip of water, and cranked the speed up. She could hear her phone buzzing with incoming texts, but focused on her workout for now.

Stephen had taken over screening all of the initial messages through the app. It became tedious for her after the first week of doing it together, and Stephen had sensed it. While she was open to the idea of maybe embarking on this journey, she didn't love wading through the details.

So Stephen began to filter through all the dozens and dozens of incoming messages, including replying to some for more details, and once he found some that she might like, he'd pass their information along to her on Kik to continue the conversation. So far, he hadn't sent her any, which wasn't promising.

They'd put her profile up on a few platforms, but eventually settled on one called Debauch, a "dating" app that served not just cheating wives—like on Ashley Madison—but also "hotwives" and "cuckolds." There was this whole new lexicon out there for her to learn, and Stephen seemed to know all of it. She wasn't sure what was harder to wrap her head around—the terms like "bull" and "stag" or some other male animal, or her husband's near expert knowledge of all of them. He'd clearly been holding onto this fantasy for so long, and because of that, she decided to indulge him.

But of course it wasn't just for him, either. The thought of being with another man was thrilling, if still a little outlandish. She'd been with the same man for so long that she'd almost forgotten what it could be like with someone else. Now, she thought about it all the time.

"Yeah, if I had that ass, I'd definitely be checking myself out all the time," came a deep voice beside her.

She nearly lost her step and fell off the treadmill.

"What?" she asked. But she *had* been checking herself out in the mirror beside her—how good she looked in her tight, blue leggings and matching tank top. Her ass was bigger than she liked, but she worked hard to keep it from getting out of hand.

"You know what I'm talking about." She saw the man in the reflection first, jogging lightly on the neighboring treadmill. He was a very attractive black man, with thick, muscular arms that drew her eyes and made her wonder what else about him was thick. She immediately blushed and looked away.

“Don’t trip,” he said. “These things can be dangerous.”

She shut the treadmill off and skipped the cooldown. “Um, you’re right.” Then she made some excuse about needing water before rushing off, feeling the man’s eyes on her the whole way.

ANA: You find anyone interesting yet?

Stephen stared at the message. Recently, she’d started to open up a lot more and play along, but almost exclusively through Kik. It was like she could easily slip into her Ana persona online, because her fake name was literally next to her messages.

THE HUSBAND: Maybe a few... Want to talk to one?

There was a long pause on her end, which Stephen immediately interpreted as her having second thoughts. He silently cursed himself for pushing too hard, especially after restraining himself these last few weeks.

The couple of weeks since they’d posted the profile had been very educational. ”Ana had included some pretty clear instructions about what she was looking for: a man who practices good grooming habits, is fit, isn’t overweight, up-to-date photos, and no pictures of dicks. Yet despite that, easily a third of the messages were a simple “Hey” followed by a picture of a penis.

Those, he immediately swiped left on.

Then, there were the cringy screen names that came through: “MrMuffDiver”, “YourHotLover” “FitFucker9Inch”, and so on. Maybe this was the modern pick-up line, reduced all the way down to 15 characters or less. They all got swiped away, although he did show her “10inchCockandGun” just to get a laugh.

“Ouch,” was all she’d said. It validated all the pre-screening work that he was doing. This wasn’t an activity to undertake while curled up on the

sofa together sharing a glass of wine. There was nothing sexy or erotic here. It was purely administrative, where the creeps definitely overwhelmed any potential winners.

Because there were literally hundreds of these messages, Stephen set the bar extremely high. All those terrible screen names were out. Anyone leading with a cock pic was out. Anyone with spelling or bad grammar in their profiles were out, too.

That got him down to profile photos. It's funny, but despite being together for over three decades, Stephen wasn't one hundred percent sure what Julianna's type was. He knew what she didn't like, though, and weeded out anyone without a fit body, or too much hair, or photos that looked like they were taken in the man's glory days. He eliminated guys who were too young, guys that were too old, guys who posted pics that were just bad.

That was another surprise. Stephen wasn't anywhere close to being a "photographer" but he knew how to take a decent photo. Some of these guys had no clue, totally inept at taking selfies. There were so many photos of these guys in messy bathrooms, no shirt on, camera over their face, flash on. The lighting was just bad. The other most common selfie was of these guys sitting in their car, seat belt on, phone about dashboard high, looking forward while driving or sitting in traffic.

Swipe.

So that left a choice few that Stephen actually responded to. Maybe as few as one in five. About a third of those simply said, "Hi" or "Hey" or "Hello".

That's it.

Swipe.

Some responded the way that Stephen had expected.

"Hey gorgeous. Will you be in town soon? Would love to hook up."

Swipe.

“Hey. You are gorgeous. Would love to get to know you better. I love to please a woman. Have great stamina. And love giving oral pleasure.”

Swipe.

“I can’t wait to come all over those tits. Let’s meet up ASAP.”

Swipe.

No, no, and no.

It left a handful of even remotely acceptable profiles—profiles that were thoughtful, used proper grammar and sentence structure, a modicum of something humorous or clever, with a photo or two of a fit body that hinted at someone who cared about appearance and style, who *also* responded to his initial messages without coming off as a douchebag.

He’d been gathering some profile names, but hadn’t passed any on to Julianna just yet. That still made him nervous. That was the true test.

ANA: Send me one. I’m curious what you’ve found.

Her message snapped him out of his musings and fears. His heart leapt.

THE HUSBAND: I thought you were at the gym.

ANA: Maybe someone here inspired me to flirt with strange men.

THE HUSBAND: Someone hit on you?

ANA: Mmm hmm. Muscular black man. Do you have any of those in your roster?

Stephen’s breath caught. This was the kind of thing she’d never say to his face—hell, she wouldn’t even be able to say it over a normal text, but here, where she was “Ana”, it came much more easily.

In fact, he didn’t have any black guys on the short list. He didn’t think they were her type, and this proved that there was still so much more to learn about her.

THE HUSBAND: Not right now. But I do have this guy.

Stephen quickly went over to one of the few guys that he’d found—a man who actually seemed semi-coherent when he’d messaged him a few days back.

He briefly contemplated just asking the guy to send her a message directly, but she sounded like she wanted something now and he worried that the guy could be a flake.

THE HUSBAND: How about this guy? He's in LA, where you've got a trip planned next month...

With that, he sent along a few photos that were from the man's profile. The first was one of AJ wearing a button up shirt, untucked, over a pair of designer looking jeans. He had his arms crossed and the cuffs rolled up enough to show a tattoo sleeve on one forearm. He had what Stephen thought of as trendy hair—nearly shaved on either side with a short faux hawk of dark hair down the middle. No way Stephen could pull off that look—at any age—but this dude rocked it.

The next photo was a shirtless shot of the man, hands on his hips. The lighting was good enough that Stephen suspected some kind of professional behind the lens. That was a good mark for him, a sign that he cared. His chest was hairless, another positive mark, if he knew his wife, and you could see a lot more of his tattoos, the dark ink etched over his shoulder and well-defined pectoral muscles.

They'd exchanged a few messages back-and-forth, and this guy seemed qualified. He'd been a bull to other couples, even offered to put Stephen in touch with some as references. That did give him a bit of a pause, thought, like maybe this guy was a bit too much.

He sent the photos off, but didn't immediately get a response from Julianna, which of course sent his mind to all kinds of places. Was it too much? Was she upset with him that he actually sent her something? Was she somewhere touching herself as she looked at those photos?

THE HUSBAND: If you want, I can give him your Kik info. His name is AJ.

Her response came back almost right away.

ANA: I don't think so. This guy looks like an asshole.

That wasn't the response that he was expecting, although upon studying the photos again, she wasn't entirely wrong.

ANA: I'm also not a huge fan of the tattoos.

Another thing he didn't know.

ANA: I'm not looking for some bad boy man-child, honey!

"But you are looking," he said out loud, to himself, before realizing that he was at work. Then he decided to write it back to her.

THE HUSBAND: But you are looking!

ANA: *We* are looking. Yes. But sorry, AJ, you're not the one for me.

“Happy birthday, honey,” Stephen said as he carried her a mug of coffee into the bedroom.

“Ugh, don’t remind me.” She wanted to crawl back under the covers and go back to yesterday—or last year, or maybe ten years ago. “Can I still say that I’m in my early fifties at 55?”

“You don’t have to say anything. You’re gorgeous, no matter what age you are.”

“Says you.” She took the coffee from him and sipped. She loved that aroma, enjoying the bitterness on her tongue, sweetened just a touch by the oat milk creamer.

“Not just me.” The way Stephen was smiling was very suspicious.

“What did you do?”

“Check your phone.”

It had been a few weeks since he’d sent her that guy, AJ. She’d actually laughed out loud when she saw the photos. He was a pretty boy, that was for sure, but not one that she could actually take seriously. Stephen hadn’t sent her any others since then, and she was starting to worry that she’d spooked her husband.

She should have known there was little chance of that.

There were five new messages on her phone, in Kik. Only one was from “the husband.”

COLE: *Hello, Julianna, this is Cole from Debauch. Happy birthday! Your husband gave me your contact info: nice to make your acquaintance. I enjoyed your very thorough profile and find your relationship exciting and refreshing. You're absolutely stunning. I would love the opportunity to chat sometime and possibly get to know you better. Maybe we even grab a drink or a coffee when you're in town. I'm in Chicago, but travel frequently for work, and would love to meet up, city of your choice. I've included a couple photos so you can see who's messaging you. Hope you like what you see, and I really hope that your birthday is a special one!*

She scrolled down to find a couple photos of this guy, Cole, and she did, indeed, like what she saw. He wasn't as cocky as the last one that Stephen had sent, and he kept his shirt on—not that she minded shirtless men. He was probably in his late forties or early fifties, judging from the gray at his temples and his fit body.

In one photo, he was leaning on the railing of a boat, wearing a pair of sunglasses and a golf shirt. A glittering marina stretched off in the distance behind him. She could practically hear the sea gulls and smell the salt of the water. The other was a tighter shot of Cole, taken somewhere indoors. The sunglasses were off, and his warm brown eyes smiled back at her.

“He's handsome,” she said, her heart beating a little faster.

Stephen scooted closer, running a hand along her body. “Write him back. Tell him, not me.”

Julianna glanced at her husband like he'd just told her that he wanted her to strip on the corner of Time Square.

“What?”

“Write him back.” Stephen was all smiles. “There's no harm. You don't have to think of him as real. He doesn't know you, and if you don't like him, just block him.”

“Okay.” She said, although she wasn’t sure about any of this. She picked up the phone, hesitated one last moment, and typed a reply.

ANA: *Hello, Cole. Thanks for the birthday wishes, and thanks for the compliments. You’re pretty stunning yourself.*

She didn’t know what else to say. This felt super awkward. She showed Stephen, who nodded, and before she lost her nerve and deleted it, she hit send, her heart in her throat.

To her shock, his response came back almost instantly.

COLE: *I don’t think I’ve ever been called stunning. How’s your birthday been so far?*

Julianna looked at her husband, who was reading over her shoulder, and said to him, “It’s pretty pretty unexpected.”

“Keep reading,” he said. “I’m just going to…” And with that, he sank beneath the sheets, kissing along her body.

ANA: *You know, I’ve never had a birthday like this one.*

Just as she hit send, Stephen pulled her pajama bottoms down and opened up her legs. She felt the soft hairs of his goatee on her thighs as she scrolled on to the next message.

OLIVER: *Hey there. Hubby gave me your contact info. Happy Birthday*

This one had no photo, and the shortness after Cole’s response was striking. Still, she wasn’t one to just ignore the gesture, so she wrote back a shorter response:

ANA: *Hello, Oliver. Thanks for taking the time to wish me a Happy Birthday. Enjoy your weekend.*

Oliver didn’t write back immediately. She moved on.

JOHN: *Hey. Happy Birthday. I’m John.*

That one was followed by a dick pic. Julianna laughed out loud. Okay, so maybe they all didn’t need responses.

The other happy birthday well wishes were something between Oliver’s and Cole’s. She responded to them, some wrote back, but it became harder

to keep the conversations straight—especially as Stephen started to run his tongue along her slit.

ANA: Thanks, I enjoy working out and definitely try my best to stay in shape. I think it would be nice to chat and get to know you. Enjoy your weekend.

ANA: You really think I'm turning 45?

ANA: I may be traveling to your area in the next few months. Let's keep in touch.

“Uhhh...” She groaned, the phone sliding from her grasp. She shut her eyes as her husband teased her clit with his tongue and pressed a finger against her g-spot. She saw stars. She also saw the smiles of all these new men—men who were real, men who wanted her, men who she could actually *have* if she wanted to.

Her phone kept buzzing as more and more messages came in. Her body shuddered with each vibration.

“Oh, Stephen...”

He lifted her thighs onto his shoulders, and she imagined it was Cole or Mason or Chris doing the same, lost in a hotel room far from home.

“Uh! Uh!”

She wanted that.

“Ohh, yesss...”

She knew that she was going to have it.

Stephen pressed a second finger into her, timing his tongue with his rapid jabs. He worked her with his whole head, the familiar practice that came after so many years of knowing exactly what she liked.

Those other men wouldn't know that, and she couldn't wait to feel the difference. How would a man with a clean shaven face like Cole eat her out? How would Chris's hands feel as they ran up her body? Would they be smoother than her husband's callused fingers? She even thought of John and his dick pic, wondering how different that would feel inside of her—

“Uhhn! I’m... I’m... ahhh!”

She crested. Stephen didn’t relent, knowing how to wring every last ounce of pleasure from her.

“Uhhhnn!”

Her body convulsed with pleasure. She shut her eyes, thinking of the men, the others, their strange touches, all of their illicit promise. She ran her hands over Stephen’s smooth scalp, pulling him against her, squeezing her thighs around his head so hard she wanted to break him.

He pulled back, gasping for air, his familiar face bright red from exertion. Her phone continued to buzz in the background as their eyes met. He cracked a smile first, and hers followed right away. It felt good to do this with someone. With her husband.

She picked up the phone as Stephen wiped his face on his pillow.

COLE: I will actually be in San Diego that same week. I’d definitely be willing to drive up and meet you for a drink. I’ll research places.

She blinked at the message, revisiting the back-and-forth she’d shared with the man. Apparently she’d told him about her LA trip and had offered to meet him. She didn’t remember any of that specifically, carried away by Stephen’s tongue and her wild imagination.

“This is your fault,” she said, but she couldn’t help but laugh. She thumbed through some of the other messages. More had arrived since she’d checked, and most came with a few hot profile pics, a smorgasbord of attractive possibility.

“What’s my fault?”

“Apparently I may be meeting one of these guys next month.”

“Really?!” His surprise filled her with joy.

“I guess I got caught up in it all.” Another message came in.

MASON: Happy Birthday, beautiful. My name is Mason, and I found your profile on Debauch. Your husband—a great guy, by the way—was kind enough to send me your info. Guess I passed the first test, and I sure as hell

am not going to fail the next. Write back or not, no pressure, but you're one special lady. Hope you're having a great day.

Mason, apparently, was an attractive black man wearing a sharp, tailored suit and a bright smile. Something moved inside of her at the thought of him.

"Yummy," she said to herself, then blushed when she realized that she'd said it aloud. "You picked quite the range."

Stephen peered at her phone and grinned. "Well, after my initial failure, I figured it best to just flood the field. Someone would stick."

Julianna laughed.

ANA: Hey, Mason. Thanks so much for the happy birthday and the photo. So far, you're doing just fine.

"You're like a different person when you're on there," Stephen said.

She flushed and darkened her phone. "Yeah, I know. I feel more at ease."

"But it's still you, right? You're not... you're not just doing this for me?"

"No. Oh no. Not anymore." She reached out and drew him in for a kiss. "Not entirely, anyway. Can a thing be both for you, for me, and for us?"

"I think we're experiencing some of that right now."

Julianna pushed him onto his back. "And if I do meet up with Cole, will you really be okay with it?"

"I really will be." He slid into her easily, and he was so thick and hard. "So it's Cole who'll be your first?"

Julianna laughed, and when she did, her pussy squeezed around his shaft. They shivered together. "Let's not get ahead of ourselves. I'm not even sure I want to meet him, and even if I do, it's just a drink."

"It can be more..."

If anything, he actually seemed to harden even more.

“It can be. And if it does, I’ll make sure you know.” She set her hands on his shoulders, rolling her hips.

“I had a good feeling about him,” Stephen said. It was a funny reminder that all of those men who’d sent her messages had gone through her husband first. She wasn’t sure how she felt about that. “He seems pretty well-off, smart, and he absolutely loved your photos.”

Julianna ground into him as she thought about all those same men seeing photos of her in lingerie. She’d approved all of them, but it had been so abstract then. Now, they’ve seen her—and she may meet them.

“But let’s take things one step at a time,” she said, trying to slow herself down as much as she was her husband’s racing mind.

“One step at a time,” Stephen repeated. “Yes. But just so we’re clear where we’re walking...”

Julianna bent over her husband, pressing her tits into his chest as she rested her forehead against his. Their eyes locked. She moved to kiss him, then drew back before their lips met. “To one of those men taking me to bed.”

“Uh God,” Stephen groaned, his cock popping off inside of her.

She exhaled with a smile, kissing him softly as he filled her with his heat. She wasn’t with some other, imaginary man this time. She was feeling *her* man come with her, enter her, be a part of her. And it was wonderful.

“Thank you for my birthday present,” she whispered, snuggling over him, listening to his racing heart and heavy breathing.

“You liked it?”

“I did. More than I would have thought.”

“You’re so sexy, Julianna. I love you so much, and I want you to experience... well, everything.”

“You know I don’t need everything. Just you.” She kissed him, already hearing his incoming protest. She headed it off before it arrived. She scooped up her phone again. Three new messages from three new men had

come in. “But honestly? This is pretty exhilarating. I’m 55-years-old now, and all these guys really want me?”

“They really do, and that’s just from your photos. They’re going to go crazy when they actually get to know you.”

“You’re crazy.” She opened up the messaging app, snuggling closer to him. “But it’s okay. I think I’m a little crazy, too.”

“So you think you’ll meet Cole?”

When she breathed in through her nose, she felt her chest flutter. “Yes.” Her heart sang. “Just a drink, right?”

She didn’t hear the answer to her rhetorical question, however. She was too busy staring at the second new message on her phone.

It was from Anthony.

“What’s this, Stephen?” she asked, her voice much calmer than the fluttering, frenetic beating against her chest that his name elicited.

He looked back at her, awash with an odd mixture of guilt and eagerness. Weakly, he smiled and said, “Surprise?”

PART III

LAYOVERS

Her stomach kept dropping, long after the plane touched down along the rain-slick runway. It kept dropping as she gathered her roller bag, and as she disembarked through the long gangway and past the lines of imminent travelers, lined up and ready to board. It continued to drop even as her heels finally met solid ground.

“It was nice to meet you, Julianna,” said the man who had been sitting beside her on the flight.

“Thanks. You, too.” Julianna couldn’t remember his name, despite having spent the last four hours chatting with him. She felt bad about that, but her mind was far more preoccupied with other things.

The last month had somehow felt like a lifetime and the blink of an eye all at once. After her birthday surprise, she’d kept in touch with a few of the guys, chatting sometimes throughout the day with one or two.

Cole seemed the most eager to message and meet her. If she’d given him her home address and invited him over, she was pretty sure that he would have jumped at the opportunity.

That did give her a bit of a pause, but she enjoyed the flattery and the back and forth. There was something wild about exchanging messages with another man. Mostly, they discussed mundane things—what kind of food did she like or what movies he’d seen lately. He liked to share things about

himself—he'd been married, but divorced for ten years. He had a teenage daughter who lived with her mother in Florida. He never asked for personal information about her, though, and she was grateful for that.

When she'd agreed to meet Cole for a drink, it had felt abstract, the way making plans in the future always felt abstract—"Sure, I can write a report next spring" or "the wedding is next year." But like all commitments, as the day grew closer, all the nervousness and pressure started to build.

What if Cole was a psycho? What if he was a fake? She'd never actually even spoken to him on the phone or heard his voice. He could be a kid. He could be an AI!

She wheeled her bag to a quiet spot, away from the other travelers, and pulled out her phone. The air carried that recycled taste that all airports had, but it was fresh and beautiful after being on a plane for so long.

Shaking out her long, dark hair, she called home.

"A phone call?" her husband, Stephen, greeted.

"I just needed to hear your voice." Julianna played with the button at the top of her roller bag's handle. "I just landed in Phoenix."

She had a layover for a few hours before reaching her final destination. It felt funny how well she knew this airport now. Before, it had been just this—a short stop before moving on to her next place. Now, with Garrett living here, she'd started to know where the shops were, the bathrooms, the quickest way to get to baggage claim.

"So you going to see him?" Stephen asked. Julianna blinked, remembering that she was on the phone.

"That's the plan." She checked her watch. She had a little over two hours, so not a whole lot of time. That alone made her nervous. "This isn't a good idea, you know."

"I think it's a great idea." She could hear the eagerness in her husband's voice.

"Of course you do. You're not the one who may miss her flight."

“And if you do, so what? There will be others. Sky Harbor is a hub. I’m sure there are plenty of flights to LA.”

“And what if I miss all of them?”

“You’re looking for an excuse to not go meet him. But Jules, this is the perfect opportunity. It’s time-bound. It’s public. It’s just coffee.”

That falling sensation was back. It wasn’t just coffee. It was coffee with another man. It was coffee with Anthony.

“What if Garrett sees me?”

Stephen’s laugh on the other end was real and genuine. “Now you’re *really* searching for an excuse. Next, you’re going to go on about how ‘he’s going to take one look at me and think that I’m old.’”

“I was going to save *that* excuse for when I’m meeting up with Cole later.”

Stephen snorted. Julianna laughed.

“Okay, fine, I’ll go. It’s just... it’s just coffee.”

“Right. Just coffee.” She giggled to herself at his barely checked excitement. He added, “I love you so much, Julianna. You’re incredible.”

“Uh huh. I’ll text you when my connecting flight is boarding.”

“Or not if you decide to stay longer,” he said hopefully.

“That’s not going to happen, dear. I’ve got meetings in LA that I need to get to.” That was her ultimate destination—where she actually had legitimate business, and also... “And what about Cole?”

Her drink with Cole had her more nervous than her coffee date with Anthony. There were no expectations with Anthony—she had two hours and 8 minutes with him in a public space, and while she did kiss him a few months back, that felt like a lifetime ago. With Cole... well, that felt more like an actual date. With another man.

“I’m sure he’ll understand if you need to reschedule,” Stephen said. “You’ve got him wrapped around your—”

“Stephen, please stop.” She was suddenly feeling very overwhelmed. Half-a-year ago, if someone had told her that she would be meeting up with a man for a drink and plenty of ulterior motives, she would have laughed it off. Now, she was seeing *two* guys in the span of as many days, and it was all feeling like a lot. “You’re setting unfair expectations here. It’s just a drink. Okay?”

“Okay, yes. I’m sorry, Jules.

“I love you, honey, silly fantasies and all.”

“I love you, Julianna. Have fun. Bye.”

When the line went dead, she felt untethered once again. Life moved about her, serious people in a rush to get to the next place. That’s what airports were all about these days—no one lingered here, no one enjoyed these experiences. They were way stations between one adventure and the next.

Only not for Julianna. Not today. Today, the layover *was* the adventure.

IT HAD BEEN four months since Stephen first confessed his fantasy to her right there in Phoenix. In that time, they’d created a profile for her on a questionable dating service named Debauch, she’d started messaging strange men, and was now, for the first time in her life, considering actually sleeping with someone else.

Any question that Stephen was game for this was gone, though. She no longer doubted that he had the “hotwife” fantasy, as he called it. After the confession, it was like the cap of a geyser had been twisted off. He’d sent her a boatload of literature on the fantasy—essays and articles were first, but later came the books of hotwife erotica that he’d apparently been reading for years. She was floored.

He'd done most of the crafting of the Debauch profile, but given her ultimate executive oversight. He'd taken photos of her, edited them, cropped them, posted them. It was wild, but also... fun. Really fun. Dizzily fun, at times, when she wasn't worried about the reality of it all.

She was a 55-year-old woman, after all, and while she acknowledged that she looked great, and she enjoyed the attention that she got in a pair of tight jeans and heels, she still couldn't compete with girls in their twenties.

They had a system going. Stephen would screen all the messages coming through on Debauch through some complex system of his own design, reaching out to those who passed like some sort of erotic recruiter. If they passed the first "interview," he would send them her contact information on Kik, and they'd reach out.

Even with all of that work, most of the guys that got through just didn't do it for her. They were either boring or pushy or arrogant or just... *something*. By this point in her life, she wasn't going to settle for just anyone. It was a liberating realization, actually. In this digital age, she could just ignore the account and that was that.

She did have a regular chat thing going on with a few guys, though, and even now, she felt a giddy flutter in her stomach when she checked her messages and saw that she had some from her "gentlemen suitors."

Of them all, though, it was Anthony who got her heart racing the most. Maybe it was because she'd actually met him before, had actually already been charmed by him, had a drink with him, kissed him. She squirmed every time she recalled that moment, as close to a real life guilty pleasure as she'd ever had.

In the beginning, after he'd reached out on her birthday, their exchanges had come fast and furious. Then he'd dropped off the face of the earth for a week, completely non-communicative. During that time, she'd vow that she was done with him... until he showed back up and apologized for his absence. Julianna was used to being pursued, to people needing to work to

get into her life, and Anthony's refusal to do that only made her more intrigued.

That's what led her to this moment, pulling her bag down the one-way corridor of the terminal's exit as her stomach, once again, plummeted. When she'd booked her flight to LA and saw that it happened to stop in Phoenix, she debated even telling him. Stephen encouraged her to, and when she had, he'd made the offer—*"There's a coffee shop close to the airport. Come meet me and I'll buy you a drink."*

The two weeks leading up to this trip had been fun, to say the least. Stephen had been so cute. He was like a kid trying to hide his anticipation for Christmas. She'd done her best to tease him, making sure that he saw her texting Anthony or Cole on her phone—even though she wasn't always texting the men.

Their sex life had been amazing ever since her last trip to Phoenix, but over the last two weeks, Stephen was insatiable—and, honestly, so was Julianna. Probably nothing was going to happen, but even still, that "nothing" was going to happen with men who wanted to have sex with her, and who, she only ever admitted in the darkest part of the night, she wanted to have sex with, too. She blushed every time she even thought about it.

Stephen helped her pick out what to wear for the trip. She was spending hours on a plane, so it wasn't like she was going to wear a minidress or something more appropriate for a nightclub.

They'd settled on her favorite pair of jeans—tight with a bit of elasticity to show off her butt and legs—and a sleeveless, black blouse. Stephen wanted her to leave an absurd number of buttons undone. She'd settled on three—which was already more than she was comfortable with. The guy on the plane beside her couldn't stop staring into the deep cleavage presented by the Victoria's Secret Miracle bra that Stephen had bought her.

She fidgeted with the third button during her Uber ride to the coffee shop. Was this too desperate? Was *all* of this too desperate? There was

something about this man that set him apart from the other guys she'd been messaging, and as the rideshare pulled up to the hole-in-the-wall coffee shop on the outskirts of Phoenix, she realized all at once what it was—she knew that he was real.

The air was hot as she stepped out and thanked her driver. Her fingers shook as she retrieved her phone and gave him his tip and rating. “5 stars, thanks for facilitating my affair.”

Deep breath now. Maybe he wouldn't even be there. She hoped that he wasn't. She anticipated her own disappointed relief.

“Julianna, you came.”

No, he was definitely here.

Stephen stared at the GPS dot as it moved from the airport to a strip of shops just north of it. She was doing it. Julianna had actually left the airport. This wasn't a ruse. She wasn't just humoring him. She was too practical to risk missing her next flight just to tease her husband.

"Just coffee," he said to himself. Zooming in on the dot, he read the name of the place she was at: The Roast House. He clicked it, pulling up photos of the small, independent coffee shop. Cute place. He wondered how crowded it was. He wondered if they'd stay.

It had taken her about twenty minutes to get there once she'd ended the call. The ride wasn't long, but she'd have to wait for an Uber again. Then there was the security line. Not much time before she needed to go—maybe a half hour on the generous side. Not much time to get into trouble.

Still, Stephen's heart was racing and his chest was heaving like he was in the final throes of a long, months-long panic attack. She was actually there. She was actually meeting up with a guy that she'd *already* kissed.

STEPHEN HAD LIVED with this fantasy for years. He'd struggled with the fear that one day she'd wake up and realize she could do much better than

him. He thought about her getting hit on by other attractive men, men who filled and fulfilled her better than he ever could. Now, as they celebrated thirty years together, he knew that she wasn't going to leave him. Yet those thoughts of her in the arms of another remained. What had started out as a defense mechanism had morphed into a real desire for her to experience other men.

Having lived with this thought for so long, being so close to it, and being immersed in all these eligible men who all had the hots for Julianna was too much, and just too tempting to sit on the sidelines for.

Prior to her 55th, Stephen had reached out to Anthony. He'd kept the man's business card and toyed with the idea. He half-hoped that Anthony would coincidentally stumble about Julianna's Debauch profile. At last, though, he'd texted the man and told him about his birthday surprise for her.

There had been questions. Anthony didn't know that Stephen knew about him, for one. Until that text, the man had assumed that his kiss was done behind Stephen's back.

[Anthony]: So you're a cuck?

The question and the term bloomed inside him like sudden fire. Was that what he was?

[Stephen]: I'm a stag.

Stephen had done his research. He didn't want to be humiliated. He didn't see himself as subservient. When he thought of whatever wild and improbable future that he and Julianna could share, he didn't imagine cock cages and pegging as part of it.

[Anthony]: I don't know what that is. You're okay that I made out with your sweet bride?

It was a text message that Stephen had read and re-read countless times since. He'd even taken a screenshot of it, just to memorialize it.

[Stephen]: Yes, I'm more than okay with it.

[Anthony]: She was, too, believe me.

Oof. That tightening of the gut would never get old.

Anthony had agreed to reach out and be a part of the birthday surprise. Julianna picked up on the coincidence right away, and he'd confessed that he'd reached out to him. She wasn't mad, which was a relief. That kind of made sense, too, since she also knew that he'd spoken to *all* of the guys who came her way.

Still, as the weeks passed and she started to focus on a few of them, she did question him about those potential back channels. "Anthony just suggested we grab coffee during my layover in Phoenix. Did you tell him to suggest that?"

This was two weeks before her flight.

"Coffee? That sounds fun. Will you have time?"

"Maybe." But she also didn't let it go. "Stephen? I don't want you conspiring behind my back with these guys."

"Of course not, honey—"

"I just want to be crystal clear about this one. I don't want to feel manipulated."

"Understood. And you know I'd never do that, right?"

She gave him a sidelong glance, but smiled anyway. "Let's not forget about how you left me at Anthony's restaurant. I'm learning that you'll do quite a bit when it comes to this particular fantasy."

"That's kind of different?" he said, his voice rising at the end as he grimaced. "I never conspired *with* Anthony."

"And you better not ever, okay?" She sighed. "Just, please, honey, respect me."

STEPHEN WATCHED THE GPS DOT, marking Julianna's phone. It hadn't moved for the last thirty minutes. Those thirty minutes had felt like an

eternity to Stephen.

And he was hard for every second of it. This was more intense than anything he'd experienced in a long time—even wilder than when he'd left her alone at the restaurant with Anthony. Back then, he didn't think she'd go for it. Now, he knew that she was open to the idea. Very open.

Their wild, farewell sex last night was testament to it. So was this morning, watching her get ready for the flight. She'd put on a seamless thong, despite vowing never to fly in a thong, because her jeans were so tight—and not wearing those jeans wasn't an option. She wanted to look good for Anthony—for *another man*.

Stephen's phone buzzed, a notification from Debauch sliding into view. He checked the GPS dot one more time—it still hadn't moved—before toggling over to the hotwife app.

COLE: *I can't wait. Only a few more hours!*

STEPHEN: *Me either.*

Cole had reached out to Stephen as her trip approached, the man's eagerness to get it on with "Ana" almost palpable. Stephen had ignored the messages at first, but the man was persistent. He kept his responses light and short, wanting to respect Julianna's wish, but he couldn't fully resist the temptation to see this from another perspective.

COLE: *Drinks will be at this rooftop bar in Santa Monica. I have reservations at a Michelin rated restaurant next door, and then, if all goes well, I have a suite at the boutique hotel between the two.*

It was all so crazy. How was he talking about his wife going back to a hotel with another man? This conversation alone felt unreal.

STEPHEN: *Sounds like you've got it all planned out.*

COLE: *I'll be sure to send you a pic of your wife on her knees, staring up at me as she bobs on my cock.*

It was statements like this that sent a rush through Stephen every time. It was why he couldn't just ignore the man, despite knowing fully well that

he should.

STEPHEN: *That would be amazing, but I doubt she'll let you take a photo of her like that.*

COLE: *We'll see.*

Stephen checked the time. Almost 40 minutes had passed since Julianna had arrived at the coffee shop, and while he kind of liked the idea of her missing her flight and having to stay with Anthony, there was also Cole with his rooftop bar and boutique hotel to think about.

[Stephen]: Watch your time.

He sent it off, then went back to watching the GPS dot. Things started moving more quickly after that. The dot left the restaurant and moved halfway down the block. He figured that she was waiting for another Uber when the dot started to speed its way towards the airport. Was she in Anthony's car?

His stomach quivered at the sensation. He just stared at it, adjusting his erection in his pants as he watched it go. She pulled up to the Departures doors, but then the dot stalled out, despite the rapidly closing window of time before her flight. Stephen squirmed. He thought about texting again, but resisted. If she missed it, then maybe something more exciting would happen.

But in the end, the dot moved into the airport, towards the terminals.

[Julianna]: Boarding now.

[Stephen]: How did it go?

[Julianna]: It went well.

Oh no, she didn't get to leave him hanging like that.

[Stephen]: What happened?

He could hear his ragged breath as he waited for her reply, watching the dots bounce, then stop, then bounce again. At last, her message slid into view.

[Julianna]: Oh, we're about to take off. I love you! Xoxo

Stephen could only groan. He loved this woman.

Anthony was exactly as Julianna had remembered—tall with broad shoulders, his dark hair graying at the temples in a way that men could pull off and women had to hide. His face was smooth, his smile broad and approving when he saw her pause at the cafe’s entrance.

“Hey there,” he said, and she knew he was forcing his casualness, because she was, too.

“Hey, stranger.”

“Kind of, right?” he said, chuckling. “But also, not at all. I don’t think I’ve texted anyone so much in my life.”

It was funny. Of all the men she’d conversed with, Anthony was the only one who knew her by her real name—Julianna. To everyone else, she was Ana, this mysterious hotwife. She liked that she could share that with him, make him part of the secret.

“Same. Is this what it’s like to be a teenager?” Julianna asked.

“I wouldn’t have the first clue,” Anthony said. “And thank god. Don’t want to go back to those awkward days.”

And like that, it was as if they were back on the plane again, two strangers falling so easily into conversation. “Can I give you a hug?” he asked. “This feels like a hugging kind of situation.”

Julianna appreciated that he asked, and she was more than happy to oblige. He wore cologne, something her husband rarely did, and his arms felt like stone as they wrapped around her.

When he released her, he only took a half-step back. “God, you’re even more beautiful than I remembered.”

“Oh, stop.”

“I’m serious. Your smile is mesmerizing.” She only smiled more at his compliments. “Come on, I’ve already got us a table. Can I take your bag?”

Like a gentleman, he collected her bag from her and rolled it over to a small table by the windows. He had his own coffee there, steaming in the sun. He said, “You take it black, right?”

“And this is a double espresso,” she said, looking at his cup. She nodded and said, “Yes, black please.”

He went to the counter and ordered. She watched. He knew her drink preference, and she knew his. This man was a stranger, and yet he wasn’t.

“This is so strange,” she said when he returned with her drink. “I feel like I know you...”

“...yet we only met the one time,” he finished. “Well, the two times, actually.”

She blushed at the memory of their second time, subconsciously touching her lips. He grinned, but didn’t say anything about it.

“Sorry you had to Uber out here, but I didn’t want to meet at a Dunkin Donuts.”

Julianna looked around at the cute coffee shop with its trendy, farmhouse interior. “This does have a better ambiance than pink and orange.”

“Slightly better coffee, too.”

Julianna blushed. She rolled her eyes and looked away, trying to force the heat to back down. They were surrounded by the cacophony of a busy cafe at breakfast time. People murmured and moved. The steamer

screamed. Orders were shouted. And yet they were two people lost in all that chaos. It was almost cozy.

She looked back at Anthony—taking in his square jaw, his smooth cheeks and steely, gray eyes. The way he was looking at her. With Anthony she didn't feel self-conscious about the wrinkles around her eyes, at the smile lines and all the other imperfections that she saw every time she looked in the mirror. He looked at her the way a hungry man looks at a hot meal, and her nipples hardened beneath that gaze.

He was saying something, she realized, but she didn't catch a single word of it. "Hm? I'm sorry, could you repeat that?"

Anthony chuckled. "I was just asking if you packed your bikini for L.A."

"Ha. Of course you were. Now you're sounding like my husband."

Anthony didn't seem put off by the mention of Stephen. "What can I say? A beautiful woman like you should show it off."

"The Los Angeles trip is strictly business," she said. Anthony didn't need to know about Cole. "No, I left the bikinis at home."

"I love that you have multiple. Next time, we'll go back to my house, where I've got a pool."

"Now you're getting ahead of yourself," she said.

"You should still try and enjoy yourself while you're there. Lot of fun things to do and see."

"You've been then?" she asked. "Chasing girls in bikinis?"

"My lips are sealed." He ran his fingers across his mouth, zipping them shut. "Maybe if you were there, I'd have chased you."

"Uh huh, once all the girls rejected you."

"Please, you're the ultimate prize and you know it."

"So you think I'm something to win?"

"I know I would have tried." Anthony sat back in his chair. "Come on, don't tell me you're a stranger to being hit on."

“Sure, but I’m married, remember?”

“And yet you’re here with me.”

“And,” she pressed on, “in all honesty? I was never one of *those* girls.”

“Those girls?”

“The kind of girls you chased in LA.”

“Yet, I’m pretty sure that you like to be chased.”

How did he know that? “I like it when a guy puts in the effort.”

“Does driving an hour to meet you for coffee for thirty minutes count as effort?”

She flashed him a coy smile. “It’s a start.”

They fell into conversation like they were old friends. The banter was fun and fresh, so different than what she was used to with the man she’d spent the last thirty years with. Beneath it all hummed this delicious tension between them. He more than lived up to the memory of the man she’d once kissed.

“Hey, I’m sorry I was so pushy the last time,” he said as their time together drew to a close. “I didn’t think I’d ever see you again.”

‘Let’s get out of here.’

‘I can’t. My husband...’

‘I live just a few blocks away. We’ll be quick.’

Julianna still remembered that exchange, the heat, the temptation, the guilt. She still hadn’t told Stephen exactly what he’d asked.

She wanted to write it off now, move past it. But there was also something about Anthony that made it irresistible not to tease. “So it’s okay to invite a woman back to your place as long as you’ll never see her again? Hm...”

“Well, that kind of came out wrong.”

She lifted her brow and smirked. “You don’t say.”

He reached between them and took her hands. His touch sent tingles up her arm and down between her thighs. Her body was buzzing, and it wasn’t

just from the coffee. “I’ll be honest, at the time, I just saw a sexy woman and thought you were available. I didn’t realize the whole story.”

“You just wanted to take advantage of me.”

“You wouldn’t have regretted it.”

Julianna snorted. “One thing you don’t lack is confidence.”

Her phone buzzed. She didn’t want to look at it, didn’t want reality to intrude into this quiet part of Phoenix. But reality was always there. It was a text. From her husband. *Watch your time.*

“Oh, shit! I need to get going!”

She rose abruptly, drawing the eyes of a few patrons. Anthony rose with her, and she hesitated for a moment, weighing her options. When she’d talked this meeting over with Stephen, they’d agreed that she would Uber out to the coffee shop, and Uber back so that she wouldn’t have to spend time in the car with a “stranger.” But Anthony didn’t feel like a stranger anymore, and she definitely didn’t have time to wait for a rideshare..

“Hey, want to give me a lift?”

He seemed to know what her question meant—that she trusted him enough to get into a private space with him. “I would love to. You sure?”

“I’m sure. Why aren’t you? Is the floor of your car covered in fast food wrappers or something?”

They laughed at the inside joke. He’d admitted to having a weakness for McDonalds at times, despite being the owner of an upscale Italian steakhouse—a confession he made when she told him how much of a fitness freak that she was.

Anthony took her bag from her again, slipping his other hand into hers. She was surprised to find his palm as clammy as her own. “Come on, I don’t mind being judged by my vehicle.”

That vehicle turned out to be a Chevy Silverado pickup, black with silver trim, and like the driver, impeccably clean. “You drive a Chevy? Thought you were a man?”

“Right. Forgot you were a Jeep girl. I can maybe overlook that quality...” He opened the door for her, and held out his hand to help her step up into it.

“Hopefully this thing has a big enough engine to get me to my plane in time.”

Anthony just laughed, gunning the engine as they tore off down the street. They were back at the airport departures ramp in less than five minutes. Anthony got out of the truck and helped her with her bag.

“I had a great time, Julianna. Thanks for meeting me for coffee.”

“Thanks for treating me.” She couldn’t stop smiling. Things felt so heated, so ripe between them. She felt like she was back on a first date, uncertain of whether her date would kiss her, but hoping that he would.

“If I could, I’d purchase a ticket to join you.”

“You’d get bored of me being in meetings all day long.”

“But I’d be there in the evenings when you were back. Worth it.”

Julianna rolled her eyes. “I better...” She glanced towards the airport entrance. “Get going...”

When she turned back, he was standing right in front of her, close enough to touch. Close enough to kiss.

“Oh,” she managed.

And then she *was* kissing him. It was a soft kiss, yet full of all the pent-up energy that had been building over the weeks and months of flirtation, over the last half hour. His lips were warm, and when she put a hand on his cheek, it was so smooth.

She barely remembered that first kiss, so long ago. She’d been a little drunk, a little upset with Stephen, and a lot overwhelmed by everything. It had been unexpected. This time, she knew that the whole moment had been building here, and she wanted to devour him.

It was Julianna who pushed her tongue past his lips, opening her mouth to his. He took her in his arms, deepening the kiss, oblivious to the world

parting around her, rushing from point A to B.

Obvious until a police officer flashed his lights at them as he rolled past. The two jumped and parted. She was buzzing. She wanted him. She wanted so much more of him.

“Listen, I know we’d said just coffee, and I know you’ve got to get in there and run through security, but I’d like to do this again.”

She nodded. “Me too.”

“Does your return trip take you back through Phoenix?”

“Maybe...” She grabbed her bag. “But I *really* should run. Can’t miss this flight.”

“Of course. See you around, Julianna.”

As she raced through the airport, getting whisked to the front of the security line because her flight was departing so soon, making it to her gate just as they were making their last calls, she couldn’t shake that smile.

To think, this was just the layover, the space between things. The main event awaited her in LA, in Cole, in an actual date with another man. And yet she couldn’t stop thinking about seeing Anthony again, about her return flight, about once again moving in this liminal space.

Boarding now, she texted her husband.

[Stephen]: How did it go?

[Julianna]: It went well.

She touched her lips, where the impression of the kiss lingered.

[Stephen]: What happened?

This was the space between, and she wanted to linger in it alone, if only for a few moments longer.

[Julianna]: Oh, we’re about to take off. I love you! Xoxo

She smiled and turned to look out the window.

Stephen knew that the best course now was to give her space. He'd coached Garrett's soccer team years ago, and knew that by the time the game began, all he could really do was watch and hope they remembered their drills and plays. In a sense, these last few months had been getting Julianna ready to play. He just had to give her space.

That's what the *best* course was. Was that what he actually did? Of course not, and he had a string of unanswered texts to her on his own Kik account to prove it.

Relax and have fun.

Focus on tonight.

Your first meeting isnt until noon tomorrow. You have all night.

I've taken care of everything at home.

Took out teh trash and recycling.

Folded and put away all teh extra clothes we didn't select.

Tonight's going to be amazing!

But no pressure. If it doesn't work, there are so many other guys in line.

You can be choosy. You are not obligated to stay if you aren't having fun.

And remember, Cole's probably as nervous as you are.

So, you may need to move things along yourself.

But no pressure.

Stephen winced as he read through all of those messages again. He didn't normally mansplain anything, but this list was pretty bad. Even he could recognize that. You don't say, "focus on tonight" and then immediately follow it up with tomorrow's schedule. He would have laughed to himself except for the despair that he felt starting to creep in. Had he just sabotaged everything?

And yet, because she hadn't responded to any of those messages, he wanted to write more. Her plane had landed. She'd texted him when she'd deboarded. He'd watched her GPS dot move through the airport, then in towards the city.

So she probably wasn't checking Kik. That was understandable. It was still kind of a new thing, and she wasn't in the habit of it. Or maybe she was annoyed with him for bombarding her with messages? Or maybe... maybe she just wasn't going to go through with it tonight at all? It was all some kind of elaborate tease. Had she even met Anthony in Phoenix, or had she just taken an Uber to a coffee shop and back again?

Stewing in it all, Stephen considered sending a message to Anthony, whom he hadn't reached out to since the birthday party. He resisted crossing that particular line, but he did send a *text* message to Julianna.

[Stephen]: I sent you a few messages on your Kik account. Check them whenever.

She'd just arrived at the hotel when the message went through, and he didn't get a response for a torturous twenty minutes.

[Julianna]: Haha. So cute. I'm relaxed, but sounds like you're not. Go have a drink, honey.

[Julianna]: That's what I'm about to do.

[Julianna]: With another man.

Devil emoji.

Stephen's gut tightened. His face was flush, his body too warm and his fingers clammy as he responded.

[Stephen]: Enjoy.

She didn't respond, but marked the message with a heart emoji. The dot in her hotel room didn't move for another thirty minutes, although that made sense. She was most likely getting ready, preparing for her date, slipping into the outfit that they'd ultimately settled on—the tight, black top, the short, black and white miniskirt, the black stay-up stockings, and lastly, the sky-high Christian Louboutin heels.

Julianna had been upset when he'd surprised her with that particular gift because she knew how expensive they were, but her anger didn't prevent her from wearing the heels out on one of their dates—or from selecting them for the one she had tonight.

He sat at home, alone, watching that dot *not* move for so long that he began to worry that maybe she wasn't going to go out for that drink after all. The paranoia was back. He wrote multiple messages asking her when she was going out—and promptly deleted them all. Instead, he went and fixed himself a drink as she'd suggested.

He did work up the courage to send the following text, though:

[Stephen]: Maybe send me a photo of yourself before you head out?

But by that point, she was already leaving the hotel. Stephen groaned in frustration at being locked out, but what else was there to do? It was late where he was, and he'd already ridden the emotional rollercoaster earlier that day, with Anthony and the coffee date. Was that really the same day?

Stephen raked his hand over his face. It was late. He felt like he'd been up for days at this point. His eyes and neck hurt from staring down at his phone. And still he watched, never taking his eyes from the screen for longer than a few minutes.

She arrived at the rooftop bar, where they stayed for almost an hour. That was a good sign. It was even better when her dot moved next door, to

the fancy restaurant. Still nothing from her, although he did get a quick Debauch message from Cole—“*Heading to dinner. She’s so beautiful.*”

It was completely inappropriate, yet was like a drop of water to a man lost in the desert. Stephen was instantly hard, and rejuvenated all over again.

Stephen just wished that Julianna had sent it. It wasn’t until today, with Anthony and then Cole, that he realized how much of an outsider he felt.

After another hour and not seeing any movement at the restaurant, Stephen couldn’t resist any longer. He brought up his phone again and started sending Julianna Kik messages.

Seems like it’s going well. So exciting.

When you get a chance , would love to hear how it is

I should sleep but am worried

Sorry, that should have been wired!

Don’t drink too much. You want enough energy to have some fun.

It’s so late! Hope you had some coffee for desert

Dessert

Oh, you’re moving! Good luck!

The dinner had lasted another 45 minutes. That put her time with Cole at under three hours. Incredible. It was also crazy late where Stephen was, which meant that Julianna must be crazy tired, too, and yet it didn’t appear that she was headed back to her hotel. It appeared that she was going to that boutique one that Cole had booked!

Holy shit. It’s happening!

STEPHEN: *Holy shit, it’s happening!*

He couldn’t resist piling on to the long thread he’d created—which was still unread. He watched that dot like he could see them having sex. It didn’t move much, but when it shifted even a little, he imagined his wife riding another man, her naked body towering over him, covered in a sheen of sweat in the dim light of the hotel room.

Stephen pulled his dick out and started jerking off. He'd done well enough up to this point, but couldn't stop now. He brought up other messages from before, from Cole—*She seems so fun, I cannot wait to wine and dine your hot wife*—to the few from Anthony—*You're okay that I made out with your sweet bride?*—to others who were a lot more direct.

"Hey gorgeous, saw your pics and couldn't resist reaching out. Your tits look amazing in that lace bra. Bet they feel even better in my hands... or mouth."

His cock swelled in his grip as he pumped it in his hand, staring at the screen, flicking through all the crazy shit that other guys had written—things that shouldn't have gotten him going, but did.

"I wanna bend you over and fuck you so hard, make you scream my name while your husband listens from the other room."

His heart throbbed along with his shaft.

"Damn girl, you're making me rock hard over here. I can only imagine how incredible you must look naked. Those curves, that smooth skin... I bet you taste as good as you look. When can I meet you in person and show you what a real man feels like? I promise I'll ruin you for anyone else."

He stopped blinking, his eyes drying out as he read more and more, jacking himself faster and faster as he thought about all those men doing the same to photos of his sexy wife.

"Can't stop thinking about you riding my thick cock, those perfect tits bouncing as you moan my name. Wanna watch you cum all over me, then flip you over and take you from behind until you scream."

Stephen saw it happening. He imagined Julianna riding some stranger's cock—Cole's at that very moment, perhaps—her body rising over him, sleek and rippling, her tits bouncing. She had her hands in her hair, raking them through her damp locks, her mouth parted and her nostrils flaring.

He beat himself faster, racing towards his inevitable, messy end. His left hand shook as he held it aloft, reading more of the threads—threads that

he'd shamefully starred so that he could come back to again and again.

"Baby, I'm dying to see every inch of your sexy body. Run my hands over your soft skin, kiss my way down to your sweet pussy..."

"Fuck, you're hot."

"I want you to suck my dick."

"I hope you keep that pretty pussy bald for me, baby. I wanna feel nothing but smooth skin when I ram my dick into you."

She didn't keep herself bald as that guy hoped, although Julianna did maintain a very sexy landing strip that Stephen himself had helped touch up just that morning, before her big trip. The thought of her shaving it off, though, for another man, was the final shove he needed.

"FUCK!" he cried out as he popped come all over his hand. His eyes were shut tight. His wife was getting railed hard. He could hear her cries. He could smell their lust.

And then it was gone, all the pressure, all the build-up that came with this trip, with those messages, with all the profound expectation, drained away as he emptied his balls.

What remained was doubt and anxiety and more than a little annoyance. Why hadn't she responded?

Cleaning up, he checked the messages that he'd sent her. His last one still sat there, unrequited—*Holy shit, it's happening!* And the dot was still at the hotel. Maybe she'd left her phone there? Maybe she was actually at her original hotel, miles away, asleep, and didn't realize it?

Stephen actually called that first hotel, getting the front desk. "Hello, could you connect me to Julianna Clark please? She checked in today, and is in room 5121."

"One moment, please."

That moment felt like an eternity as the phone rang and rang. Stephen's blood pressure rose the longer the rings lasted. Finally, it switched to

voicemail. Had she slept through the call? No, impossible. She must actually be at the *other* hotel. Which meant she was fucking.

He went back to the thread of messages. Still no response.

STEPHEN: All okay?

No response. His gut quivered. Panic began to rise. What if everything *wasn't* okay?

STEPHEN: *I need to know that you're okay?*

No response again. He shifted over to the Find My... app. She was still there. Her dot hadn't moved. She was with Cole. She was probably with Cole in his bed! But maybe she wasn't? Why hadn't she responded to any of his messages after all these hours? Surely she could have checked her phone at some point.

So he called her. He had to.

It rang.

And rang.

And went to voicemail.

He thought about calling *that* hotel, but had no idea what name Cole had checked in under. Probably not "Cole", and even if he had, Stephen didn't know the man's last name. Why hadn't he thought to ask the guy's last name? In fact, he didn't know much of anything about this guy, a fact that was becoming painfully, frighteningly obvious the more the minutes ticked by.

Without her responding to his messages, he felt the distance between them like one feels the silence after a song, lingering yet empty. When they'd discussed this before, he hadn't pressured her to send him pics or keep in constant touch. He knew that Julianna had an aversion to photos at all—getting the ones for the profile had been a real sell—so getting action shots seemed crazy. Stephen hadn't asked, because at the time, he thought that just the idea of her fucking another guy would be hot enough.

And yet now, it was so much harder to be completely outside of it all, knowing that he wasn't witnessing something that he knew would be mind-blowingly erotic. It was so much harder than he could have imagined.

Stephen knew what he was about to do was a bad idea. He knew that he should have just let the night run its course and reap the rewards in the morning. He also knew that he wasn't going to do that. Not as he stared at Julianna's dot on the Find My iPhone app, or the "Play Sound" button just below it.

This was a bad idea.

He pressed it anyway, knowing that somewhere in LA, her phone was ringing bloody murder.

Too late to take that back now...

“...So they really didn’t want to pull the trigger on this deal, right? We’d tried everything to entice, but they were so stubborn. And then it hit me, these guys were Texan. You’re following, right?”

Actually, she wasn’t. They were at the tail end of dinner. She’d consumed more than her normal share of drinks—two Cosmopolitans at the rooftop bar, a glass of red wine at dinner that never emptied.

“Tell me,” she said, prompting Cole to continue talking about himself. That’s how it had gone all evening long. At first, she thought that he was just nervous—and he was. She could tell by the awkward way he hugged her when they first met, or how he fidgeted with the drink menu at first.

But time and drinks had melted the nerves away, and what was left was still an awkward guy who defaulted to speaking too much about himself when the conversation lagged. Which it almost never did because Cole seemed intent on filling every moment of silence with *something*.

“Would either of you care for a dessert?” their server asked, mercifully saving her from having to hear more about these Texans and why they were so stubborn.

Cole glanced at the small dessert menu, then up at Julianna. She could almost read his mind as if he were speaking his thoughts aloud—*I would*

like dessert, he was probably thinking as he stared at her. Or something like that.

“I actually think we’re all set here,” Julianna said. “Just the check please.”

“Right away.”

Cole wasn’t a bad looking guy. He didn’t *quite* match the photos of his profile, which were probably taken ten years ago, but his smile was still the same, as were his eyes. She’d been looking forward to meeting him for the past month. She really had. Even when she saw him waiting for her in the restaurant as she arrived, she fluttered at the thought that maybe this was going to be her first man.

But there was just no way now. She didn’t need an expert conversationalist, but she also wasn’t settling. If there was one thing that these past few months of awakening had taught her, it was that “Ana” didn’t settle.

“It was a lovely evening, Cole,” she said, trying to be light about what came next.

“Very. You’re even more amazing in person, Ana.”

Really? she thought. *You barely even let me talk.* “Oh, that’s kind of you.”

The last things that her husband had messaged her returned.

And remember, Cole’s probably as nervous as you are. So, you may need to move things along yourself.

She almost laughed to herself. Cole saw the smile and seemed to misinterpret it. He may have been nervous once, but he wasn’t anymore. If she’d wanted to, there wouldn’t have been much issue moving things along here.

“The check,” the server said, returning with a folded booklet. Julianna took it before Cole could, slipping her credit card in and handing it back. As she saw her name flash on the card—her real name—she realized that it

could potentially be a problem in the future. Cole wasn't paying any attention to it at all. His eyes were on her, his mind on what came next.

"So I was thinking..." he began, reaching across the table and taking her hands into his. He had nice hands, she had to admit, a little clammy from nerves, but large with nice, long fingers. He dragged his eyes up to meet hers, lingering for a moment in her cleavage.

"I know what you're thinking," she said, doing her best not to bruise this guy's ego too much. She withdrew her hands and picked up her glass of water. "It's getting late, and I've got meetings in the morning."

Julianna felt bad, watching as she dashed his hopes against the table. But she'd already given this man three hours of her time—and many hours before—and it wasn't going to go *there*.

He was graceful about it, at least, giving her a nod after a quick, deep breath. "Of course. Thank you for dinner. Oh, shoot, I was going to pay for it."

Yes, that would have been gentlemanly of you, she thought. The server returned with the paid bill. "It's no worries. Thanks for the company."

He nodded. They rose, moved to the door together, hugged. He felt strong in her arms, although not quite as strong as Anthony

Anthony. Just thinking of that man's name sent a thrill through her. If she'd been out with Anthony here in LA, they wouldn't have remained at the restaurant for so long. That, she was certain.

They got separate cabs. True to form, Cole took the first one, waving goodbye to her as it whisked him off to whatever five-star hotel he was staying at. She wondered if she'd hear from him again. She hoped that she wouldn't.

The whole thing had her wired, though. Even the possibility that she might have slept with that man was thrilling, even if he ended up a dud. A taxi pulled up to the curb. She glanced at it, thought about her empty hotel room, and waved him off.

Turning, she strolled down the street, needing to walk, to clear her head. If only the circumstances had been reversed—if it was Cole she'd had coffee with on her layover, and Anthony at her final destination.

"You're that easy, Ana?" she asked herself.

Spotting a bar attached to a small, boutique hotel, she decided to go in for one more drink before calling it a night.

Julianna glanced at her reflection in the glass doors that led into Bar 99, and she looked pretty amazing. Her skirt was shorter than what she normally wore, but she had the legs to pull it off. The four-inch Louboutins helped, although she was still a smidge annoyed with Stephen for making such a big purchase. Still, she appreciated the encouragement, and she did love the look—black with red soles. Up top, her blouse was tight, conforming to her breasts and offering up a nice view that Cole couldn't take his eyes off of.

She sighed as she made her way to the bar. Cole. What a total dud.

"White wine, please," she said as she settled in at the bar.

"Put it on my tab, Chris," came a deep, accented voice beside her.

Julianna lifted her brows and turned to the man. He was a few years younger than her, handsome, tall, and dark skinned. "That's quite forward of you," she said.

"I was thinking I was being generous, no? But I can see how you might interpret my offer as forward."

Julianna liked that she had to look up to meet his eyes, even in her four-inch heels. Here was a nice distraction from her disaster of a date.

"Why thank you for your generosity," she said.

"A woman like you should never have to pay for her own drinks." His accent was African, although she wasn't sure where.

"I don't know. That feels a little dated, don't you think? I enjoy my independence."

The man grinned. He had brilliant, white teeth. “You can pay for my drink next, if you would like.”

“My independence doesn’t depend on your dependence on me, but sure. If we make it to a second drink.” This was fun. This was more of what she had hoped for with Cole. Next to this guy, Cole seemed like such a potato.

“Why don’t you tell me a bit about yourself,” he said. “Are you here alone?”

“Right now I am. You?”

“I’m not. I’m with you.”

Julianna snorted. “Does that normally work?”

“I don’t know. Is it working?”

“It’s not *not* working,” she admitted. “I’m here for work.”

“Okay.” Then, as he processed it, his eyes lit up. “Oh, for *work*, you say? Like... you’re working now?”

Julianna realized the implication, her face lighting up. She covered her mouth and shook her head. He thought she was a prostitute? “No, sorry, I mean, I’m here in LA on business. No, you know...”

“Okay, yes, good.” The man looked relieved. “I’m happy to buy you a drink, but I don’t typically buy... that sort of thing.”

“You don’t typically?” Julianna asked, raising a brow. With his dark complexion, she couldn’t tell whether he was blushing, but thought that maybe he was. She liked that she could make him blush. She wondered if she could make him moan.

Now *she* was blushing.

“I am also here on business. I split my time between here and Ghana.”

“What do you do?”

And this time, as the man started to get into his business stories—albeit in that vague way that people use when meeting strangers in bars—she was actually interested. Unlike Cole. Maybe it was because she was wondering what it would be like to take him upstairs and get naked with him. She’d

never been with a black man before, and never really considered it, but ever since Stephen had broached the hotwife fantasy, she'd started to consider all kinds of things.

Not that she was going to have a one-night-stand with a man that she'd just met, and who seemed determined not to even give her his name.

That wasn't how she was going to pop her hotwife cherry, right?

Her heart buzzed. Maybe she would. Maybe, she'd skip the room all together, drag him into the bathroom, and fuck him on the sink, staring into his eyes through the mirror.

She buzzed even harder.

"I think your phone is..." The man pointed to her small purse, snapping her out of her daydreams.

"Oh, right." She was so flushed, and judging by the way this man was staring at her, it was like he knew exactly what she was thinking. She reached into her purse and silenced the phone.

"Not important?" he asked.

"If it's an emergency, he'll call back."

"He, huh? Do I ask?"

She bit her lip, holding her breath, considering what came next. Yes? No? I'm married? It doesn't matter? What did she say to him?

"Last call," the bartender said, wrapping his knuckles on the bar. "Close out the tab?"

The man looked at Julianna, raising his brows. This was it. Did she go? "I think—"

RAH! RAH! RAH!

They all jumped—Julianna, the black man, the bartender. It was like a fire alarm going off. Then, she realized that the fire alarm was coming from her purse!

The man she'd been flirting with smiled one last time at her. "Guess it was an emergency," he said. "It was nice to meet you." To the bartender, he

said, "Charge it to my room."

Julianna fumbled with her phone, silencing it as she drew the eyes of the remaining people in the bar. It was Stephen, of course, along with a missed call, missed texts, and a whole essay in her Kik account.

"Thanks for the drink," she said to the guy. "I need to deal with this."

"Of course." He nodded. "Although now I kind of wish that you were... working tonight." He winked at her, then left her alone.

Julianna didn't know whether to thank her husband for bailing her out of that, or to kill him. She texted back:

I'm fine. Heading back to the hotel now.

Instead of replying, he called her, and when she heard the relief in his voice as he said, "You're okay," she *did* feel bad for him.

"I am. Sorry to worry you so much. I was just caught up in the moment."

"Caught up how?"

She waved a taxi down and climbed in, giving the driver the address of her hotel.

"What's going on?" Stephen asked, his voice small and distant through the phone.

"Getting a cab."

"Are you alone?"

"Yes, just me and the driver."

There was a long silence at his end. Then: "You were out with Cole for a long time."

"He liked to talk."

Stephen knew her well enough to read into her tone. She appreciated that now, after spending so much time with someone who couldn't pick up on anything.

"Ah. So no fun stories?"

“Not with Cole, no. There will be no more stories involving that particular man.”

“He always seemed too eager,” Stephen admitted.

“He was nice enough. There just wasn’t any chemistry.”

“That’s too bad.”

“I did get a drink with a stranger though,” she said.

Julianna could almost see him perk up on the other end of the phone.

“Oh?”

Julianna realized that the cab driver could hear everything, and was, in fact, stealing glances at her in the rear view mirror. She blushed, but then realized that she’d never see him again.

“Was there... was there chemistry there?” Stephen asked.

“Maybe. We’ll never know anymore because someone literally pulled the alarm on us.”

“Shit,” he cursed. “I’m sorry, I... I kind of panicked there.”

“You did.” She was still buzzed, not sure if she was ready to have this kind of serious conversation, but the alcohol helped her ask the question.

“Do you still want me to do this, Stephen?”

“I do.”

“So why DEFCON 5?”

“Because... I don’t know.”

“Because maybe this is a mistake?” she offered.

“No. Definitely not that. I just... went to a weird place. And it was hard, not knowing what was going on.”

She understood that. “I’m sorry, you’re right.”

“Just... next time, maybe send me a few more texts?”

“So you want there to be a next time?” she asked. They arrived at her hotel. She paid the driver and got out as she waited for Stephen to respond.

“Yes, I do. If... if you do.”

“Not with Cole. But I’m starting to like the possibility of *something* happening. It was a fun night, once I got rid of Cole.”

“I’m sorry I messed that up,” Stephen said.

“I’m not. I think I want my first time to be special. I didn’t even know the guy’s name, and I don’t think he intended to share it.”

She swore that she heard Stephen whisper, *That’s so hot*. Instead, he said the more reasonable thing: “I think that’s a good idea. Any candidates on that list?”

“Well, now that you mention it, I *do* have a slightly longer layover in Phoenix heading home...”

“Yes. That,” Stephen said eagerly. Julianna laughed. “This time, I swear I won’t hit the panic button”

“And I’ll be better about keeping you in the loop.” She walked into the hotel lobby feeling simultaneously alive and exhausted. “I’m back at the hotel, honey, and I really need to get some sleep.”

“I love you, Julianna.”

“Love you too. Thanks for looking out for me.”

There was a brief pause before he added, “Looks like there are flights the next day out of Phoenix if you wanted to spend the night...”

“Good *night*, Stephen!”

He chuckled. “Night.”

So much happened on that first day that it was hard to keep up. Julianna had woken up in the morning with her husband, flown to meet a man for coffee—and later kissed—had drinks and dinner with a second man—who she didn’t kiss—and ended the night getting hit on by yet *another* man—whom she probably would have kissed and maybe done a whole lot more were it not for Stephen’s “intervention.”

She could have chosen to be annoyed with him, but she was decades past that now. She accepted the man for his quirks and flaws, because she knew that there was so much more to him than all of that. She also knew what anxiety could do to anyone.

Still, she didn’t call him immediately the next morning, either. Let him stew a little. He deserved it. And her head was splitting. She wasn’t much of a drinker, and last night had been filled with drinks.

Getting up, taking some Advil, and hitting the hotel gym got her head straight. So did the furtive glances that she got from the one other guy working out. He was way too young for her, but it felt energizing to get that kind of attention.

It wasn’t until that evening, after her meetings and after grabbing dinner with a colleague—something that she texted Stephen was happening ahead

of time lest he track her to a restaurant and raise the alarm again—that they finally did connect.

“Long day?” he asked as she flopped into the nearly made hotel bed, earbuds in and eyes closed.

“Long couple of days. Did I really just leave yesterday?”

“Honestly? I’m pretty sure you left about a month ago.”

“Sure feels like it.” She pulled her heels off and tossed them to the foot of the bed. “How are you doing?”

“Better.” He hesitated. “I’m sorry about last night.”

“I’m sorry, too.”

“Because I interrupted you?” he asked shyly.

“What? Oh, no. Actually, like I said, probably best that you did.” She laughed to cover her own blush, even though he couldn’t actually see her. “I’m sorry that I kind of ignored you.”

“Yeah, but I went a little nuts.”

“You did. And we should talk about that. Because we don’t have to do this, you know.”

“It’s not that. It’s more... just... I wish I could be there sometimes.”

Julianna had been thinking about that, too. She’d done some of her own research into this hotwife lifestyle since Stephen had brought it up. She knew some men liked to watch. Some liked to participate. Some preferred being denied all of that—Stephen was clearly not that type.

At the same time, Julianna didn’t feel entirely comfortable with her husband watching or being present. She knew that many men liked to watch their wives flirt at a bar—they’d even done that before. That was okay, if a little weird, but even then, Julianna felt like she was performing for Stephen. It was harder to live in the moment and just be a woman getting hit on by a new man. She also didn’t think that she could ever do... *it*... with him in the room. But she also knew that he wanted details.

“What would you like to know?”

“Your dinner with Cole. Not great?”

“It was fine. But there were no sparks.” *Not like with Anthony*, she thought.

“Not like with Anthony?”

Julianna blinked as her husband seemed to pluck her thoughts from her head. “No, not like with him.”

“Tell me about that.”

It was funny. With all that had happened, she hadn’t actually told Stephen about her kiss. She’d just left the tease hanging out. No wonder he was so crazy.

“Well, he was waiting for me at the coffee shop, looking just as I remembered him...” And then she proceeded to recount, in painstaking detail, her initial meeting. She was partly trying to torture him, partly trying to delay the moment where she had to confess to the kiss. Stephen ate it all up, and as she retold her coffee date—that word still made her heart flutter—Julianna grew more excited.

“...and then he drove me back to the airport.”

“You got in his car.”

“He seemed safe.”

“Okay.” She could hear how heavy his acknowledgment was.

“He dropped me off at the departure gate, as I’m sure that you saw.”

“Yes.”

She was building up the punchline, but even the memory of that had her palms moist again.

“But before I left him, he... kissed me.” Her heart leaped. She slipped her hands down her body, beneath her dark slacks, unable to help herself.

“And I kissed him back.”

“Oh, Julianna...”

Her face was on fire. Her pussy was moist. “And I want to do it again.”

“You should.”

“You really are okay with this?”

“I’ll be better,” he said. “I promise.” He sounded like an addict.

“I’m going to hold you to that.” If her husband was an addict, she was clearly his enabler. But could she give it up herself? Not when they were so close.

“Has he texted you since the kiss at the airport?”

“Not yet,” she said. “But that’s not unusual.”

Anthony wasn’t the greatest when it came to communicating, but she actually preferred this to Cole’s incessant chatter. Seemed to translate into better in-person experiences, too.

“And don’t you go reaching out to him and telling him to message me,” she added, knowing her husband.

“I... would never.” She heard the hesitation.

“Of course not, dear. But also, you better not do it.”

“Right.”

ANTHONY *DID* SEND her a Kik the next day. So did Cole, although she found her heart skipping a beat at the former man’s name rather than the latter.

ANTHONY: *How’s your trip going?*

ANA: *You really want to hear about work?*

ANTHONY: *If all you’re doing out there is working, then I’d say your trip isn’t going very well.*

ANA: *Maybe you should have flown out with me after all.*

She was feeling bold. Anthony brought that out in her.

ANTHONY: *I’ve been thinking the same ever since we “said goodbye.”*

Heat pooled below her navel.

ANA: *Your loss.*

Anthony was fun. She kept up the playful banter throughout the day. She also took screenshots or particularly charged conversations to send to Stephen. Like when she teased Anthony about taking a shower and how nice it was to be able to walk around her hotel room naked, she sent a copy of the exchange to her husband.

ANA: It's just so freeing.

ANTHONY: Pics or it didn't happen.

ANA: Nice try.

Stephen seemed to appreciate it, attaching a heart emoji to those screencaps, and it helped keep things light for Julianna, too. He also encouraged her to send pics as proof, which she definitely didn't do.

She hadn't actually sent photos to any of her guys, although not for lack of requests. Part of that was fear of judgment. Part of it was just fear that these things would get out into the wider world, that someone would recognize her—or some detail in the background—and she'd be outed. Still, with Anthony, at least, it was tempting. She'd met him, after all.

She didn't send him a nude shot of herself, though—she wasn't actually walking around her hotel room naked. The temptation was there, though, following her through the rest of her trip.

So did his flirty messages.

ANTHONY: Let me know the next time you take a shower. I'll take one, too.

She didn't respond to that one, as it came in the middle of the day, during meetings. When she checked again, there were a few more—but not Stephen-levels of messages.

ANTHONY: Hope your day is going well. Mine is boring.

ANTHONY: Mostly, I've spent it wondering when I can shower.

ANTHONY: You see, I've been having very dirty thoughts.

Julianna laughed at the man's persistence. In contrast, she appreciated Stephen's restraint. The two men seemed to have swapped roles, and she

had to wonder about that—just not enough to worry.

Back in her hotel room at the end of a long day, she stripped off and stood before the mirror, observing herself. She wasn't the tight, fit thing she once was. She'd had a kid. Her face was lined with the ups and downs of a life well lived. All that said, she knew she was attractive, and this whole hotwife thing, with the men and the messages and the drink dates, was a good reminder of that.

ANA: You can take your shower now.

On a whim, she took a shot of herself over her shoulder, nothing but an obscured view of half of her naked back. Her phone blocked her face. It was about as innocent as a sexy selfie could get, yet it was a huge step for her.

[Julianna]: I'm going to send this to another man. Any objections?

She wanted to give her husband one last opportunity to refuse this game, and she wanted to include him. His response was almost immediate.

[Stephen]: None! Yes, do it! So hot.

So she did, hearing the woosh of it travel to Anthony's phone before she could come to her senses. She set the phone on the counter and slipped beneath the shower and its cleansing spray.

All her insecurities were washed away as she gave in to the heat and the steam. Here, when she closed her eyes and thought of Anthony, she felt the same tickle of excitement that her husband wore so plainly.

She soaped her body, imagining Anthony's hands on her. She didn't have the same flat stomach of her fitness modeling days, but good genes and a rigorous gym regimen had it in a place she was proud of.

She cupped her breasts, full and soft, and brushed her thumbs over her nipples. They were already hard without the stimulation. That first touch sent a shiver through her. She imagined Anthony behind her, caressing her like this, his lips on her neck and his large hands squeezing.

She dropped a hand down between her legs, gasping as her fingers found her swollen clit. She didn't do this very often. She didn't play with herself. Lately, though, ever since she'd started chatting with Anthony, she couldn't seem to help herself.

And when she did, all of her embarrassment and anxiety lifted away. She thought of his eyes on her, his hands on her, his lips and his... erection on her...

"Ah!" She shuddered, the beginning of her climax starting to build. She silenced the cry and forced her hands away.

Grabbing a razor and her shaving gel, she made sure that her legs and underarms were smooth. She glided her palms along her calves, down to her feet, rinsing the foam away and checking that she didn't miss a spot. Satisfied, she grabbed the shaving gel again and applied it to her mound, making sure that her pussy, too, was as smooth except for the narrow strip of dark hair above her clit.

Out of the shower, she blow dried her long, dark hair. It curled naturally, loose ringlets falling around her bare shoulders. Wrapped in a towel, she picked up her phone and had to laugh at Anthony's response.

ANTHONY: *Best solo shower I've had in ages.*

He attached a photo of himself, and unlike Julianna's obscured and "artistic" one, there was no masking who he was. He stood, shirtless and proud, his skin still damp from the shower, with a thin, white towel tied about his waist.

Grinning, she picked up her phone and responded.

ANA: *I love a man with broad shoulders and chest hair.*

Did she really just write that?

ANTHONY: *Well, I'm not so vain as to shave my chest, but as a swimmer I pretty much shave everywhere else. ;)*

ANA: *Well, I pretty much do too....ummm....almost.*

Had she really just teased him about her grooming habits? She squeezed her thighs together and laughed. This is what he did to her. She felt years younger. When she glanced back, she saw a new message had come in.

ANTHONY: So speaking of landing strips... ;) I seem to recall that you're flying back tomorrow.

He hadn't mentioned this since the airport, when she'd told him she was still thinking about it. Julianna appreciated that he gave her space, and appreciated it even more when he finally asked.

ANA: I am!

She let him stew for a moment, watching the three dots bounce as he composed a message, then disappear, then bounce again. She giggled and decided to help him out.

ANA: I was thinking of getting something for dinner while I'm there... outside of the terminal. You have any fun recommendations?

His response came quickly.

ANTHONY: You know what? I've got a few ideas.

ANA: I bet you do!

She looked around, once again feeling like she was about twenty years younger. She loved it. She glanced down at her phone again, her thumbs a blur and she typed out her response.

ANA: Pick a place. I'll meet you there.

ANTHONY: And what if I suggested chocolate covered strawberries served in a hotel room?

She felt hot, and not just from the shower.

ANA: I love chocolate strawberries...

It was happening. It was actually going to happen this time. Stephen barely got any sleep. Not after Julianna texted him and told him that she'd extended her layover tomorrow a little longer.

[Julianna]: Meeting up with Anthony for dinner.

Just as she'd met up with Cole. Only this time, he *knew* that it wouldn't end in boredom. Anthony had already proven himself a charmer in person. Julianna knew this, too, and had agreed to dinner with him anyway.

[Stephen]: You're amazing.

[Julianna]: Help me pick out what to wear.

And so they had, going through the limited wardrobe that she'd brought along to LA. She still had the same outfit that she'd met Cole in, the black and white skirt, the tight blouse. But that felt like a loser.

[Julianna]: How about we start with this?

The photo came in of Julianna wearing a lacy, black Victoria's Secret bra that he'd bought her the previous year. He found it so sexy that she was going to wear something for another man that he himself had bought her.

[Stephen]: Yes! That's a good start. And the matching thong?

[Julianna]: Of course. I'm just not sure about flying in a thong.

[Stephen]: I'm sure he'll appreciate it.

[Julianna]: The things we do for men.

What a statement. Stephen was so hard.

[Stephen]: Now aren't you glad I told you to pack the little black dress?

[Julianna]: My hero. LOL

The next photo was of her in that LBD. Her hair was still damp from her shower and she wasn't wearing makeup, but she looked phenomenal in it. The neck plunged, and her cleavage spilled out freely, helped by the bra. If she met up with Anthony in that dress, all parties knew where it would end.

[Stephen]: Is this really happening?

[Julianna]: We'll know tomorrow, won't we?

And that was why he couldn't sleep. How was any man expected to sleep after that? He tried. He tossed and turned. He wished that she was there, not miles away. He wished that he could hold her, touch her, kiss her, before sending her off to a lover. But at the same time, this was good. He couldn't smother her or second guess any of this. Things were in motion. He just had to be chill enough to let them run their course.

The next morning she texted him that she was heading to her final round of meetings. He wished her luck. He went to work himself, but was barely present. It helped that he was on the cusp of retirement anyway. Things didn't need much attending to anymore.

She did send him her new itinerary, though. She really had switched her flight home to a red eye, leaving Phoenix at 11:32 at night, and arriving at home the next morning. This was really fucking happening!

[Julianna]: Okay, at the airport. About to board Here we go!

[Stephen]: It's going to be amazing. Just relax. I'm relaxed.

That was a total lie.

[Julianna]: That's a total lie.

He laughed at how well she knew him.

[Stephen]: Fair. But I'm better today. I'll give you space.

[Julianna]: And I'll keep you as in the loop as possible. Here, for example.

And what came through was a Kik thread between Anthony and Julianna. She'd been sharing these throughout their trip, and he really appreciated it.

ANTHONY: *Made us a reservation for the finest restaurant I could find near the airport.*

ANA: *Oh?*

ANTHONY: *The Marriott on 44th Street. Room 1295.*

ANA: *Hope it's Michelin-rated.*

ANTHONY: *Still waiting on the star, but it's got great... seating.*

He read the thread, his eyes nearly falling out of his head.

[Julianna]: Turns out, dinner's going to be room service.

[Julianna]: Okay, I have to shut my phone off. I'll text you when I land!

Stephen practically had a heart attack when he read that. No, she wouldn't do that. Would she? Then again, even with the extension, she only had a few hours with Anthony after factoring in security.

He sat back and re-read the text, all the threads, the photos from last night of Julianna in her sexy lingerie. This was going to be a long, amazing, difficult evening. This time, he was determined not to fuck it up.

Leaving the family restroom in an airport, alone, dressed in an LBD and her makeup done, would have been equal parts embarrassing and nauseating—changing in a public restroom wasn't the most sanitary thing to do. Julianna didn't care. She was practically vibrating as she got ready for her date.

Changing at the airport wasn't part of the initial plan. Hell, this second layover hadn't been part of the plan. She was going to wear the same jeans that she wore flying out, along with a nice, yet inconspicuous, blouse.

But Stephen had suggested a dress, and once he had, her mind started to turn on how to make that happen. She wasn't going to go to the airport in a hot little black dress. She wasn't a call girl, and the idea of traveling in one wasn't great.

So she'd carefully packed her LBD into her carryon, along with her makeup kit and a pair of black, heeled sandals. At least the family bathroom was clean.

"Family" bathroom. She snorted at the thought, catching a glimpse of herself in the mirror. Black stockings with lace-trimmed tops, black garter belt, matching black bra and thong, heels that made her legs look spectacular.

The flight had taken forever to taxi to the terminal, eating into her four hours and twenty-eight minute layover. It had seemed like an age when she'd shifted her flights around. Now, it didn't seem like enough time.

Still, Julianna took her time to do her makeup and make sure she looked her best. When she exited the bathroom, she half-expected a disapproving family waiting for her on the other side. No one paid her any mind. She was just another traveler.

Between the taxi delay and her wardrobe change, she was already running 45 minutes behind—a precious 45 minutes lost. She arranged for a car to pick her up, and since she'd been here before, she knew exactly where to go, but even still...

Getting a car now!

She texted Anthony first, then her husband. Her anxiety levels were high enough that she didn't realize how much of a kick Stephen would probably get out of that. Was this really happening? Was she really going to do this?

There was traffic. Of course. She checked her watch as the pressure and her anxiety ramped up and up.

Stephen didn't bombard her with texts as she suffered, and she was grateful for that. Instead, he sent her a single, reassuring response.

[Stephen]: Relax. Breathe. Enjoy.

She did as instructed, and it helped... only to be disrupted all over again when her other man wrote: *Come up to room 1295.*

Just like that, a room. The text sucked the air from her lungs. Time stood still for a hollow moment before crashing forward. One moment, she was in the back of the rideshare car. The next, she was crossing the lobby of the Marriott, her heels clicking on the polished floor.

Her stomach rose with the elevator. A couple stepped on just as the doors were closing. She smiled at them, but refused to meet their eyes,

worried that they knew exactly what she was doing—that she was about to meet a man for sex. She covered her rings. They got off before she did.

Her heart only started to calm down as she arrived at room 1295. Things were in motion now. She'd crossed the void. The hardest parts were all behind her. She knocked on the door, feeling light as a feather.

On a whim, she reached out and covered the peephole on the door. She heard him moving behind it, checking to see who was there, possibly, and encountering nothing but black. She heard the deadbolt slide open and took a steadying breath.

He opened the door, and there he stood, as impeccably dressed as she'd come to expect. This time, he had a cool-casual vibe going—a light sport coat over a pink shirt and dark pants.

"Is this the Admiral's Club?" she asked him.

He chuckled, his eyes scanning her. "If that's what you were expecting, it absolutely is."

Julianna pulled her roller bag into the hotel room, brushing right up against him, buoyed on a cloud of giddiness. "A man not afraid to wear pink..." She ran her fingers along the pink square of silk that was tucked into his breast pocket. "Very sexy."

She splayed her fingers out over his chest, pressing her palm into him. His body felt like granite, hard and toned. Going up onto her toes, she kissed his cheek, just as smooth as last time...

As last time, when he'd pushed his tongue into her mouth, when he'd filled her head with the heady scent of his cologne. She drew back from the more innocent kiss, and their eyes met. He was thinking the same thing. They both laughed at once.

"Would you like a glass of wine?" he offered.

"I would love one."

She followed him into the room, her chest tightened when she saw the neatly made king size bed. *This was really happening!*

“That’s some dress,” he said. He poured her a glass of red from the minibar.

“Why thank you.”

For the first time since they’d met, Anthony was speechless. Or, rather, he looked like he had something to say, but decided to just smile instead.

She raised a brow. “What?”

“When you weren’t here, right away, I convinced myself that you weren’t coming at all,” he said.

“Sorry. Best laid plans and all that...”

“How much time do we have?”

She checked her watch. “Just over three hours.”

Julianna could barely contain her excitement. It had been building since their first kiss, so long ago, growing with each exchange and encounter, with each new dress that she tried on, with each long shower in LA. And here she was, standing next to another man in a hotel room with a bed splayed out before them.

“We don’t have to do anything, Julianna. We can go down to the bar and just talk.”

She smiled—first to herself, then to him. “You trying to get out of it now that you realize I’m an old woman?”

“You need to stop with that. You’re one of the sexiest women I’ve ever met. And I promise I’m not just saying that to get into your pants.”

“Good, because I don’t want to just talk.” She drained her glass in one, long gulp. “And I’m done wasting time.”

Anthony scooped her into his arms, finally unleashing all that feverish, rabid passion. They kissed like they’d done at the airport. They kissed like they talked about kissing over the last few months. They kissed with all the promise of an uninterrupted evening of fun.

“This dress...” Anthony groaned, running his hands down her back and up between them, finding her breasts. “Your body is unbelievable.”

She caressed him right back, slipping her hand inside of his jacket. “Let’s see what you’ve got, yourself.”

Together, they pulled off the jacket. When he started to open his shirt, she took a couple steps back and started to play with the hem of her dress. He fumbled with his buttons when she lifted it enough to tease the tops of her stockings again.

He opened his shirt. She nibbled on her lower lip. “So that pic wasn’t a Photoshop,” she said, admiring his broad chest and the sparse crop of salt-and-pepper curls. She appreciated a man who took care of himself and Anthony *definitely* took care of himself. “Neither was mine.”

Reaching behind her back, she unzipped her dress. She locked eyes with Anthony, encouraged by his look of hunger. With a shimmy and a tug, it pooled around her heels, leaving her exposed in nothing but her black, lacy lingerie.

“Incredible.”

Julianna felt the tingly thrill of being so exposed. She didn’t consider herself an exhibitionist, but moments like this were always electric. It helped that Anthony finished pulling off his shirt.

They came together again, hands now unfettered as they caressed and explored all that newly exposed skin. “Incredible,” Anthony said again as he cupped her thong-clad butt.

They kissed again, deep and wet, exploring in the low light of the hotel room. When she finally found his cock, she said, “Very nice, Anthony.”

“Now don’t you wish I sent you dick pics?”

Julianna burst out laughing, resting her forehead on his shoulder. It lightened the mood, but didn’t diminish the passion either of them felt. “You just wanted to get nudies of me.”

He scooped her up into his arms with surprising ease and walked her over to the bed. “Who me? Nah! Nothing beats the real thing.”

They continued to kiss once on the bed. More clothes came off—Anthony’s pants, Julianna’s bra. He couldn’t resist her nipples, hard and swollen. “Oh, that’s...” She sighed, running his fingers through his close-cropped hair. “That’s good...”

Anthony’s hands weren’t idle. He ran them down her stomach, out her hip, tracing the garter belt and suspenders that held her stockings. “Have I told you that you’re incredible yet?”

She giggled. “You may have mentioned it.”

With his fingers, he admired the lace band at the top of her stockings before tracing them up between her thighs. “I can feel your heat.” He grazed his teeth across her nipple as his fingers pressed against her mound, only the lacy thong protecting her

The protection didn’t last. Pushing it aside with an impatience that they both felt, he found her pussy at last, moist and ready for him.

“Uhhh...”

“Fuck, that’s hot,” he groaned as he ran his fingers over her landing strip. He quickly sank a forefinger into her smooth slit and brushed her clit with his thumb.

Her gasps tripped free, a breathy stutter as she arched her back and opened her legs.

They shed more clothes—her thong, Anthony’s boxers. When she went to push the garter belt over her hips, he touched her hand. “Leave them. They’re sexy.” He ran his fingers down between her legs, rubbing her mound. “Everything about you is sexy.”

Anthony shifted up her body, kissing across her collarbone and along the side of her neck.

“Go on,” he whispered. “Touch it.”

She hadn’t yet. Not directly. It was like a decadent dessert that she hadn’t convinced herself to taste. Anthony guided her hand to him, nudging her to try.

“Touch it,” he repeated. “I know you want to.”

It was warm and hard, larger than her husband’s. Thicker, too. She was already wondering what that would feel like inside of her, even before she fully closed her fingers around all that girth. It throbbed in her hand, and the two of them shared a laugh.

“It likes that,” he said.

Julianna looked up at him, brushed her hair back, and said, “Then it’s going to *love* this...”

With that, she dipped her head into his lap and wrapped her lips around the tip of his cock. Anthony gasped, rocking his hips up into her face. She was ready for it, slithering her tongue back and forth along the sensitive underside of his shaft.

Julianna was a pleaser. She enjoyed giving her husband blowjobs because she knew how much he enjoyed it. She also enjoyed the power that it gave her. Anthony was no different in that regard. In all others, he was *so* different.

“Look at me,” he said.

When she glanced up at his body, his cock still sliding in and out of her mouth, he was staring right back at her. She choked. There was so much intensity, directed right down at her. His eyes weren’t closed. He wasn’t lost in the sensation alone. He was focused on *her*.

“You have amazing eyes, Julianna.” His voice was strained, like leather stretched taut over muscle. “I love a woman who makes eye contact.”

Watching him like that, there was no way she could deny what she was doing. She was with another man. She was going to have sex with another man.

And she couldn’t wait.

“I’m close,” Anthony rasped.

She nodded, but didn’t pull off. She bobbed faster, teasing him with the back of her throat. When she gagged and choked again, she pulled off.

“Sorry, sorry.”

Anthony only shook his head. *It's good. It's good*, he seemed to say.

She went back to work, jerking him with both hands, fondling his balls, watching as his orgasm overwhelmed him. It was as profound and beautiful as a sunrise. His brow creased, his mouth gaped, and all at once—

“Nghh!”

—he was filling her mouth with his hot come. So much come. She couldn't hold it all in her mouth.

“Swallow,” he said. “I want to watch you swallow.”

The focus was back on her, like a spotlight she hadn't realized that she'd stepped into—a spotlight that she loved. With her eyes locked on Anthony's, she released his dick and swallowed his load, brushing the dollop of escaped come back into her mouth with her fingers.

She smacked her lips as she straightened up. “Guys like that?”

“Watching a hot woman swallow? Yes. Yes we really do.”

“Interesting.”

“My turn.” Anthony laid her onto her back and crawled down between her legs. “You're so wet.” He kissed the narrow stripe of hair just above her clit. “And this is so hot.”

“What? Most mommies my age don't shave?”

He lapped along her bare pussy lips. “No.”

Even the way this man ate her was different from Stephen. His cheeks were smoother on her thighs. His technique was more demanding. He encouraged her to drape her legs over his shoulders.

“Oh, my...” She shuddered as he ravaged her, his tongue alive and aflutter across her sex. “Oh, my... God!”

As her orgasm began to peak, he pressed harder between her legs, lifting her hips up off the bed. She groaned at the pure physicality of the moment. Oral sex had never felt this hardcore. He slid his hands down her body, cupping and caressing her tits. And he timed it all so perfectly. Just as she

was about to crest, he pinched her nipples. Her breath caught, her brain hiccuped. It was just hard enough to feel good and sharp and *different*.

And yet when she did come, her throat raw from all the moaning, she wasn't ready to be done. She wanted more. She wanted all that this man had to offer.

Anthony was happy to oblige. "I'm going to fuck you now." His voice was low and hungry, his gaze playing across her sweat-slick curves. "Tell me you want it."

"I want it." Her voice nearly shook. She wanted it so badly. Reaching between them, she grabbed his dick and tugged him closer. He was hard again, and if anything, even thicker than before. She trembled as she looked him in the eyes. Drawing him against her pussy, she said, "I want you to fuck me."

It didn't take much. She was soaking wet, welcoming all that thick, new cock. Kissing her first new man after thirty years had been weird. Going down on another man after thirty years had been thrilling. Feeling a new cock enter her after all those years was like taking that first drop in a roller coaster while blindfolded.

"Uhhh!" She arched her back as he spread her open, feeling like a warm bar of steel. "That's... ohhh!"

"You feel... so..." Anthony sighed. "...good..."

She ran her hands over his back, intending to just touch, to caress, to be gentle. Somewhere along the way, though, the animal in her took over. She clawed at his ass, encouraging him to take her deeper. She needed him. She wanted him. She wanted all of him.

Their mouths found one another, the kiss sloppy and awkward and impassioned. "Fuck me," she whispered as he buried his face in her hair. "Fuck me with that nice, big dick."

Anthony did as ordered. Breathing heavily into her neck, he began to take her in earnest, smothering her with his fit frame.

“Yes! Yes! That’s it. That’s... it!” She wrapped her legs around him, squeezing him with her thighs and driving her heels into his buttocks. “I’m close. I’m so... I’m so close!”

“Let it out, Julie.” Not a name anyone called her—anyone but Anthony. “Come. Come now. I want to feel how tight you get.”

“Ahh, God! I’m... I’m... ahh!”

It was too much. All of it. Every thick, throbbing inch. She dug her nails into his shoulders, overcome by the sudden urge to tear this man apart. For one fleeting moment, she nearly bit his ear. Instead, she just crested, her body taut and arching, arching, arching back into the bed as her world turned to fire.

And Anthony wasn’t done. He fucked her through her orgasm, pulled out, and flipped her onto all fours and entered her from behind. She’d barely recovered when he was fucking her again, turning her inside out in the best possible way.

Stephen didn’t fuck her like this. No man had ever fucked her like this. It was hard and heated, physical in a way that she wasn’t sure she was capable of with her husband. His hands were all over her ass. She felt the pressure down her spine, his fingers tangling up in her dark hair. When he tugged, just enough that she felt a lick of pain, she gasped. Stephen never pulled her hair. She never thought that she’d like it, yet she did.

“Uh!”

With Anthony, she was discovering so many new things that she never knew she liked.

“Fuck me, Anthony!” Her order spurred him on. One hand in her hair, the other clutching her hip, he rode her hard, hitting places that Stephen couldn’t. Even behind her, even out of sight, there was no doubt how *different* he was. “Yes... yes... do me harder... harder!”

Julianna was coming again. She was caught in a fever, too hot, too wet, too delirious to think straight. She wanted pleasure. She wanted carnality.

She wanted Anthony.

“Come, Anthony!” she cried. “Come!”

“Oh, Julie! Oh... you’re so... ahhh!” And he was there, with her, liquid heat flooding through her. She should have made him wear a condom. She shouldn’t have fucked him bareback like this, but oh...my...god...she was so glad that she had.

“Yes! Yes! Give it to me!”

“Take it! Take it, Julianna!”

He was a jackhammer behind her, driving into her like a statement—*I am not your husband, and I can fuck for hours.*

When they came down from the high of their mutual orgasms, Julianna crumpled forward, Anthony sliding into place behind her. He softened inside of her.

“That... was...” Her breathing was heavy, like she’d just finished a heavy lifting set. She laughed to herself. “Did we just do that?”

Anthony spooned close to her, kissing the sweaty nape of her neck. “And I hope we do it again.”

She looked over her shoulder at him, still skeptical that any of this was real. “Now I know this must be a dream. You’ve already come twice.”

He shifted enough so he could kiss her again. He fondled her tits, coaxing them back to their erect points. Incredibly, as he did so, she felt him begin to stiffen against her ass.

“Really?” she asked incredulously.

He just grinned. “What can I say? You’re an inspiration, Julianna.”

They made out some more, their slick bodies once again entwined. Kissing turned to more. She went down on him, tasting herself and not caring. The feeling of his cock hardening against her tongue was so good. She made sure to look up at him, to watch his arousal build until he was hard enough to fuck again.

“You like that cock, don’t you?”

“Mmm,” she hummed around his dick. She did. She loved it. She didn’t want to give it up. Who knew it would be this good?

“Up here, Julie,” he prompted. “As good as your mouth feels, I’d rather feel something else wrapped around me.”

They rearranged themselves. They were running out of time. Julianna knew it, but didn’t want to look at the clock. She was beyond caring about the flight. She just wanted to feel more of this man inside of her.

“Uhhh, that’s so good,” she groaned as he sank into her one last time. He was on top of her again, his toned body smothering her. He held her hands above her head and stared down at her as he drove his hips home.

Julianna spread her legs, squeezing her knees into his sides as he drove and drove and drove. “Fuck me!” she squealed. “Fuck me!”

Her ears rang with her own cries and his moans. Their skin slapped. Their lust went off like a screaming kettle. It was overload. It was so good, so much, so everything.

So loud that she didn’t hear her phone alarm. Not at first. Not until it grew shrill enough to cut over their moans. “What is that?” Anthony grunted, slowing his pace.

“I don’t—OH!” Her phone. For a moment, she thought it was her husband again, hitting the alarm, stumbling into the scene again. But no, it was her own alarm. Her flight! “My flight! I need to go!”

Neither was sure who started laughing first, but before they knew it, they were in one another’s arms, laughing as the alarm blared somewhere amidst all of their discarded clothing.

Anthony climbed off of her and recovered her phone, silencing it before handing it over. He didn’t try to convince her to stay and skip her flight. He knew the score. He also knew this wasn’t the last time they’d be getting together.

She checked her messages, surprised to see only two from her husband.

[Stephen]: Watch the time. Don't want to miss your flight. Or maybe you do and that's fine too!

[Stephen]: I ordered you an Uber just in case you lost track of time. He should be down there at 10:54.

The love she felt for her husband in that moment was profound.

[Julianna]: So thoughtful. Here's a reward.

She went over to the bed, where Anthony was watching her. Holding the camera out, she took a selfie of herself, naked, with an equally naked man behind her.

"Mind if I send this to my husband?"

"Only if you agree to see me again."

"Deal." She kissed him, sent the photo off, then started to get dressed. She didn't bother with the dress, pulling her jeans and shirt from her carry-on.

She couldn't stop smiling every time she looked his way. Pulling her shirt over her head, she went over to him on the bed. "Thank you for a wonderful time. I know it's been a long journey—"

"But it's been worth the wait," he finished for her.

They kissed again, his hand pawing at her breasts. And because of that, she reached down and groped at his still-erect cock. "Sorry to leave you like this."

"I'm sure you'll make it up to me somehow."

She smirked at him. "I have a few ideas in mind." She jerked him a few strokes before kissing him one last time.

Her phone buzzed. Stephen again.

[Stephen]: You did it? So hot! I want to know all about it, but you need to get going!

"Time to go," she said.

Anthony got up, following her to the door, still naked. "Next time you're back in town, stay the night."

The idea was thrilling. “Puts a whole new meaning into the word ‘layover.’ Bye, Anthony.”

“Goodbye, Julie.”

He pulled her against her, kissing her again. She felt his dick against her and just couldn’t resist reaching down and touching it. He was still so hard... and tempting... and she *really* needed to go...

“**Y**es! Yes, fuck me. Fuck me... Anthony!”

Stephen gasped as his own wife cried the other man’s name—*her* other man. Her bull—although she still laughed at the term. He held her hips, fucking her from behind as visions of what must have happened last night played in his mind.

“Oh, Jules!” Stephen grunted, his breathing shallow but his thrusts deep. “Say it... again...”

“I fucked another man.”

Stephen’s balls tightened.

“Oh my...” He was close. He couldn’t hold out much longer. He’d denied himself all day yesterday, and all through the night, making sure not to come. He needed to save it for this moment, and knew that if he didn’t, he could very well fall apart all over again. But now that the moment was here, he was determined to make it last. “Tell me... tell me about it, baby!”

“We... had... sex... ohhh...”

Stephen knew that his wife wasn’t very comfortable with giving details—when it came to sex, they’d never been great at communication. But he needed details now to fuel the raging fire burning him from within.

“Did you suck him?”

“Oh, yesss,” she replied with a pleased hiss that nearly undid him. He shuddered, digging his thumbs into the meat at the top of her ass cheeks.

“Was he... was he big?”

“He was, baby. Yes.”

“Oh, Jules!” His voice lifted at the end as he felt his inevitable end finally arrive. “Oh, fuck, Julianna!”

“Yes! Yes, Stephen, do it!”

She was pumping back into him, meeting his thrusts with her own. Has she done that before? Or was this a new trick that she’d learned from her lover.

Her lover.

“Uhn!”

And he was there, erupting at last inside of her, reclaiming her, just like in the books, like in the online forums, in the stories.

Stephen collapsed beside her, spent, his whole body aching. Unlike the characters in those stories, he was definitely not a young man any longer, and his hips and butt burned from the vigorous thrusting.

“Welcome home, honey,” he said, kissing her shoulder.

She turned to look at him, her smile bright with relief. “You really do get turned on by that.”

Something about the way she said it made it sound like this fantasy was still mostly his. A trickle of fear made its slow path down his spine. “Did you really see him? Or was that another story?”

Julianna’s blush filled him with relief. “No more stories. I really did see him. I really did fuck another man.”

The F word had him twitching back to life—a sixty-year-old man getting a second hardon without pharmaceutical help!

“Did you... was it...?”

“Yes. I liked it. It was so good.”

Yes, he was definitely coming back to life. He leaned in and kissed her. Lifting his brows in hope, he asked the other burning question on his mind. “Are you going to do it again?”

“If you’d asked me that a couple days ago, after the Code Red incident, I think I would have said no.”

“But I behaved last night.”

“You did, and I appreciate it.” Julianna smiled at him. “But last night was... so worth it.” She bit her lip, looking slightly embarrassed to be talking about this. “I feel like... this is going to sound silly, but I feel like Dorothy coming out of Kansas, and seeing the world in color for the first time.”

She refocused on Stephen. “Not that I thought our life was boring or black and white,” she added. “But just... there’s all this new possibility there. And you’re part of it, standing before me in vibrant technicolor.”

“Is Anthony the tin man?”

“He’s certainly built like one,” she said, surprising herself so much that she covered her mouth and laughed.

“So he’s fit?”

Now she looked a little more embarrassed. “Yeah. A lot.”

“What else happened?”

Julianna started to look uncomfortable again. She’d been like that when she’d first come in early in the morning—a little embarrassed maybe, a little cagey.

“We did it in his hotel room. He wanted me to keep my stockings and garter belt on.”

“A man who appreciates sexy things,” Stephen said, picturing her naked except for that black lace, picturing her bouncing on another man’s thick cock. “Did he wear a condom?”

Julianna glanced away, her eyes fluttering and her breath catching. “No. I’m sorry, I should have made him...” She bit her lip, glancing back up at

him.

“And did he come inside of you?”

This time, she held his gaze, but looked like she really didn't want to. “Yeah.”

“Fuck, that's hot,” he kissed her, and like that, he was so hard again, pushing her onto her back and mounting her.

“Honey, I don't think that I can... take any more sex.”

Her revelation that Anthony had fucked her without protection made Stephen's cock pulse and strain against her pussy. He felt a primal surge of desire to take his wife again, imagining Julianna filled with another man's seed, like he needed to prove that she was still his. But she wasn't just his. Not ever, and certainly not anymore. She was a hotwife now. She was free.

He took a steadying breath and nodded, respecting her wishes. “He fucked you hard?”

“It was... vigorous, yes.”

Stephen slumped down beside her, but she didn't leave him hanging. She reached down and wrapped her hand around his shaft, starting to pump. “But it wasn't just that pace,” she whispered. “It was his stamina.” She started jerking Stephen faster. “Like, God, I thought there was no way he'd be able to maintain that tempo, you know, but he was like a machine.”

There was a wistfulness in her voice that was triggering for Stephen—triggering in all of the best ways. She was changed. *They* were changed. This wasn't the end of this adventure. It was the prelude.

“Oh, Julianna...” He groaned.

She beat him off faster, refocusing on him. “I lost count of how many times he made me come,” she whispered. “He... he knew what he was doing...”

“Tell me,” Stephen said, his voice tight. “Tell me how much... you liked... it.”

“I didn’t just like it.” Her hand was a blur on his shaft. “I loved it, Stephen. I never thought I’d feel something like that again. The newness. The sense of exploring.”

“Uhhnn, Jules...”

She leaned in close, her breath hot against his ear. “And now I know I’ll feel it again.” Her hand tightened on his cock. “And again.” Faster and faster. “And again.”

Stephen exploded on her wrist, his chest and back lifting off of the bed as he experienced a full body orgasm. He saw stars. He saw the future, and the future was wildly bright.

ANTHONY: *I was wondering if you’d reach out.*

Stephen’s stomach churned as he read the text. His shaved scalp prickled. When he ran his fingers across the smooth skin, his hand came away damp. He’d sent a message to the man three days ago, and had felt like it was a mistake at the time. When Anthony didn’t respond, he felt relief. The man must have written him off, which was for the better. Only now, he’d returned, and with that, all of Stephen’s anxiety.

He wasn’t doing this behind Julianna’s back, though. She’d actually told him to do it when it became clear how uncomfortable she was giving out explicit details.

“Ask Anthony. I’m sure he’d love to share with you,” she’d said.

“I thought you didn’t like the back channel.”

“Just don’t tell me about it. And don’t conspire.”

So he had, and it felt like walking into a cage with a sleeping lion and clearing his throat.

STEPHEN: *Ana said it was okay.*

ANTHONY: *Oh, I know. She told me you might.*

The reminder that these two were still talking sent a quake of excitement through him.

ANTHONY: *You want details?*

S: *Yes please.*

A: *Your wife sure loves to fuck.*

Oh, God. Those were words that Stephen never dreamed he'd read from another man, not even in his deepest fantasies.

S: *How do you know? Did she say that?*

A: *She said she loved my cock.*

S: *She did?!*

A: *Oh yeah. Couldn't get enough of it. If her alarm hadn't gone off, I think she would have ridden me all night long.*

Stephen's pulse was pounding. His dick so hard.

S: *I told her she could get a flight in the morning.*

A: *Next time then.*

Next time. Next time. Yes, next time.

STEPHEN: *So was the goodbye kiss passionate?*

ANTHONY: *Yes. She sucked my cock goodbye.*

Stephen nearly came in his pants as he read it.

STEPHEN: *No way!*

ANTHONY: *Oh yes.*

STEPHEN: *Literally? Some more details, please.*

A: *You're in it deep, aren't you? Sure, let's see...*

ANTHONY: *As she was leaving I gave her a kiss goodbye. I was still naked, and still hard. She felt it against her, stroked it some. Then got on her knees and just sucked me off. Swallowed and all. Then left*

ANTHONY: *Told you, she really enjoyed my cock*

STEPHEN: *So....you were still in the room, she was dressed and leaving. After a kiss, she leaned over and sucked on your cock as a goodbye?*

ANTHONY: *Exactly*

STEPHEN: *That's so hot*

Julianna came in from the store, saw him sitting alone in the living room on his phone, and seemed to know exactly what was going on.

“Anthony?” she asked.

Stephen nodded. Looking up at Julianna in her tight jeans and short, denim jacket, all he could imagine was her kneeling down and sucking Anthony’s cock again.

“You’re incredible,” he said. “So amazing.”

“I love that it turns you on,” she said, putting her purse down and crossing over to him. She curled up beside him, kissing him on the neck and whispering into his ear, “It’s what makes any of this work.”

His phone rumbled.

ANTHONY: *You have one hell of a hotwife*

Stephen showed the text to Julianna, who laughed. “Can’t wait to do it again.”

A COUPLE WEEKS had passed since the second layover—a solid month for Julianna to consider what she’d done, the vows that she’d broken, the social norms that she’d trampled. The guilt that she’d worried about never arrived. The regret just wasn’t there.

A large part of that was the man on the sofa on his phone. She climbed into his lap and kissed him. He was hard. She wondered what Anthony had just told him, then decided that she didn’t want to actually know.

Stephen had opened the door for her, and was always there, smiling and waving when she looked back.

When she thought about her time with Anthony and how he made her feel, she didn’t feel *young* again, exactly. She felt... ageless. She felt free to

have fun, the way she had when she was a girl and the weight of expectation hadn't descended yet.

"I've got a trip coming up in a few months to Boise" she said as she wrapped her arms around her husband.

"Have you looked into flights?" He sounded so measured, so restrained.

"I have. No direct flights."

"That's a real shame," he said. They couldn't help smiling at each other.

"And the layovers look quite... long."

Stephen groaned.

"I may even need to spend the night." She giggled as she felt him shudder beneath her.

Stephen pulled her in for a long kiss. When they parted, he grinned up at her. "Who knew layovers could be so much fun?"

ABOUT KENNY WRIGHT

Kenny has been publishing hotwife erotica for over ten years (and writing for much longer than that). He writes what he likes to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. He believes in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

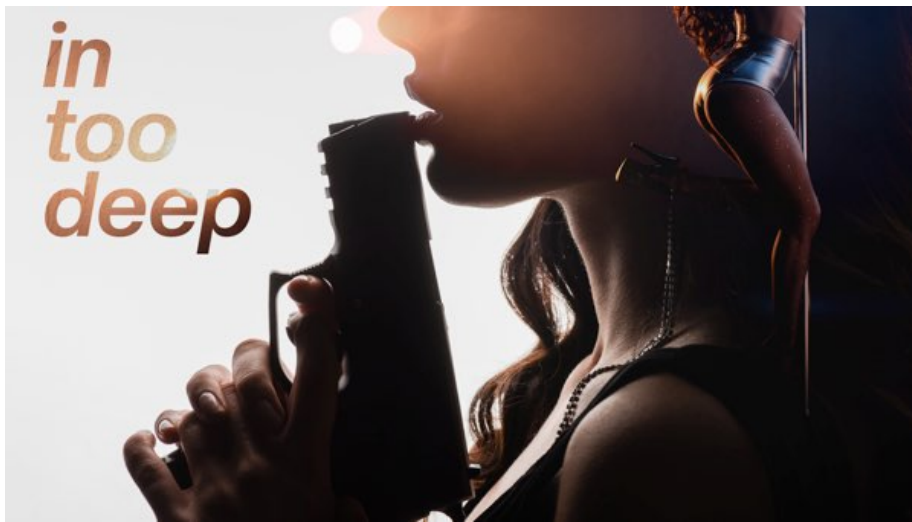
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In Too Deep



David hasn't seen his wife, Amanda, in two months—not since she went undercover on a dangerous, highly secretive case. He doesn't know where she is, what she's doing, or who she's pretending to be. He only knows he misses her—her laugh, her touch, her kiss.

Then one night, David finds himself in a strip club... and finds her on stage.

Seeing Amanda like this—seductive, confident, and far more uninhibited than he ever imagined—awakens a cocktail of emotions: confusion, desire, jealousy... and a craving for more. And then suddenly he's dragged into Amanda's dark and thrilling new world, where every move could shatter her cover—and their marriage.

Can they survive the lies, the danger, and the temptation? Or has Amanda already crossed a line that neither of them can undo?

Packed with explicit, pulse-pounding passion, intrigue, and a unique take on not just the hotwife genre, but the mystery-thriller genre, this is one story you won't forget.

***In Too Deep* is a two-part book series available [everywhere that you purchase your ebooks](#).**

Castaway Wife: A Survival Game of Passion



Reality Television Meets Fantasy Hotwife

Have you ever wondered what it's like to be the husband to a beautiful woman on a reality television show? Millions obsessing over her. Guys on the show hitting on her. No way to interact. All you can do is watch. All you can do is hope that in the end, she comes back home.

Andy certainly never considered any of that when he encouraged his wife, Chelsea, to live her dream as a contestant on Castaway. The six weeks of separation that followed were hard enough. The months that followed were even more difficult. She wasn't allowed to talk about the show, but as each episode unfolded and he saw how close she got with Todd, a fireman from LA, he began to wonder how much was editing and how much was real.

Everything comes to a head as the final episode of the season airs before a live audience. The winner is crowned. The contestants reunite. And Andy learns just how much the spotlight has changed his wife.

[Find Castaway Wife at any major online retailers.](#)

Everyone's a Winner



Who says a couple can't have new adventures after two decades of marriage?

When Lauren heads to Las Vegas alone, Eric encourages her to explore their hotwife fantasies. What ends up happening is a series of experiences that cross lines that Lauren never thought she would, and leave Eric wondering who he married and how he got so lucky.

Follow Lauren and Eric's journey, and find out just how everyone wins.

[Find Everyone's a Winner online.](#)

The Blonde in 3C



From neighbor to friend to wife to... hotwife?

Cooper always had a crush on Annika, the blonde in apartment 3C. She was friendly. She was pretty. Best of all, she had loud sex with her boyfriend, Brett, that Cooper could hear through the floorboards. He never thought that one day, he would marry that sexy blonde.

But first impressions are hard to shake, and Cooper's first impression of his future bride was of an insatiable woman he could never fully satisfy. He was always waiting for the other shoe to drop, for a new man to take his place, for him to lose it all. A hotwife fantasy was born and it grew with their marriage.

The things that Annika did for love always surprised her, but that was just who she was. She gave all of her energy to a relationship. She'd done some wild things for her hedonistic former boyfriend, Brett. She was still trying to figure out Cooper.

When they attend Brett's wedding, Annika and Cooper are put to the test. Will Annika be tempted by the past? Will Cooper's repressed fantasy explode into the open?

[Find The Blonde in 3C online!](#)

Bull's Eye Series (5 books)



Paul Sharpe, self-avowed bachelor, works hard and plays harder—always looking for a new conquest. Blondes, brunettes, redheads, he enjoys them all as long as the pursuit is fun and they're up for a good time. He's fine being disposable. Life is simpler that way.

Until he meets a woman who opens his eyes to a whole new world—the world of hotwives and cuckolds and the games that they play. After that, he sees it everywhere. At bars, at clubs, at his company's gala, he sees men furtively watching other men hit on their wives.

Can he be the other man? Can he be the bull?

Follow Paul's epic journey over five books as he evolves from the bull to so much more.

[Bull's Eye 1: Discovering the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 2: Exploring the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 3: Enjoying the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 4: Consequences of a Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 5: Beyond the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

Training to Love It Series (3 books)



Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time he thinks of Erin with

AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

Training to Love It series